

Second Level Spells

Calculation of the Evoked Servitor	Summon a magical familiar that can't fight, but obeys all other orders
Casting Forth the Inner Eye	Scry a distant location through a luminous or reflective surface
Conjunction of the Inexorable Step	Teleport a creature or loose object to a visible non-dangerous place
Decree of Lithic Dissolution	Destroy all non-magic stone, earth or non-metal minerals in an area
Extirpate Arcana	Dispel magic in a twenty-foot radius on the target point
The Inexorable Imputation	Make a statement; listeners believe it unless impossible or abhorrent
Jade Palanquin of the Faceless God	Summon a floating palanquin that can bear heavy burdens
Mantle of Disjecting Dissection	A willing target is mantled in blades, harming those who get close
Prudentially Transient Abnegation of Life	A willing target at zero hit points appears to die, but later revives
Resounding Temporal Echo	Give targets an extra Main Action for a short time for System Strain
The Verdant Vallation	Create a solid wall of plant life; it persists if planted in good earth
Visitation of the Clement Clime	You and three allies/level become immune to natural heat or cold

Third Level Spells

Adopt the Simulacral Visage	Transform a target into a chosen humanoid shape until the next dawn
Conjunct the Vital Viscera	Merge living creatures to share hit points or body parts
Exhalation of Congelating Cold	Freeze a target area, doing 1d6 dmg/two caster levels, with save
Foresightful Apprehension	Divine the most likely outcome of an action in the next five minutes
Glass Chimes of the Bamboo Terrace	Summon chimes for long-distance messages or 3d6 area damage
The Howl of Light	Cause an explosion doing 1d8 dmg/level in a large area, with save
Phobic Storm	Terrify foes within forty feet, forcing Morale checks and damage
Scorn the Fetters of Earth	You and an ally per level can briefly move through the air
The Torment of Tumefaction	Curse a foe with hideous disfigurements that hurt them if they act
Touch of Elucidating Intangibility	Touch a barrier to see through it or make it briefly intangible
Vallation of Specified Exclusion	Draw a line that bars targets of a particular obvious type or kind

Fourth Level Spells

Calculation of the Phantasmal Eidolon	Summon an obedient magical servitor that can fight for the caster
Contingent Excision of Arcana	Cast the spell to later dispel magic as an Instant action once
Disjunctive Temporal Reversion	The target can redo their current round's actions; can cast Instantly
Evert the Inwardness	Summon contents from a container or viscera from a living creature
The Grinding Geas	Bind a target to obey a command or suffer a terminal disease
Obnubilation of the Will	A helpless target is made an intelligent slave to the caster's will
Ochre Sigil of Juxtaposition	Swap targets between a current place and a distant prepared one
Pierce the Pallid Gate	Create a short-ranged gate between two near known locations
Sigil of Aeolian Auctoritas	Create a blast of air or control weather in the nearby area

Fifth Level Spells

Abdication of Temporal Presence	Stop time for 1d4+1 rounds, though you can't affect the world
Banishment to the Black Glass Labyrinth	Exile targets to an extradimensional prison-maze for a time
The Dazzling Prismatic Hemicycle	Blast targets in a 100 foot cone to inflict random gruesome effects
Deluge of Hell	Do 1d8 dmg/level in a huge area, but risk taking a quarter of it
The Earth as Clay	Mold and shape natural stone and earth in a very large area
Invocation of the Invincible Citadel	Create a force-shield bubble as an Instant action
Open the High Road	Create a temporary gate to a prepared distant target point



HIGH MAGES

A High Mage is the product more of a philosophical tendency than a specific magical tradition. There are countless magical orders that embrace the principles of this path, whether they are the austere master-and-pupil instructors of the Eightfold Lineage, the formal magical schools of the Sodality of Wisdom, the unstructured teachings of hermit-sorcerers to their apprentices, or a host of other organizations named and unnamed across Latter Earth.

High Mages are united not by an organization, but by the belief that true power and enlightenment lies in the High Magic of the ancients, and that a wizard of sense will direct their efforts towards unearthing, understanding, and mastering these lost arts. New Magic is a waste of valuable time and effort, a mere fumbling with ill-understood tricks when a mage ought to be spending their labors in better-comprehending the deeper principles behind the magic of old.

High Mages are skilled at the production of magical Workings and the development of arcane devices and standing enchantments, but they rarely ever attempt to devise New Magic. Instead, they work to unearth lost spells of High Magic and expand their own grimoires with more of these potent sorceries.

To this end they have developed numerous arts that help them control and focus the powers of High Magic. Experienced High Mages can mold and adjust their spells in ways that other wizards cannot hope to achieve, and they are exceptionally skilled at resisting, undoing, and discerning the magics of others.

Because of this aptitude it is common for High Mages to be credited as the “orthodox” magical practitioners of many nations, with their way of doing things taken as the generally correct way for a wizard to conduct their business. Some High Mage organizations push this even further, using their influence to outlaw or suppress rival traditions in their pursuit of arcane lore.

High Mage PCs may choose to have been taught by a lone practitioner of the tradition, or they may decide to be part of some larger organization of mages that exists in the campaign world, either as a newly-released apprentice or a less-successful student who seeks a new path.

If the GM doesn't have any particular magical lineages in mind for their campaign setting, the player should feel free to make up their own and credit their PC as a newly-graduated initiate in the occult arts. Provided the GM thinks the player's creation is reasonable and appropriate for the setting, it can be added in as another element to the campaign.

HIGH MAGE BENEFITS

All High Mages gain Magic as a bonus skill, acquiring it at level-0, or level-1 if was already level-0. Every High Mage is well-educated in the principles of magic as understood by the sorcerers of Latter Earth.

High Mages can prepare and cast High Magic spells, and have a number of arts dedicated to improving their use of these incantations. As usual for spellcasters, they cannot wear bulky clothing or armor while casting or using arts, nor use shields. Mages who have trained to overcome these limits with the *Armored Magic* Focus have more latitude.

High Mages conduct extensive experimentation and study as part of their daily activities. This relentless focus helps them master High Magic spells without needing the outside help of tutors and discovered texts. Each time they advance a level, they may pick two High Magic spells from the list in this book to add to their repertoire. These spells must be of a level they can cast.

High Mages also gain arts specific to their tradition. At first level, a full High Mage picks two arts and a partial picks one. As they gain levels and experience, they'll learn additional arts from the adjacent list. Once picked, an art cannot be changed.

Full High Mage

Level	Max Level	Spells Cast	Spells Prepared	Arts Gained
1	1	1	3	Any Two
2	1	1	3	Any One
3	2	2	4	
4	2	2	5	Any One
5	3	3	6	
6	3	3	7	Any One
7	4	4	8	
8	4	4	9	Any One
9	5	5	10	
10	5	6	12	Any One

Partial High Mage

Level	Max Level	Spells Cast	Spells Prepared	Arts Gained
1	1	1	2	Any One
2	1	1	3	Any One
3	1	1	3	Any One
4	1	2	4	
5	2	2	5	
6	2	3	6	Any One
7	2	3	7	
8	2	3	7	
9	3	4	8	Any One
10	3	4	9	

ARTS OF THE HIGH MAGES

High Mage Effort is calculated as usual, with each PC's maximum being equal to one plus their Magic skill level plus the better of their Intelligence or Charisma modifiers. Partial High Mages have a score one point lower than this, albeit not less than one.

Arcane Lexicon: Commit Effort for the scene. For the rest of the scene, you can read any script that was not intentionally obfuscated or encoded by its writer. Extremely esoteric or nonhuman scripts may not be comprehensible this way; the “plain meaning” of the text might be utterly foreign to human logic.

Counter Magic: Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action when a visible enemy mage casts a spell. Both of you make opposed Int/Magic or Cha/Magic skill checks; if you win, their spell fizzles and is wasted. This art only works on actual spellcasters and not creatures that merely activate magical powers. You can use this art no more than once per round.

Empowered Sorcery: Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action to re-roll any variable die roll associated with a spell's effects, such as a damage roll; take the roll you prefer.

Hang Sorcery: Commit Effort for the scene as an Instant action when casting a spell. The spell does not go off, but remains “hung” and waiting to be triggered as an On Turn action, with details of targeting and effect determined at that time. Damage does not disrupt a hung spell, but no additional spells can be cast until the hung spell is released or allowed to dissipate.

Inexorable Effect: Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action to force an enemy to re-roll a successful saving throw and take the worse result. You may use this art only once per scene.

Iron Resolution: Commit Effort for the day when injured or disturbed in combat; you may make a Physical saving throw to resist spell disruption and ignore the damage for purposes of spellcasting.

Preparatory Countermagic: Commit Effort for the scene when you are affected by a spell you have prepared, including when you are standing in the area of effect of one of your own damaging spells. You are unaffected by the spell's direct effects.

Psychic Conversion: Once per day as an On Turn action, expend one casting slot to remove one point of accrued System Strain and heal 2 hit points per level.

Restrained Casting: Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action when casting a High Magic spell. You may do so in perfect silence and without need for somatic gestures, though damage will still disrupt the casting.

Retain Sorcery: Commit Effort for the day as an On Turn action after casting a spell; it does not count against your casting limits for the day. You can use this art no more than once per day, and the stress of using it prevents you from casting another spell before the end of your next turn.

Sense Magic: Commit Effort as an Instant action; while it remains committed, you can visually perceive magical energy and get a one-sentence description of the effect of any standing magics or magical items you inspect. The ambient magical energies in most areas allow you to see clearly even in conditions of perfect darkness.

Suppress Magic: Commit Effort for the day as an On Turn action and target a visible or known magical effect within one hundred feet. The effect is suppressed as if by the *Extirpate Arcana* spell for 1d6 rounds plus the caster's character level. Spells cast by more powerful casters may not be successfully suppressed, as noted in the spell description. The caster can attempt to suppress an effect only once.

Swift Casting: Once per scene, you may Commit Effort for the day to turn a spell that normally requires a Main Action to cast into an On Turn action. You can cast no other spell this round and you can't use this art if you've already cast a spell this round or been injured or otherwise disqualified from casting.

Ward Allies: Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action to omit up to six allies from the effects of an area-effect spell you cast, allowing them to avoid any damage or other negative effect that would be directly produced by the spell. This does not protect them from indirect consequences, however, such as destroying the building they are standing in.

Wizard's Grandeur: Commit Effort as an On Turn action. As long as it remains Committed, you will not become dirty, sweaty, stained, or rumpled regardless of the circumstances. Noxious substances will slide off you without staining and you will remain comfortable regardless of your attire in any normal climate. You may sleep comfortably without shelter or bedding as per the privation rules on page 51.

HIGH MAGES IN OTHER WORLDS

The High Mage is a default baseline magic-user in most campaign settings, easily reflavored as the most traditional sort of wizard in a world. While they lack the specialized talents of more conceptually-focused wizards, they have arts that help them excel at using conventional magic.

High Mages have arts almost exclusively limited to manipulating spells and the energies of spellcasting. If you use them for settings where the “average wizard” is defined by a broader scope of abilities, you may wish to add some extra art options. For example, if wizards in this setting are all generally able to hurl bolts of magical force, then you might add that as an art.

Be careful not to step on the concepts of more focused wizards, however, by giving your default casters too broad a range of toys. Specialists should always have a sphere of effects only they can use.



SPELLS OF THE HIGH MAGES

Abdication of Temporal Presence Level 5

The caster and up to one visible ally per caster level briefly step outside of the conventional flow of time, the rest of the world freezing around them. These subjects can take $1d4+1$ free rounds of actions, but they cannot physically affect the world or move any object they were not carrying at the time they cast the spell. Any spells the caster or other allies cast can affect only their own group, and not those entities still in the normal flow of time.

Adopt the Simulacral Visage Level 3

A brief incantation transforms one visible, willing target per caster level into a perfect simulacrum of any humanoid creature the caster has seen before, whether a specific individual or a general type. No special abilities are granted by this transformation, but the target will perfectly resemble a chosen individual, including in voice and scent. Their non-magical clothing will transform to whatever clothing is appropriate to the target, and they will gain an intuitive ability to speak and understand the target's native tongue. The spell lasts until dawn of the day after casting it, whereupon the targets and any transformed clothing revert back to their original seeming.

Apprehending the Arcane Form Level 1

The mage opens up their mind to the presence of occult energies. For fifteen minutes per character level, they are capable of seeing active magical effects, curses, enchantments, or other dweomers as colored auras or patterns of light. They may identify magical items and get a one-sentence description of their purpose or most significant powers, and may get more sophisticated answers with successful Wis/Magic skill checks at difficulties of 8 or more depending on the subtlety of the enchantment. Mages with prepared spells are visible to the caster, though which spells the subject might have prepared is not knowable. As a side effect of this spell, the ambient thaumic currents cast enough quasi-light to allow the caster to see normally even in perfect darkness.

Banishment to the Black Glass Labyrinth Level 5

Aimed at a visible point within three hundred feet, the spell affects all creatures except the caster within a ten-foot radius of the target, translating them into a lightless extradimensional maze of endlessly tall obsidian walls. The maze is infinite, featureless, and empty. Transported creatures get a Mental saving throw to end the spell, re-appearing one round after it was cast. Those who fail their save get to make an additional attempt once an hour afterwards. Creatures with five or fewer hit dice cannot

attempt these saving throws and are trapped forever unless the mage is killed or ends the spell. Time passes normally while trapped, and creatures snared within may rest, fight, or starve as their situation and wills so recommends. Dead or escaped creatures appear in the nearest clear space to their original departure.

Calculation of the Evoked Servitor Level 2

This spell conjures up an intelligent familiar for the caster, one with one hit point per caster level, an AC of 14, a ground movement rate of 30' per action, saving throws the same as the caster, a +0 skill modifier, and no effective attack. The familiar always adopts the same shape for the same caster, though the initial casting can set this to any shape the caster wishes provided it's no larger than a small human. The familiar retains a telepathic connection with its creator and will obey any command it is given, including suicidal ones. It can perform any action that a competent human servant could. If the familiar is slain, it fades away, but can be called forth again by the spell. The familiar retains its memories of what happens while it's summoned, and can develop its own personality in time. The familiar remains in existence until dawn following the spell's casting or until dismissed by the caster.

Calculation of the Phantasmal Eidolon Level 4

The caster conjures up a semi-real phantasmal creature in any shape or appearance they desire, provided it is no larger than an ox. The servitor is as intelligent as a human and will obey the caster with fearless and suicidal devotion, having 4 effective hit dice, 20 hit points, AC 15, a movement rate of 30' per action, a +1 skill modifier, saves of 13+, and a +6/1d8 damage melee attack with 2/AC 15 Shock. As the creature is partly phantasmal, the damage it inflicts cannot kill a subject, but only knock them unconscious for an hour before they awaken with 1 hit point. The caster may pick one special quality for the creature when it is summoned: the ability to fly at a rate of 30'/move, the perfect duplication of a particular person they've seen, the ability to form a telepathic speech connection with the caster, or the ability to effectively use normal weaponry and armor. The servitor lasts until destroyed or the dawn after the spell is cast.

Casting Forth the Inner Eye Level 2

A pool of water, mirror, open flame, polished crystal, or other luminous or reflective surface is used to peer at a distant location. The location must either be within one hundred feet per caster level or be a location the caster has physically occupied before. The caster perceives the location as if he were standing at the targeted point with-

in it, seeing and hearing events there as if he were present. This spell cannot scry locations that have been magically warded, and scrying the same location repeatedly is hindered by the resonance created by the spell. The spell cannot perceive the same area twice within the same week, or position its target point so as to overlap a prior area with its perceptions within that time. If a target present in the area has more hit dice than the caster has levels, they get a Mental saving throw to get an uncanny sense of being watched, something that will alert those cognizant of this spell. This spell lasts until the caster performs some action other than focusing on the scrying.

Cognitive Supersession of the Inferior Orders

Level 1

The mage targets a visible, normal, non-magical animal or insect, obtaining temporary control of the beast and the ability to share its senses. The animal gains a telepathic bond with the caster, obeying any non-suicidal command and allowing the mage to perceive everything it perceives. The beast will not fight for the caster, but can perform complex actions entirely out of character for it while under the mage's control. The mage must focus to share the beast's senses, requiring a Main Action and leaving the mage unable to act physically while so focused. The spell lasts until the mage releases the beast, it is dispelled, or it is cast again.

Conjunct the Vital Viscera

Level 3

The caster renders the forms and life energy of up to one visible subject per caster level into something plastic and transferable. Hit points, poisons, and diseases can be transferred from one creature to another, if both are willing or helplessly bound, healing up to the maximum allowed hit points of the target creature. Body parts can be exchanged or gifted so long as each subject retains at least half of their original corpus. A willing target can even be absorbed into the body of another subject of the spell, disappearing into them until the spell ends or they choose to spring back out, fully-equipped. Assimilated subjects can continue to see and hear what goes on outside their carrier. A given subject can absorb up to five other human-sized targets. The spell lasts until dispelled, released, or one hour per caster level has passed, though transferred hit points or afflictions do not return to their original subject. If a subject is killed while "borrowing" another's body parts, those parts do not return.

Conjunction of the Inexorable Step

Level 2

A visible target within a hundred feet is immediately teleported to any visible, solid resting point within a half-mile, provided the target point has enough room to accept them and it is not a position of imminent physical peril. Unattended objects can be translocated by the spell, but they can be no larger than a horse. Unwilling

creatures targeted by this spell may make a Mental saving throw to resist; on a success, it is the caster who is transported to the intended destination instead.

Contingent Excision of Arcana

Level 4

The caster sets up a triggered resonance of dispelling magic which may later be invoked as an Instant action. Until the next dawn, the mage may negate magic as if with an *Extirpate Arcana* spell as an Instant action. Once this negation is triggered, the spell ends.

The Coruscating Coffin

Level 1

A thaumic discharge is focused on a single visible creature within one hundred feet per caster level, wreathing them in a lethal mantle of crackling energy. The target suffers 1d8 damage per caster level, with a Physical save for half. NPC targets with only 1 hit die will inevitably be slain regardless of the damage done. The spell cannot be blocked by non-magical intervening barriers, provided the caster can see the target with their unaided vision.

Damnation of the Sense

Level 1

The caster targets a visible creature within two hundred feet. The target gets a Mental saving throw to resist; on a failure, one sense of the caster's choice is entirely under the caster's control for the rest of the scene, while a success leaves them bound only for the next round. Any false impression may be given, or any true one concealed, and a creature may be left effectively blinded or deafened. Distracting tactile sensations can force the victim to make a Physical saving throw in order to act each round. Blinded creatures can't make ranged attacks and roll all melee hit rolls twice, taking the worst result. If a creature thinks itself in mortal peril its excitement allows it to make a Mental save to throw off the spell at the end of each round.

The Dazzling Prismatic Hemicycle

Level 5

A blinding fan of impossible colors cascades over all targets in front of the caster in an area equal to a cone a hundred feet long and a hundred feet wide at the end. Each creature within that area must make a Physical saving throw; those who fail roll 1d6. On a 1, they are unharmed, on a 2 they collapse into a handful of dust, on a 3 they fall unconscious for an hour, on a 4 they go violently insane for the next hour and attack all around them, on a 5 they turn to stone, and on a 6 they become utterly enthralled to the caster's commands for the next hour, as if under the effect of an *Ineluctable Shackles of Volition* spell.



Decree of Ligneous Dissolution Level 1

Wood, linen, cotton, rope, and other plant- or fungus-derived matter is annihilated by a wave of entropic force that washes through an area near the caster. The mage targets a point within one hundred feet per caster level and designates a number of contiguous 10-foot cubes within that area equal to or less than their caster level. All non-magical plant matter within that area immediately erodes away to dust. Enchanted objects of plant matter cannot be affected, but ordinary plant-based clothing, bows, or wooden-hafted weapons will be destroyed. If used against plant-based monsters, the spell does 1d10 damage per caster level, with a Physical save for half.

Decree of Lithic Dissolution Level 2

Stone, earth, sod, sand, or other largely mineral material is reduced to a faint spray of fine dust by this sorcery, though metal and enchanted objects are unaffected. The caster nominates up to one contiguous 10-foot cube per caster level in a visible area within one hundred feet per caster level, causing all such stone or mineral material within the cubes to disappear. Such rapid destruction may well cause larger structures to collapse as well. If used against rock-based monsters, the spell does 1d10 damage per caster level, with a Physical save for half.

Deluge of Hell Level 5

The caster unleashes a consuming destruction on a visible point within three thousand feet. A torrent of eldritch ruin rains down from the heavens on everything within up to a two hundred foot radius per caster level, inflicting 1d8 damage per caster level with a Physical save for half damage, and automatically killing all targets with 4 or fewer hit dice. This damage is sufficient to destroy any wooden or lightly-built stone structure and will seriously damage even fortifications. The caster can tighten the radius down to a minimum of 20 feet, but cannot be selective about targets within that area. This spell cannot be cast indoors, and is extremely hazardous to the caster; they must make a Mental saving throw on casting it or suffer a quarter of the damage inflicted, rounded up.

Disjunctive Temporal Reversion Level 4

The caster may invoke this spell as an Instant action on any single creature within one hundred feet. Time is rolled back slightly, allowing them to replay their current round of action as if it never occurred, though all involved retain a memory of what originally happened. This spell is only useful on targets that are currently taking their round's actions; once they've finished for the round and another creature has started acting, it is too late to benefit from this spell. If the target is unwilling to roll back their action, they may make a Mental saving throw to resist the spell.

The Earth as Clay Level 5

The caster molds the soil and stone of the land around them, raising hills, digging trenches, or forming simple structures out of extruded bedrock. Once cast, the mage may psychically mold the terrain within three hundred feet per caster level, shifting it slowly over the course of an hour to form whatever shape they desire out of it, provided the material used can actually maintain such a shape. Simple buildings and walls may be created out of bedrock or available stone, and tunnels and caves may be shaped up to 50 feet down from the caster, while hills may be raised up to 200 feet above the prevailing grade. This spell cannot work within a thousand feet of stone or earth that has been significantly worked by intelligent creatures, though the use of this spell by the same caster doesn't count as working the earth on further castings.

Evert the Inwardness Level 4

A single visible target is selected, whereupon whatever contents that target may possess are extracted and placed in the caster's hands. If used on a cabinet, backpack, pocket, or other such container it can be no larger than an armoire, and the caster can choose whether or not to receive any particular object from inside it, being instantly appraised of its contents when the spell is cast. If used on a creature, it attempts to tear out the subject's innards; if the subject has equal or fewer hit dice than the caster, it must make a Physical save or die instantly. Whether or not it perishes, it suffers 1d10 damage per caster level, with a Physical save for half.

The Excellent Transpicuous Transformation Level 1

The mage chooses up to one visible willing target per caster level provided they are within 100 feet, though afterwards the targets can separate freely. The targets and all they wear or carry become perfectly transparent. Missile attacks against invisible foes are largely impossible, and melee attacks against them usually suffer a -4 penalty to hit rolls. The spell lasts for up to an hour per caster level, but it breaks if a subject performs some violent motion, such as running, attacking, or casting a spell. Once broken for one subject, it breaks for all.

Exhalation of Congelating Cold Level 3

The caster invokes a gust of deepest winter on a point within one hundred feet per level, freezing everything in a radius up to ten feet per caster level. All liquids freeze solid down to a depth of two feet and all living creatures not impervious to arctic cold must suffer 1d6 damage per two levels of the caster, with a Physical save for half damage. Those who fail their Physical saves are numbed by the cold and lose their Move action each round for the next 1d4 rounds. The frozen area warms again at the usual rate for the surrounding environment.

Extirpate Arcana Level 2

The caster sweeps away all unwanted magical effects and enchantments within a twenty-foot radius, centered on any visible point within one hundred feet per level. If the magical effect was cast by a creature with equal or fewer hit dice or levels, the effect is negated automatically. Otherwise, a contested Int/Magic or Cha/Magic skill roll must be made, with higher-leveled caster gaining a +2 bonus on their roll and the dispeller winning any ties. This spell is not strong enough to permanently suppress standing magical effects, and requires the aforementioned contested roll to have any chance to even temporarily suppressing them. If successful, the effect is negated for 1d6 rounds. If cast on a very large enchantment, only the portion within the spell's zone of effect is suppressed.

Foresightful Apprehension Level 3

The caster probes the near currents of fate to discern the likely immediate outcome of an action. The caster describes a particular action they or a comrade intend to presently undertake, whereupon the GM tells them what is most likely to happen in consequence within the first five minutes after the action, as the GM thinks it most probable. This spell cannot be used more than once a week on the same general topic.

The Glass Chimes of the Bamboo Terrace Level 3

This spell calls forth a floating set of colored glass chimes. The caster alone may strike them, producing sounds of great subtlety and penetration. The caster may allow anyone in the desired range to hear the music, or may make it inaudible to anyone save specific targets within range. Such is the expressiveness of the chimes that those who hear them may instantly understand the caster's desired message, however abstract. If the caster strikes the chimes violently as a Main Action, they may shatter them, causing a deafening clamor that does 3d6 damage to all non-deaf targets within forty feet except for the caster. The maximum range of the chimes is ten miles per caster level, and they persist until shattered or the scene ends.

The Grinding Geas Level 4

A single visible living creature is struck with a grim geas, forcing it to comply with a particular command or else suffer a progressively-worse affliction. The caster may lay one single-sentence command on the target that is neither suicidal, indefinitely imprecise, nor likely physically impossible for them to comply with. Thus, the caster could geas a man to kill his son or never seek to harm his lord, but he could not reasonably command a peasant to become king or bind someone to forever after comply with a master's arbitrary commands. If the target then defies that geas or unreasonably delays its execution, they suffer an agonizing progressive wasting disease that will inevitably kill them in 1d6 weeks, applying -2 to their hit rolls and -1 to skill checks for each week that passes and halving their maximum hit points. If they again begin complying with the geas afterwards or if the curse is lifted, the disease halts and reverses itself at the same rate it progressed. An active target can make a Mental save to resist this spell, but they cannot if they are restrained, unconscious, or otherwise subdued. The curse lasts until dispelled or the caster lifts it.

The Howl of Light Level 3

A flattened disc of tremendous heat, sound, and shock is triggered at a visible point within fifty feet per caster level, erupting in a twenty-foot radius eight feet in height. Everything within the area suffers 1d8 damage from flame, concussion, and sonic shock per caster level, with an Evasion save for half. If used in a space less than 40 feet in width, the explosion is channeled through adjacent spaces and passages for an additional 1d6 x 10 feet.

Imperceptible Cerebral Divulgence Level 1

The mage focuses on a visible living creature within 100 feet per caster level. For the rest of the scene, they immediately receive an impression of the target's surface thoughts and interests, understanding them regardless of any lack of a shared language. The caster may ask one question of the target's memories per caster level, but doing so risks breaking the spell; the target can make a Mental save before answering each question and the spell ends if the save is successful. These questions can only query memories, not compel any exercise of judgment or extrapolation. This spell is very subtle in its casting, and can be invoked without any visible gestures or audible incantations.

Ineluctable Shackles of Volition Level 1

The mage targets a visible living creature within 100 feet. The subject must immediately make a Mental saving throw at a penalty equal to the caster's Magic skill or become enthralled to the caster's will. Such victims will obey any physical commands issued by the caster, bar-



ring ones that seem suicidal or patently meant to result in their murder. The caster cannot order the creature to answer questions or perform acts that require independent judgment, nor to use non-physical abilities or spells, but it will fight for the caster or to defend its own life. Enchanted victims appear torpid and dazed, and will act only to defend themselves or satisfy their needs. The spell lasts until dispelled, or until the caster dies or releases them. Every time this spell is cast, however, all prior subjects get an immediate unmodified Mental saving throw to throw it off. If the creature has more hit dice than the caster, it gets an unmodified saving throw to end the effect the first time each day it's ordered to do something it finds strongly objectionable.

The Inexorable Imputation

Level 2

The caster makes a single one-sentence statement as part of casting this spell, a process which is subtle enough to appear as no more than ordinary conversation. All who hear the caster speak within a forty-foot radius must make a Mental saving throw or come to immediately believe the statement is true unless it seems physically impossible to them or it is emotionally intolerable to believe. The listeners must be able to understand the caster's language, and the caster may exempt up to two targets per caster level from this delusion when casting the spell, so as to avoid beguiling their companions. The spell's effects linger for one hour per caster level, after which the believers will be no more persuaded of the fact than events or their own common sense would allow.

Invocation of the Invincible Citadel

Level 5

The caster hurls up a magical shield that is impervious to almost all hostile powers. Unlike most sorceries, this spell can be cast as an Instant action, and immediately creates a transparent bubble of force around the caster with up to a twenty-foot radius. Entities and forces outside the bubble cannot penetrate it, and the interior remains a warm, breathable, safe environment regardless of the exterior. Those within the bubble can pass out of it, but they cannot then return within. The bubble can be dispelled by appropriate magics, but other enchantments and attacks cannot harm it, nor can magical effects or material objects pass through it from either direction. The spell lasts until the caster departs from the bubble.

The Jade Palanquin of the Faceless God

Level 2

This spell calls forth a floating palanquin of ornately-carved green stone. A slim three-foot-tall statue of a faceless entity stands at the center of the platform, while four slender pillars rise at the corners, the roof and sides being draped by metallic golden cloth. The palanquin itself is twelve feet long and eight wide, with room enough for several people to sit on it. It floats at shoulder-height

above the ground or a liquid surface below. It does not move of its own, but may be pulled along by even one human-sized bearer. The total burden on the palanquin cannot exceed more than two thousand pounds, or it sinks to the ground. It lasts until dusk, dawn, or until the statue of the god is struck or insulted, whichever comes first.

The Long Amber Moment

Level 1

This spell may be cast as an On Turn spell, provided no other has been cast this round, and targets a single willing or helpless creature the caster is touching. The subject is shifted out of the flow of conventional time, freezing and being limned in a pale sepia light. They and all their carried possessions are rendered impervious to all non-magical harm and are frozen in temporal stasis until the spell ends or is dispelled. Enchanted creatures are quite light, counting as only four items of Encumbrance due to their unwieldiness. The spell ends when the mage releases it, or up to a maximum of one day per caster level. If cast on himself, the mage cannot end it before the full duration expires.

Mantle of Disjuncting Dissection

Level 2

A visible willing creature within thirty feet is surrounded by a whirl of razor-sharp energy shards. Anyone who attempt to touch the target or make a melee attack against them must make an Evasion saving throw or suffer 1d6 damage plus the caster's level before resolving their attack. The field of blades is indiscriminate and will affect even allies trying to touch the target. The blades remain as long as the target gives up a Move Action each round in order to avoid disrupting them from within, up to a maximum of one scene.

Obnubilation of the Will

Level 4

This spell can only be applied to a helpless or restrained living victim, who gets a Mental saving throw to resist it and be forever after immune to its effects. On a failure, the target becomes hopelessly subject to the caster via a series of psychic fetters, obediently carrying out their will. The target must be able to understand the caster's wishes, but will obey them to the best of its intelligence, capability, and initiative. They must make a Mental saving throw to resist performing even suicidal acts. The spell lasts until it is dispelled or the caster releases the target. A caster can have no more creatures under this spell than twice their level or hit dice; if this number is exceeded, the earliest thrall is freed first. Creatures under the effect of the *Obnubilation of the Will* display numerous small ticks and magically-compelled quirks of behavior that may provoke puzzlement in casual observers and will give away the mental influence entirely to an onlooker with at least Magic-0 skill who can observe them for at least an hour.

The Ochre Sigil of Juxtaposition

Level 4

This spell is cast in two parts, each of which must be cast separately within a mile of each other, though such paired use counts as only a single spell slot. The first casting inscribes a palm-sized seal of ruddy brown radiance on the ground beneath the caster. The second casting will immediately switch the caster and all creatures and objects within ten feet with all creatures and objects within ten feet of the sigil. The caster may refrain from swapping certain targets as they wish. Only portable objects are swapped; any object too heavy for the caster to lift or secured in place remains unmoved. Unwilling targets get no saving throw if they have four or less hit dice; others can make a Mental save. Unused sigils dissipate in a day.

Open the High Road

Level 5

The caster carves open a metadimensional gate between their present location and a preset target point. Attuning the target point requires an hour of effort, after which this spell will open an opaque portal to it from a distance of up to one hundred miles per caster level. The portal is large enough to admit a cart and wagon and will remain open for up to one minute per caster level, ending when they pass through it. The gate is one-way only, from caster to target. Only living creatures and the vehicles they drive and objects they carry may pass through; atmosphere and other environments remain on the far side of the gate. Only one target point may be prepared for this spell at a time, and there is a 1-in-10 chance for every casting that the real destination is 1d100 miles in a random direction, discovered only after the portal is used.

Phantasmal Mimesis

Level 1

The mage creates a phantasmal seeming at a visible location within 100 feet per caster level. The illusion can occupy a number of 10-foot cubes equal to the caster's level and can include visual, audible, olfactory, and even tactile elements. If onlookers have no reason to believe the illusion is false, they will unconsciously move and perceive so as to conform to its apparent physical qualities, halting before walls, reeling from imagined blows, and seeing their clothing burnt by phantasmal flames. The illusion will behave and act on its own in accordance with the caster's intentions for it, but it cannot go more than a hundred feet from where it was conjured. Phantasmal monsters fight with the caster's hit bonus, do 1d8 damage, have AC 10, and vanish if struck. There can be no more than one active illusionary attacker per two caster levels. Foes brought to zero hit points fall unconscious and wake up ten minutes later with 1 hit point. Creatures convinced the illusion is false can make a Mental saving throw each round to reject its psychic influences, becoming immune to its effects. The illusion lasts until dispelled, the caster drops it, or this spell is cast again.

Prudentially Transient Abnegation of Life

Level 2

This spell may be cast as an Instant action, even if another spell has been cast the same round, and targets either the caster or a willing visible target. It can only be used in immediate response to an injury that reduces the target to zero hit points. When it does, the target suffers dramatic and ostentatiously obvious death, with mortal blows cleaving them asunder or gorily butchering them. They are dead to all mundane or magical examination. Up to two hours later however, at the target's discretion, the various remains of the target flow back together and restore their body with two hit points per caster level and two additional System Strain points gained. If the target's remains are intentionally scattered widely, incinerated, or entirely eaten, however, they cannot revive. The subject is aware of their surroundings while "dead".

Phobic Storm

Level 3

A wave of numbing terror sweeps over all enemies of the caster within forty feet. They must immediately make a Morale check at a -1 penalty, with failure causing flight. Those who succeed at the check suffer one point of damage per caster level from demoralization and despair, with those brought to zero hit points instead regaining one hit point and fleeing. This spell has no effect on creatures that feel no fear or that have a Morale of 12.

Pierce the Pallid Gate

Level 4

The caster opens a short-ranged spatial rift between two points within one hundred feet per level, provided they can see or have physically occupied both points at some prior time and provided the two points are at least twenty feet apart. The rift forms a gateway that connects the two points, one large enough to drive a cart through, and allows subjects on either side to see through and pass through the gate. Ambient environmental qualities such as liquids or atmospheres will not pass through the portal; only intentionally-directed creatures and objects will transfer. Once the creature has passed through a portal, it cannot pass through again until its next turn. The portal remains open for up to one round per caster level, but can be shut as an Instant action by the caster. Creatures partially in a rift when it closes are spat out on the far side.

Resounding Temporal Echo

Level 2

The caster imbues one visible ally per caster level with a burst of tremendous speed as their localized time begins to flow more rapidly. For 1d4+1 rounds, all subjects get an extra Main Action during their turn. This Main Action may not be used to cast spells or use arts. This spell severely taxes those who take advantage of it, adding 1 System Strain for each round in which the recipient takes the bonus action.



Scorn the Fetters of Earth

Level 3

The caster and up to one visible ally per caster level are briefly granted the ability to move in three dimensions, being able to walk and run upward into the air as easily as along flat ground. For the rest of the scene, those affected can move in such a way, remaining suspended in the air after their movement for the round. When the spell ends, either naturally or upon being dispelled, all affected targets float gently to the ground. Optionally, the caster can instead use this spell on one visible flying creature per caster level, which must make a Physical save at a penalty equal to the caster's Magic skill or be forced to land as they had fallen half the distance they had descended. For the rest of the scene, such creatures remain grounded and unable to fly.

Sigil of Aeolian Auctoritas

Level 4

A fierce gust of wind may be conjured in a line a hundred feet long and thirty feet wide. All creatures of man-size or smaller must make Physical saves or be bowled over and blown back thirty feet, losing their next round's Main Action and suffering 1d6 damage. Light wooden constructions or similar structures are flattened by the wind. If used outdoors, the spell can instead control the local weather, transforming the quarter-mile around the caster into any climate found normally at that location at any point during the year. The spell cannot summon a tornado or other extreme weather, but it can call rain and conventional storms sufficient to cause flooding in areas prone to it. The gust of wind is instantaneous, but the weather change lasts for one hour per caster level before reverting to its natural state.

The Torment of Tumefaction

Level 3

A single visible living creature is smote with a hideous curse of torment. Boils erupt all over their body, blood weeps from their orifices, tumors engorge their flesh, and all of their hair falls out almost instantaneously. If they perform any vigorous physical action save movement they incur two points of damage per caster level from the effects of the curse, damage which can be suffered no more than once per round by a target. A creature may spend its Main Action to attempt a Physical save to throw off the curse and return to a glabrous normalcy, but on a failure, the curse remains for the rest of the scene. If the creature has fewer hit dice than the caster has levels, a single failed save means the curse lasts indefinitely, until dispelled or until the caster releases them.

Touch of Elucidating Intangibility

Level 3

The caster touches a solid non-magical barrier when casting this spell. A 10 foot cube of the barrier then becomes perfectly transparent on the caster's side, allowing them to see and hear whatever lies on the other side as if it were well-lit and visible. Optionally, the caster may make the barrier insubstantial for one round per caster level, allowing anyone to pass or shoot through it from either side. The barrier always appears solid and opaque from the other side, even while the caster is peering through. If someone is caught within the barrier when it becomes solid again, they're spat out on the nearest clear side and suffer 2d10 damage. The spell ends when the caster ceases to touch the barrier or immediately after it has been made insubstantial.

Vallation of Specified Exclusion

Level 3

The caster must form some sort of line as part of this spell's invocation, either with dropped powders or a trace drawn in the dirt or a more permanent inlay into a floor. In extremis, the caster can make such a line as part of a Move action, tracing it out or scattering powder as they go. The line itself may be no longer than twenty feet per caster level, and may be straight or curved as the caster wishes. Once it has been drawn, this spell may be cast, empowering the line with the ability to ward off a particular target and prevent them or their powers from crossing or being made to cross the line, as if it were a physical wall. The caster can nominate any kind of target to be warded that could be distinguished without need for knowing their thoughts, such as "humans" or "non-humans" or "men wearing the livery of the baron". The barrier extends a hundred feet upward and ten feet downward and blocks any attack or magical power used by those warded. If the excluded creatures are attacked or targeted by powers from the other side of the barrier, however, the entire field shatters. The barrier lasts until dispelled, the caster drops it, or until one hour has passed per caster level.

Velocitous Imbuement

Level 1

Unlike most spells, this one may be cast as a simple On Turn action, targeting up to one visible willing creature per caster level within one hundred feet. Enchanted creatures become incredibly fleet of foot, doubling their usual ground movement rate and becoming capable of running up walls and across ceilings without falling, provided they end their round upright on a navigable surface. They may also move away from melee opponents without needing to make a *Fighting Withdrawal* to avoid a parting attack, and may pass through and around armed foes who do not completely physically block their path. The spell lasts for the remainder of the scene and adds 1 System Strain to those who take advantage of it.



The Verdant Vallation

Level 2

A vast wall of thick, heavy vines and other plant life blooms from a visible point within one hundred feet per caster level. The wall is up to twenty feet high and three feet thick and runs for as much as twenty feet in width per caster level. The vine wall can be shaped as the caster wishes within the spell's area of effect, so long as it's contiguous, and may be laid horizontally if a bridge or roof is desired. Enemies must inflict five hit points of damage per caster level to cut a man-sized hole in the vines, and they must be using weapons or means that could actually cut through a wooden wall to do any meaningful harm. The vines may be optionally covered in long, vicious thorns to discourage climbing, inflicting 2d6 damage on any creature who tries to climb over it. If the vine wall is summoned from earth that could plausibly support plant life, it remains until dispelled or until it dies naturally. If called from bare stone or other infertile soils, it withers away to dust at the end of the scene.

Visitation of the Clement Clime

Level 2

The caster and up to three visible allies per caster level are shielded from the excesses of hostile elemental energies, becoming immune to mundane extremes of heat and cold and natural acids or electrical discharges. Against magical harm of this nature, they automatically take only half the damage they normally would, or none if they make a successful Physical saving throw. This spell lasts for one hour per caster level.

Wardpact Invocation

Level 1

This spell may be cast in two different forms. If it targets a creature within 200 feet, the target becomes partially immune to physical weapons; any weapon hit on them requires the attacker make a successful Physical save or the hit is negated. This effect lasts for one round per two caster levels, rounded up, and can't target the caster. If it targets a visible weapon within two hundred feet, that weapon is rendered entirely harmless and unable to inflict damage for the rest of the scene, with no saving throw. The spell may only affect a given target or weapon once per scene and natural body weapons aren't affected.

The Wind of the Final Repose

Level 1

The mage designates a visible point within two hundred feet. A silent, invisible burst of soporific influence erupts from that point, targeting all living creatures within a twenty-foot radius. All such targets with 4 or fewer hit dice within that area fall unconscious instantly, and can be roused only by damage or by a Main Action used to kick them awake. If not roused, they revive at the end of the scene. Entities that do not sleep are immune to this spell.



ELEMENTALISTS

The long eons of the Legacy have ravaged the natural laws of Latter Earth. Simple properties such as electrical conductivity, steam pressure, chemical reactions, and other qualities now no longer behave as they once did and react in unpredictable and unreliable ways. Sages have demonstrated how some physical reactions that should be necessary for basic human life no longer function outside of living organisms, suggesting that entire swaths of fundamental reality are being supported as special-case exceptions by the power of the Legacy.

The intellectual ancestors of the Elementalists attempted to deal with this chaos by returning to the basics; not the reactions of combustion or the elemental chemicals, but the classical elements of earth, fire, wind, and water. These substances were thought to be the key to the unfathomable changes of the Legacy, as they were simple enough to avoid the decay of complex machines and devices, yet complex enough to behave in a logical way rather than as the chaotic matter of subtler chemical compounds.

Elementalists thus seek to use New Magic to control these elements, adapting fragments of High Magic spells and dimly-understood aspects of the Legacy to control their creation and manifestation. By using the classical elements as subjects for their magic, the Elementalists believe that they can eventually understand the logic of the Legacy, and perhaps even learn to control it, enforcing a new, stable implementation of natural law.

Of course, not all Elementalists are fired by this high zeal. Many simply find the practical uses of flame, stone, water, and air to be beneficial for their own ends. The fiery rebuke of a master Elementalist can scourge whole towns, and even less talented mages can work wonders in helping others deal with physical obstacles.

Some Elementalists learn at the feet of wizened masters, while others belong to formal schools that teach the art for the benefit of their patrons. A PC might be one such student, or some scientist-sage who has developed their arts in pursuit of some deeper understanding of the Legacy and its impact on physical laws. Outside of their formal organizations, Elementalists often find much to discuss in their occult studies, though differences of opinion regarding the “correct” operation of unaltered reality can sometimes cause bloody disputes.

ELEMENTALIST BENEFITS

All Elementalists gain Magic as a bonus skill, acquiring it at level-0, or level-1 if was already level-0. A firm grounding in the arcane science of Latter Earth is necessary to master their particular arts.

Elementalists can prepare and cast High Magic spells in addition to the New Magic spells specific to Elementalists. Some of the latter are given on the following pages, but others doubtless exist. As usual for spellcasters, Elementalists can’t cast spells or use arts while armored or holding a shield.

Elementalists are not as talented at general High Magic research as High Mages are, but their studies still bear fruit in time. Each time they advance a level, they can pick a new High Magic spell or a New Magic Elementalist spell to add to their spellbook. They must be able to cast the spell to add it to their selection.

Elementalists gain the *Elemental Resilience* and *Elemental Sparks* arts as part of their basic training, and may pick one additional art from the adjacent list. Further arts are learned as they advance in character level, as given in the tables below. Once chosen, an art cannot be changed.

Full Elementalist

Level	Max Level	Spells Cast	Spells Prepared	Arts Gained
1	1	1	3	Elemental Resilience, Elemental Sparks, and Any One
2	1	1	3	Any One
3	2	2	4	
4	2	2	5	Any One
5	3	3	6	
6	3	3	7	Any One
7	4	4	8	
8	4	4	9	Any One
9	5	5	10	
10	5	6	12	Any One

Partial Elementalist

Level	Max Level	Spells Cast	Spells Prepared	Arts Gained
1	1	1	2	Elemental Resilience, Elemental Sparks, and Any One
2	1	1	3	
3	1	1	3	Any One
4	1	2	4	
5	2	2	5	
6	2	3	6	Any One
7	2	3	7	
8	2	3	7	
9	3	4	8	Any One
10	3	4	9	

ARTS OF THE ELEMENTALISTS

Elementalist Effort is calculated as usual, with each PC's maximum being equal to one plus their Magic skill level plus the better of their Intelligence or Charisma modifiers. Partial Elementalists have a score one point lower than this, albeit not less than one.

All Elementalists learn the *Elemental Resilience* and *Elemental Sparks* arts as part of their basic training. Other Arts may be chosen normally afterwards.

Elemental Resilience: You are unharmed by mundane extremes of cold or by heat less than that of a furnace. You suffer only half damage from magical or extremely intense flame or frost attacks.

Elemental Sparks: You can conjure petty amounts of flame, water, ice, stone, or wind, sufficient to do small tricks, chill drinks, light candles, or do other minor things. Conjured substances last no longer than a scene, and conjured water cannot lastingly quench thirst. This art cannot actually be useful in solving a problem or overcoming a challenge more than once per game session.

OTHER ELEMENTALIST ARTS

Beckoned Deluge: Commit Effort for the scene as a Main Action to conjure a considerable amount of water at a visible point within fifty feet per caster level. This water is sufficient to drench one 10-foot cube of matter per character level, making non-magical bowstrings useless, extinguishing flames, and inflicting 1d6 damage per caster level on fiery supernatural creatures. This water persists indefinitely after its conjuration and is sufficient to hydrate ten people per caster level.

Earth sight: Commit Effort for the scene as an On Turn action. For the rest of the scene, you can see the outlines of solid objects even in perfect darkness, and can peer through a number of feet of earth or stone equal to your character level.

Elemental Blast: Commit Effort for the scene as a Main Action to hurl a blast of some elemental force at a visible target within fifty feet per character level. The attack is made with Magic as the combat skill, Int, Cha, or Dex as the attribute, and a bonus to hit equal to your character level. It is not hindered by melee foes. On a hit, the attack does 1d6 damage plus your character level and attribute mod. The blast may have collateral effects on objects in the case of hurled fire or a torrent of pressurized water, but any conjured matter vanishes at the end of the round.

Flame sight: Commit Effort as an On Turn action. While the Effort remains Committed, you can see thermal gradients sufficient to distinguish surfaces and living creatures, even in perfect darkness. Optionally, you may cause your own eyes to cast a light sufficient to illuminate your surroundings clearly out to a range of 30 feet.

Pavis of Elements: Commit Effort as an On Turn action to conjure an elemental barrier around yourself. The barrier improves your Armor Class by +4 and remains as long as the Effort remains Committed. This bonus stacks with other effects, but cannot increase AC above 18, regardless of the combinations.

Petrifying Stare: Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action and target a visible creature. The creature must make a Physical save or become partially petrified, losing its Move action for a number of rounds equal to half your caster level, rounded up. Flying creatures are forced to land by this art and swimming creatures will inevitably sink to the bottom.

Rune of Destruction: Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action and target an adjacent solid surface. A glowing rune the size of a handprint forms on the surface and persists for one hour per caster level. Any creature who gets within two feet of the rune will trigger it, causing it to explode in a five-foot radius with an elemental force of your choice and suffering 2d6 damage plus your caster level. Creatures already within five feet of the rune when it is laid will not trigger it until they re-enter the area, nor will the caster trigger their own runes. Runes cannot overlap their areas of effect.

Steps of Air: Commit Effort for the scene as an On Turn action and target a visible ally; for one round per caster level, the target can fly at their usual movement rate. If the art ends while they are still in the air, they descend harmlessly to the ground. This art may also be used as an Instant action to negate falling damage for any single target.

Stunning Shock: Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action and target a visible creature within fifty feet per caster level. The target creature must be wearing or holding at least a pound worth of conductive metal or be considerably dampened. An electrical bolt leaps from the caster to stun the target, causing them to lose their next Main Action. A Physical saving throw can mitigate the effect, causing the target to lose their Move action instead of their Main. A creature can be targeted only once per scene by this.

Thermal Shield: Commit Effort for the scene as an Instant action to immediately negate one instance of fire or frost damage to any single visible ally or object. This defense lasts only long enough to nullify the single instance of damage.

ELEMENTALISTS IN OTHER WORLDS

The wizard who specializes in a particular variety of elemental magic is a familiar fantasy trope. If you want to create such a specialist in a different campaign setting, you can do so by giving the Elementalist a few more art and spell options specifically flavored for that element and forbidding them from taking arts or spells related to other elements.



ELEMENTALIST NEW MAGIC

As with other specialist traditions, the Elementalists have been able to devise a number of New Magic spells in line with their particular specialties. Only Elementalists may learn or cast these sorceries.

Aqueous Harmony

Level 1

The elementalist and up to a dozen allies are charmed with powers of water-breathing, a tolerance for the pressure and cold of the deeps, and the ability to see through water as if it were well-lit air. Ensorcelled beings may move freely while in the water at their usual movement rate and their attacks and projectile weapons are not hindered by the medium, nor are their possessions soaked or damaged. The spell lasts for one hour per caster level, but will not naturally end so long as a subject is still at least partially submerged. Only the caster or magical dispelling can stop it under those circumstances.

Flame Scrying

Level 1

The elementalist becomes aware of the approximate locations of all open flames within thirty feet per caster level. They may choose one of those flames as a focus for the scrying, allowing them to see and hear everything around the flame as if they were present. The spell's duration lasts for as long as the elementalist remains motionlessly focused on it; during this duration, they may switch their focus between the various flames in range as they wish.

Elemental Favor

Level 1

The elementalist makes a direct appeal to a non-magical mass of earth, stone, water, flame, or air no larger than a ten-foot cube. At the end of the round, the mass will move or reshape itself within that space as the elementalist requests, maintaining its new form until the end of the scene. If its new shape is one that is stable without magical help, it can be told to remain in it after the spell is finished.

Elemental Spy

Level 1

The elementalist enchants a stone, ounce of liquid, flame no smaller than a candleflame, or a particular plume of smoke or incense. For one day per level, so long as the charmed object is not destroyed, dispersed, or consumed, they can as a Main Action see and listen to anything around the object as if they were standing there.

Boreal Wings

Level 2

The elementalist chooses a visible ally within one hundred feet; the target becomes capable of swift and easy aerial travel, flying at twice their usual movement rate. If

the spell ends or is dispelled while aloft, the target descends gently to the earth. This spell lasts for one scene, though casters of fifth level or more can make it last an hour, and those of eighth level or more can make it last until dawn or dusk, whichever comes next.

The Burrower Below

Level 2

A passage is carved through natural stone or earth, forming a tunnel up to twenty feet long per caster level and up to ten feet wide and tall. The caster can cause the earth to compress and pack itself so as to stabilize the tunnel even in very sandy or burdened soil, or they can allow it to collapse naturally if burdened by some large structure or unstable surroundings. This spell can function against worked stone, but the length of the tunnel is much shorter, being only two feet per level. Magical stone or earth cannot be altered by this spell. The caster has basic control over the direction and interior features of the tunnel, and can form stairs or other simple structures within it.

Flame Without End

Level 2

A sample of flame no larger than the caster is made effectively eternal. It no longer consumes the object it burns, though it can still be used to burn or heat other things, and it resists all extinguishing save being buried or wholly immersed in water. The elementalist can temporarily extinguish it at will. A number of such flames can be created equal to the elementalist's level; beyond that, special ingredients and fuels are needed that cost 500 silver pieces per flame. If used as a weapon, it adds +2 damage to a successful hit, albeit nothing to Shock. The flame lasts until dispelled, extinguished, or the elementalist releases it.

Pact of Stone and Sea

Level 2

The elementalist chooses earth, water, fire, or wind when casting this spell and selects a visible target to be affected. For the rest of the scene, the target is immune to injury caused by mundane manifestations of that substance; stone weapons don't harm them, water doesn't drown them, fire doesn't burn them, and wind doesn't topple them. This affects secondary effects of the material as well; a fire-pacted mage couldn't be boiled in a pot, and an earth-pacted one won't be suffocated if buried alive.

Elemental Vallation

Level 3

A wall of a chosen churning elemental force can be called up by the elementalist. The barrier is ten feet long per character level, with a height of ten feet and a thickness of one foot. The barrier must rest on solid ground but may be bent or shaped as desired so long as no part of it

is more than two hundred feet from the caster. Earthen walls are impervious to anything but mining-appropriate tools or rock-shattering strength, taking 20 HP of damage to knock a man-sized hole in them. Fire walls inflict 3d6 damage plus the elementalists' level on anyone who passes through them. Water walls spin and hurl creatures of ox-size or less who pass through them, ejecting them at a random point on the far side of the wall and doing 2d6 damage from the buffeting. Air walls are invisible, inaudible, and twenty feet in height; those who cross them suffer 1d6 plus the elementalists' level in electrical damage. The walls vanish at the end of the scene.

Like the Stones

Level 3

The elementalists charge their physical shape with the qualities of a chosen element for the rest of the scene. In all cases, they need not breathe and become immune to poisons and diseases not already present in them. If stone, they automatically stabilize at zero hit points and ignore the first three points of damage from any source of harm. If water, they can pass through any aperture a mouse could get through. If air, they can fly at their usual movement rate and gain a +4 Armor Class bonus against ranged attacks. If fire, they inflict 1d6 damage to all creatures in melee range at the start of their turn each round and become immune to heat damage.

Wind Walking

Level 3

A visible target creature and their possessions are briefly transformed into a misty, insubstantial cloud. Only sources of harm that could conceivably disrupt a cloud of mist can harm them, and until the spell's end they may pass freely into any area that a vapor could reach. They may move freely in all three dimensions at their normal movement rate, though they cannot physically manipulate objects. The spell lasts until the end of the scene or until the target or the caster choose to end it.

Calcifying Scourge

Level 4

A visible target within one hundred feet must make a Physical saving throw or be turned to stone. Any size of living creature may be so transmuted, though inanimate objects larger than a cart cannot. Objects being held or worn by someone else get a Physical saving throw made by their user. The calcification remains until dispelled or the caster undoes the magic, but if the object or creature is damaged in the meanwhile, it may end up being harmed or killed on its restoration. If the Physical saving throw is made successfully by a creature, the target is temporarily slowed, losing its Move action for the next 1d6 rounds.

Elemental Guardian

Level 4

The elementalists imbue a human-sized mass of earth, water, fire, or air with a crude awareness and an eagerness to defend them. Whatever the substance used, it now has 4 HD, AC 15, a Move of 40'/action, a +1 skill bonus, saves of 13+, Instinct 0, Morale 12, and a melee attack of +6/1d10 with no Shock. If called from earth, it has 6 hit dice, albeit its other stats don't change. If called from fire, it does 5/- Shock damage. If summoned from water, it has an AC of 18, and if called from air, it can fly at its usual movement rate. It has a human degree of intelligence, can communicate with others and manipulate objects, and serves with suicidal devotion. Only one elemental guardian can be summoned at any one time, and if destroyed, a new one cannot be called that same scene. A guardian persists until destroyed or until the dawn after they have been summoned.

Fury of the Elements

Level 5

A combination of molten rock, searing pyroclastic winds, and superheated steam erupts forth to ravage a chosen target point within two hundred feet per caster level. The cataclysmic ruin smites everything within thirty feet of the target point for 10d6 damage, destroying all conventional structures. The zone of devastation then moves 1d6x10 feet in a random direction at the start of the next round, blasting everything in its path. The zone will continue to wander in this fashion for 1d6 rounds in total before dying out. The molten remnants of the spell remain after this duration, a hazard for whomever enters the area for the rest of the day.

Tremors of the Depths

Level 5

The elementalists call up a deep, rolling tremor from within the earth, centering it on a visible point and affecting all structures in a radius of up to five hundred feet. This spell's effects build slowly, requiring five minutes to fully manifest, but they can successfully topple or destroy any structures, tunnels, or caves within the affected area unless such structures are magically reinforced. The effects are negated if the spell is dispelled within a minute after it was cast; after that, it's too late to stop the effect.



HEALERS

Every culture has need of physicians and menders, and it is no surprise that many of them would turn to magic for this need. Healers are those adepts of curative sorcery who focus on mending wounds, purging diseases, and preserving the lives of living creatures. They are very rarely the only medical specialists in their native society, but their remarkable powers are in high demand wherever they are found.

Healers do not practice High Magic or other forms of conventional spellcasting. Instead, their training revolves around specific techniques for mending damaged living tissue and the neutralization of diseases and toxins. Conventional medical treatments that revolve around the germ theory of disease and ancient commonplaces of physiology aren't always reliable or valid in the lands of Latter Earth, and so magical techniques are sometimes necessary to achieve what antibiotics or surgical intervention could accomplish in a former age.

Not every aspiring physician is cut out to be a Healer. Channeling the magical energies requires the right traits, and those without these native gifts can't hope to be trained successfully. Those with the right magical potential can look forward to a position of respect and reward from most societies.

The actual training of a Healer is often left to a master-apprentice relationship, with likely candidates serving out a period of instruction and field practice before being freed to make their own way. Richer or better-organized societies might establish special schools for Healer candidates, often patronized by the very nobility they will later be expected to serve.

Religious orders are another major source of Healers, as many monasteries and seminaries are ideally positioned to identify compatible candidates early in their careers. In some nations, the very role of a Healer is considered a fundamentally religious one, with the powers they wield being special gifts of their patron deity. Such Healers are often called upon to act as priests as well.

Partial Healer

Level	Arts Gained
1	Healing Touch and Any One
2	Any One
3	
4	Any One
5	Any One
6	Any One
7	
8	Any One
9	
10	Any One



HEALER BENEFITS

The Healer class exists only as a partial Mage class, to be taken by an Adventurer along with another partial class. Thus, a Partial Warrior/Partial Healer might be a grizzled combat medic, a Partial Expert/Partial Healer might be an erudite physician gifted in both mundane and magical healing methods, and a Partial Necromancer/Partial Healer might be an adept of life and death.

All Healers gain Heal as a bonus skill, acquiring it at level-0, or level-1 if they already have it at level-0. A basic grounding in mundane healing techniques is necessary in order to learn their more sophisticated magical arts.

Healers do not learn how to cast spells. Instead, they focus on their special arcane healing arts. Wielding these arts usually requires nothing more than touching the target and concentrating on the desired effect, and the process is direct and simple enough to perform even when burdened by armor or carrying a shield. These arts are usually quite subtle, and don't produce visible or audible indications of their use.

A Healer may have certain social advantages in some situations, depending on the culture and their own traditions. Even in the roughest surroundings, a proven Healer can likely expect hospitality and decent treatment in exchange for their efforts in treating the innumerable pains and aches of their hosts. A famous Healer can often impose on the powerful in exchange for curing some noble's persistent or difficult case of illness.

At first level, a Healer gains the **Healing Touch** art and can pick one more of their choice. As they advance in levels afterwards, they can learn new arts. Once chosen, an art is permanent and cannot be exchanged.

ARTS OF THE HEALERS

Healer Effort is calculated with Heal rather than Magic, with each PC's maximum being equal to their Heal skill level plus the better of their Intelligence or Charisma modifiers, to a minimum of one point.

All Healers are trained in the *Healing Touch* art, but may develop other techniques with time.

Healing Touch: Commit Effort for the scene as an Instant action; for the rest of the scene, you may heal 2d6 damage plus your Heal skill to a touched ally as a Main Action. This healing adds 1 System Strain to the target each time it is applied.

OTHER HEALER ARTS

Empowered Healer: Your *Healing Touch* becomes more powerful, adding your level to any healing.

Facile Healer: Your *Healing Touch* ability is improved, and you no longer need to Commit Effort to activate it.

Far Healer: Your *Healing Touch* ability is improved, and may be used on a visible target within ten feet per character level.

Final Repose: Target a visible living creature and Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action. For the rest of the scene, they take a Physical saving throw penalty equal to your Heal skill. If they are reduced to zero hit points before the end of the scene, they die with no chance for stabilization or revival.

Healer's Eye: Commit Effort as an On Turn action; while the Effort remains committed, you can use a Main Action to visually detect diseases and poisons, diagnose creatures flawlessly, perceive their physiology, and learn their current hit point totals. As a side effect, you can detect living creatures by sight regardless of available light or obscuring mists.

Limb Restoration: Only expert healers can master this art, which cannot be learned earlier than 8th level. You must Commit all remaining Effort for the day, a minimum of one point, to regenerate a missing limb or organ for a target you are touching, or efface some dramatic scar or other physical debility. The target's System Strain is automatically maximized.

Purge Ailment: Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action. An ally you are touching is cured of one poison or disease. Creatures killed by poison can be revived by this art if it is used within six minutes of death. Magical poisons and diseases may require a Wis/Heal or Cha/Heal skill check against a difficulty of 8 or more. At seventh level, you need only Commit Effort for the scene to use this ability.

Refined Restoration: You and up to a dozen allies you tend before they sleep will all lose 2 System Strain from a good night's rest instead of 1.

Revive the Fallen: Only expert healers are capable of mastering this art, which cannot be learned earlier than 8th level. Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action to revive a recently-slain living creature that

you are touching. This ability must be used on a target within one minute per caster level of their death, and will not work on a corpse that has been dismembered, incinerated, or otherwise disjuncted. The target's System Strain is automatically maximized and they'll be unconscious for twenty-four hours after their restoration before awakening with 1 hit point.

Swift Healer: Your *Healing Touch* ability is improved, and may be used as an On Turn action once per day per character level, though not more than once per round on any given target.

The Healer's Knife: Your *Healing Touch* ability is altered, and may be used to inflict damage to a living target instead of healing it. The damage done is equivalent to the healing that would normally be done, albeit you receive 1 System Strain instead of the target. Using this power in melee requires a successful Punch attack with a hit bonus equal to your Heal skill, with the damage added to any done by the blow, or simply touching an unwary target. Ranged use with *Far Healer* is impossible with this art.

Tireless Vigor: Commit Effort; while it remains Committed your need to eat, drink, breathe, or sleep does not grow further. You may exert yourself tirelessly and regenerate 1 lost hit point per hour.

Vital Furnace: Your tremendous life energy can be used to instantly regenerate any non-mortal wound you have received. Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action to negate the damage from an injury you just received that did not reduce you to zero hit points. Aside from this ability, you automatically stabilize if reduced to zero hit points and awaken ten minutes later with 1 hit point. This ability cannot undo damage you intentionally inflict on yourself via some power or magical exchange.

HEALERS IN OTHER WORLDS

The classic "cleric" or "priest" concept could be replicated by using Healer in conjunction with Warrior for the armored fighting-cleric or a different flavor of Mage for the robed spellcasting priest.

The former might pine for some of the wider variety of spells often given to such clerics in other role-playing games, but a GM might be best off just adding the most characteristic of those powers or deity-specific gifts as optional arts the PC can pick.

However it's decided, a GM should be careful not to make magical healing the only source of quick hit point recovery in their campaign unless they want every party to require a Healer or the equivalent. The first aid rules on page 48 should allow a party without a Healer to still recover after a fight, even if it's less efficient than a magical healer and not practical for use mid-combat.



NECROMANCERS

The Legacy has changed much in the eons that have passed since humanity first obtained its power, but death remains the common fate of all. Whether king or peasant, all must find the grave in time.

Necromancers are those sorcerers who are not satisfied with this finality. Through study of ancient records and the examination of the countless fragments of healing magic and restorative arcana that still persist in the Latter Earth, they have concluded that at one point in the past, humanity was immortal. The Legacy once preserved all the children of Earth from their final dissolution, and only through the malice of the Outsiders and some unfathomable historical change was this blessed state ever undone.

Necromancers are determined to restore this lost immortality. Some seek it only for their own selfish purposes, while others wish to make war on Death itself and drive it out of the world once more. The ancient powers that once granted every human a perpetual life of vigor, health, and happiness must be renewed once more, and all the corruptions and bars that banished that state must be undone.

The path to this immortality is regrettably laden with corpses. Only by studying death itself and examining the intricate relationship between the Legacy and unliving flesh can the deeper secrets of life be unlocked. Some zealous Necromancers are inclined to enlist unwilling "volunteers" for this work, while others content themselves with the naturally dead and the remains of those who cannot object.

Skilled Necromancers are able to imbue corpses with a semblance of life, evoking ancient Legacy protocols to call back shadows of intellect or echoes of former identity. Actual full restoration of the long-dead is considered the hallmark of true arch-mastery of this tradition, but only a Legate-Necromancer is ever apt to have that kind of power.

Unsurprisingly, Necromancers have a checkered reputation among people. Their life-prolonging research is eagerly sought by the rich and powerful, but also often outlawed on the basis of their supposed depredations and the worries of anxious heirs. Some more broad-minded or amoral polities allow Necromancers to operate openly, but usually a considerable amount of discretion is necessary.

A Necromancer PC was likely taught in secret by a mentor who either posed as a High Mage or kept his powers entirely hidden. Some nations do have actual open orders and schools of necromancy, however, though such organizations tend to be havens for the worst impulses of the tradition, where the most ruthless and savage of sorcerers rise highest in the hierarchy.

NECROMANCER BENEFITS

All Necromancers gain Magic as a bonus skill, acquiring it at level-0, or level-1 if was already level-0. The arts of life and death require a proper education in the occult to practice correctly.

Necromancers can prepare and cast High Magic spells in addition to the New Magic spells specific to Necromancers. Some of the latter are given on the following pages, but others doubtless exist. As usual for spellcasters, Necromancers can't cast spells or use arts while armored or holding a shield.

Necromancers are not as talented at general High Magic research as High Mages are, but their studies still bear fruit in time. Each time they advance a level, they can pick a new High Magic spell or a New Magic Necromancer spell to add to their spellbook. They must be able to cast the spell to add it to their selection.

Necromancers can pick an art specific to their tradition from the adjacent list. Further arts are learned as they advance in character level, as given in the tables below. Once chosen, an art cannot be changed.

Full Necromancers

Level	Max Level	Spells Cast	Spells Prepared	Arts Gained
1	1	1	3	Any One
2	1	1	3	Any One
3	2	2	4	
4	2	2	5	Any One
5	3	3	6	
6	3	3	7	Any One
7	4	4	8	
8	4	4	9	Any One
9	5	5	10	
10	5	6	12	Any One

Partial Necromancers

Level	Max Level	Spells Cast	Spells Prepared	Arts Gained
1	1	1	2	Any One
2	1	1	3	
3	1	1	3	Any One
4	1	2	4	
5	2	2	5	
6	2	3	6	Any One
7	2	3	7	
8	2	3	7	
9	3	4	8	Any One
10	3	4	9	

ARTS OF THE NECROMANCERS

Necromancer Effort is calculated as usual, with each PC's maximum being equal to one plus their Magic skill level plus the better of their Intelligence or Charisma modifiers. Partial Necromancers have a score one point lower than this, albeit not less than one.

Bonetalker: You can see and communicate with any undead creature, regardless of a shared language or the creature's natural state of invisibility. By Committing Effort for the scene you can sense the surface thoughts of any visible undead, including an impression of any commands or behavior it has been ordered to carry out. Unintelligent undead will not attack you or your companions unless specifically compelled to do so by a command or a master. Even intelligent undead will generally pause at least for an initial parley before attacking.

Cold Flesh: You no longer require sleep and feel pain only in an abstract sense. You can suffer no more than 2 points of damage from any given instance of Shock and you have a natural Armor Class equal to 12 plus half your level, rounded down.

Consume Life Energy: By making a Punch attack or using a melee weapon you have spent at least an hour properly consecrating, you can absorb a portion of the damage you inflict on others as healing to yourself. For each successful attack you make with such implements, you heal 1d6 damage, up to a maximum of the damage done by the attack. You cannot drain more life than the target has remaining hit points.

False Death: Commit Effort as an Instant action; while it remains Committed you appear dead to all mundane examination. You lose your Main Actions while "dead", but can move and perceive normally and do not need to eat, drink, breathe, or perform other bodily functions. Poisons and diseases do not progress in you while you are "dead". You can maintain this state of death for up to one day per level before needing at least an hour to recover.

Gravesight: Commit Effort as an On Turn action; while it remains Committed, you can see the life energies of living creatures around you as various glowing patterns, regardless of the mundane illumination available. You can perceive sicknesses, poisons, and other physical qualities on sight. As a side effect of this ability, you can see normally even in perfect blackness.

Keeper of the Gate: At your discretion, creatures within twenty feet of you per character level that are Mortally Wounded will die instantly and cannot be revived by magic or medicine. Conversely, you can Commit Effort for the day to automatically stabilize any or all within that range, increasing their System Strain by 1 point. This benefit cannot aid creatures that have been dismembered, shredded, or otherwise suffered unsurvivable injuries.

Life Bridge: You can transfer life force between willing or helpless participants. Commit Effort for the day; for the rest of the scene, you can shift hit points from one willing or helpless target no smaller than a dog to another as a Main Action, provided you are touching both. You can shift enough hit points to Mortally Wound a donor, but you can't give more to the recipient than would refresh their maximum allowed hit points.

Master of Bones: Undead must roll twice to save versus your abilities or spells and take the worse roll. You may Commit Effort for the scene as an Instant action to negate any single attack, magical power or spell an undead uses against you. Undead with more than twice as many hit dice as you have levels cannot be foiled this way.

Red Harvest: You are empowered by death. As an Instant action, whenever an intelligent living creature with at least one hit die perishes within fifty feet of you, Commit Effort for the day to either heal 1d6 plus your level in lost hit points or gain a +4 bonus on your next hit roll this scene. This art cannot be stacked, and it can be used only once per round.

Unaging: You no longer naturally age, and will remain perfectly hale and vigorous up to your species' natural maximum age plus 20% per character level, after which you will collapse into dust and decay. Immortality beyond this point is possible, but generally requires consistent supplies of life energy, occult materials, or other difficult-to-acquire or morally questionable materials. You also become immune to poisons and diseases.

Uncanny Ichor: Your blood is not like the blood of normal beings. Predators find it nauseating and will not bite you unless provoked. Unintelligent predators will not consider you edible. This ichor is reluctant to leave your body, and stabbing or puncture injuries can Mortally Wound you but cannot result in your death unless you are entirely pincushioned by your foes or suffer catastrophic physical damage.

Unliving Persistence: Commit Effort for the day as an On Turn action to automatically stabilize when Mortally Wounded. You may use this ability to benefit others if you are able to touch them. This ability cannot save a subject that has experienced dismemberment or other extremely final deaths.

NECROMANCERS IN OTHER WORLDS

Death wizards are a mainstay of fantasy literature, and the Necromancer can work well for adding such flavor to different campaign worlds. They don't necessarily need to be naturally malevolent casters, however; it's quite possible to build a more morally-neutral broker of life energy or undead-hunter with this class. You can drop the class in whenever you need some mechanics to represent such mages.



NECROMANCER NEW MAGIC

As with other specialist traditions, the Necromancers have been able to devise a number of New Magic spells in line with their particular specialties. Only Necromancers may learn or cast these sorceries.

Command the Dead

Level 1

The necromancer exerts their will over a number of hit dice worth of undead equal to twice their character level. These undead must be visible and within one hundred feet of the caster. Undead get a Mental saving throw to resist this binding, at a penalty equal to the caster's Magic skill. Creatures only partially-bewitched by the spell due to their excess hit dice merely stand dazed for a round. Those fully within the hit die cap who are affected become suicidally loyal to the necromancer until they are released by the caster. Regardless of how often the caster uses this spell, they may have no more than twice their level worth of hit dice bound at any one time, with the oldest-enchanted being first released.

Query the Skull

Level 1

This spell requires a corpse with largely-intact organs of communication. The corpse cannot have been dead for more than one day per caster level. Once sorceled, the corpse will answer up to one question per caster level, with the caster understanding the answers regardless of the creature's natural language. Corpses are laconic, and generally answer in no more than one or two sentences; their replies will be truthful, but tend to be literal and they have no power to hypothesize or make judgments. This spell may not be used twice on the same corpse.

Smite the Dead

Level 1

The necromancer conjures a blast of dispelling force at a point within one hundred feet per caster level, affecting an area up to 20 feet in radius. All hostile undead within that area immediately suffer 1d10 damage per caster level. Undead with hit dice equal or less than the caster's level must make a Physical save or be destroyed outright. The necromancer may Commit Effort for the day immediately before casting this spell; if so, its casting does not count against the Necromancer's available spell slots for the day.

Terrible Liveliness

Level 1

A necromancer can give an undead creature the semblance of a healthy, normal living being with this spell. The target appears as it did in life, at any point in its lifespan that the necromancer so desires, and is capable of performing all normal human activities that its cognition allows it to perform. The spell uses the creature's nature as a template for its effects, so the disguise is tangible

and physically real until dispelled or the necromancer drops the effect. A necromancer can maintain only one such disguise per level, and it does not work on sentient unwilling targets.

Augment Mortal Vitality

Level 2

The necromancer may refine and enhance the natural flow of vitality within a willing visible target. For the rest of the scene, all Physical saving throws they make gain a bonus equal to the necromancer's Magic skill and they automatically stabilize when Mortally Wounded. Once during the scene, as an Instant action, they can immediately heal from all damage inflicted by an injury that did not Mortally Wound them. The recipient of this spell gains one System Strain.

Enfeebling Wave

Level 2

A wash of debilitating force erupts in a 20-foot radius at a visible point within one hundred feet. All living creatures within the area must make a Physical saving throw or for the rest of the scene their movement rate is halved and they must make all attack and damage rolls twice and take the worse result. If the save is successful, these penalties apply only to their next turn.

Final Death

Level 2

The necromancer curses one visible target per level. For the rest of the scene, these targets cannot recover or gain hit points and will die instantly if Mortally Wounded. After each failed instance of healing, a target can make a Physical save to throw off the spell.

Raise Corpse

Level 2

The necromancer targets a mostly-intact skeleton or corpse, imbuing it with a semblance of life. Whatever the creature's attributes were in life, it now has 1 HD, an AC of 13, a Move of 30'/round, a +0 skill bonus, saves of 15+, a +1/1d6 unarmed melee attack, Instinct 0, and a Morale of 12. Such corpses may be equipped with weapons or armor. Its decay or dissolution immediately ceases, and it becomes suicidally loyal to its creator. The corpse has no natural volition, but will obey commands with a human degree of intelligence. It has only vague memories of its prior life, and while it may retain human tics or habits it had in life it can answer only the simplest and most self-evident questions. Damage to a corpse can be repaired only by casting this spell on it again, which restores it to its original "health". The corpse continues to exist until it is reduced to zero hit points or its creator releases it. A necromancer cannot have more active subjects of this spell than their character level.

Compel Flesh

Level 3

A visible living creature or physically-bodied undead within 100 feet is ensorcelled by this spell, their flesh and bones becoming temporarily enthralled to the caster's will. The target becomes paralyzed unless commanded by the caster as an On Turn action; once given a command, their body will dutifully carry it out on their next turn. The user's mind is not affected by this spell, so they cannot be made to cast spells, answer questions, or perform other intellectual tasks, but they will fight, move, and perform other non-suicidal physical acts as normal. The target may make a Physical saving throw at the start of each of their turns to throw off the effect, but they will inevitably suffer one point of damage per caster level with each attempt as their flesh writhes and tears. If not thrown off earlier, the spell lasts until the end of the scene.

Festering Curse

Level 3

The qualities of a corpse are forced upon a visible living target. The subject begins to rot, fester, and decay in whatever ways the necromancer thinks appropriate. Food tastes like ashes, water does not quench thirst, and their body is numb to all physical pleasures. They suffer a -2 penalty to all social skill checks due to their repugnance. This transformation does not inflict physical injury, but it makes the target's life an utterly joyless misery until it is dispelled or the necromancer lifts the curse. Creatures with more hit dice than the necromancer has levels can make a Physical save to resist the curse.

Forgetting the Grave

Level 3

A necromancer can temporarily suspend the mortality of a willing target within sight. For one round per Necromancer level, the creature simply cannot die, no matter how drastic their injuries. Those reduced to zero hit points lose their Move action each turn but can continue to act otherwise; if such a target is damaged yet again, they must make a Physical saving throw each time or become incapable of movement until healed. At the spell's end targets reduced to zero hit points are Mortally Wounded; those that have been dismembered or otherwise slaughtered beyond the hope of survival die instantly.

Merge Souls

Level 3

By molding the plasmic stuff of life force, the necromancer can create a bond between two willing or helpless targets. These subjects must be close enough for the necromancer to touch; thereafter, for as long as the spell is in effect, the two creatures pool their hit points. Injuries to either subtract from this pool, and neither dies until it is reduced to zero, whereupon both are Mortally Wounded. They can communicate telepathically at will while the spell is in effect. The power ends at daybreak; if dispelled sooner, the remaining pool is split proportionately.

Boneshaper

Level 4

The clay of flesh and bone run obediently to the will of the necromancer. Whether living or undead, a willing or helpless victim under the effects of this spell can be reshaped into any roughly-equivalent form with an hour's work. Limbs can be added or removed and existing tissue can be recolored, re-textured, or rearranged to the necromancer's wishes. Perfect imitation of a particular creature requires a Dex/Magic skill check against difficulty 10. This spell is limited in the physical changes it can effect; a bonus of +1 can be added to modifier of Charisma or a physical attribute at the cost of a -1 penalty to the modifier of one of the same attributes, to a maximum of +2 or -2. This spell lasts until the necromancer lifts it or it is dispelled.

Raise Grave Knight

Level 4

The corpse used for this spell must be of a relatively powerful creature with at least four hit dice or levels. The result is much like that of the *Raise Corpse* spell, but this undead servitor is much stronger, with 4 HD, AC 15, a Move of 40'/action, a +1 skill bonus, saves of 13+, Instinct 0, Morale of 12, and a melee attack of +6/1d10, assuming it doesn't use a normal weapon. It is fully intelligent and self-willed, albeit utterly devoted to its creator, and it remembers a significant amount about its prior life. A grave knight regains all lost hit points at dusk each day, assuming it's not destroyed. A caster may have only one grave knight active at a time. One that has been reduced to zero hit points is destroyed and can only be rebuilt with a month of painstaking repair and re-enchantment.

Call of the Tomb

Level 5

The necromancer invokes the inescapable urge for self-dissolution within the substance of all that exists, amplifying the weight of their own mortality. All enemy creatures within forty feet are affected. Targets can make a Physical saving throw to resist, in which case the effects last only one round, otherwise lasting for one round per caster level. During this time all attacks made against the victims automatically hit and all damage dice they suffer are maximized. Any special defenses they may have against mundane weapons or certain types of injury are negated while the spell is on them.

Everlasting

Level 5

The spell may be triggered as an Instant action by the caster, imparting a burst of unquenchable life force to all allied creatures within 50 feet. For the next five rounds, no affected ally can be reduced below 1 hit point, regardless of the damage inflicted upon them. At the end of the spell's effect, the caster's own life energy is exhausted, leaving them with only 1 hit point. A creature can benefit from this spell no more than once per day.



VOWED

Innumerable sects of bodily adepts can be found throughout Latter Earth, each determined to master the hidden capabilities of their body and spirit. Some focus on a religious or philosophical dedication to the task, while others see only practical benefit in honing their bodies to a pitch of superhuman prowess. These “Vowed” are those men and women who have attained some measure of success in their quest.

The ancient Legacy was tuned to provide numerous benefits and augmentations to human beings. Despite the interference of the Outsiders and the inevitable corruption of eons, some threads of this ancient power still remain, and the Vowed practice secret techniques for awakening this power within them.

Not all of these sects do so through innocent means of meditation, training, and diet. Some employ terrible rituals of blood and unclean sorcery to imbue their adepts with supernatural power, while others have made certain pacts with Outsiders or stranger entities in order to get the help they need to awaken their strength. Savage brawlers and bestial warriors are as often found among the Vowed as are serene ascetics and philosophers.

Vowed sects are commonly found as guardians to some powerful organization, perhaps as royal guards or temple defenders for a faith. A few are wholly independent orders, perhaps dedicated to some religious or philosophical quest or else a secular power that the locals look to for defense and lordship. Occasionally the lines blur, with temple priests becoming mundane lords as well as spiritual leaders.

Vowed are usually trained in monasteries or retreats dedicated to that purpose. A strict hierarchy of masters and disciples is common to most sects, and many members might spend their entire lives laboring on behalf of the sect’s faith or political interests. Some Vowed are

knocked loose from their former homes by the vagaries of chance, however, and must set out alone to avenge a ruined monastery or slain master... or escape the censure of instructors who find them unfit to represent the order to the outside world.

VOWED BENEFITS

The Vowed class exists only as a partial Mage class, to be taken by an Adventurer along with another partial class. Thus, a Partial Warrior/Partial Vowed might be a hardened temple warrior-monk, a Partial Expert/Partial Vowed might be a sage teacher of religious or philosophical truths, and a Partial Elementalist/Partial Vowed might be a mountain sage who wields the elemental forces of nature. Regardless of classes, a Vowed’s hit dice can’t be worse than 1d6 per level thanks to *Martial Style*.

All Vowed gain a non-combat bonus skill appropriate to their order, acquiring it at level-0, or level-1 if they already have it at level-0. Orders that focus on physical training might grant Exert, while scholarly ones might give Know, religious ones Pray, or occult sects grant Magic. You may pick whatever non-combat skill suits your order, assuming the GM finds it reasonable.

Vowed do not learn how to cast spells. Instead, they refine their inner powers and physical capabilities. These arts are too precise and delicate to bear the encumbrance of heavy clothing, armor, or shields, and cannot be used when so burdened. The *Armored Magic* Focus can mitigate this, but Vowed are all trained in effective unarmed defense techniques.

At first level, a Vowed gains the *Martial Style*, *Unarmed Might*, and *Unarmored Defense* arts, in addition to one more art of their choice as given on the adjacent list. Further advancement will grant additional arts, though once chosen they cannot be changed.

Partial Vowed

Level	Punch Hit Bonus	Punch Damage	Punch Shock	Arts Gained
1	+0	1d6	1/15	Martial Style, Unarmed Might, Unarmed Defense, and Any One
2	+1	1d6	2/15	Any One
3	+1	1d8	2/15	
4	+2	1d8	2/15	Any One
5	+2	1d10	2/15	Any One
6	+3	1d10	3/15	Any One
7	+3	1d10+1	3/15	
8	+4	1d10+1	3/15	Any One
9	+4	1d10+2	4/15	
10	+5	1d10+3	4/15	Any One

VOWED IN OTHER WORLDS

Bare-knuckled fighting monks and prowling ninjas are commonplaces in some campaign worlds, and the Vowed can be used to represent both archetypes, as well as any other that your specific setting might require.

The particular flavor of a given unarmed combatant can be adjusted by the other partial class they take, such as ninjas perhaps picking up the stealth and subterfuge skills of a Partial Expert, or a grimly determined order of guardian monks taking the Partial Warrior class. Monks with exceptionally strange powers may have additional art options.

ARTS OF THE VOWED

Vowed Effort is based on the skill they chose to represent their order's main focus of study, whether Exert, Know, Magic, Pray, or some more esoteric skill.

Their maximum Vowed Effort is equal to this skill level plus their best attribute modifier, whatever it may be, to a minimum of one point. All Vowed automatically gain the *Martial Style*, *Unarmed Might*, and *Unarmored Defense* arts as part of their basic training.

Martial Style: Regardless of class, your hit die can't be worse than 1d6 per level. When attacking with the Punch skill, your class hit bonus can be no worse than that of an Expert of your same character level. At third level, any attack using the Punch skill counts as a magic weapon.

Unarmed Might: Your unarmed attack damage increases as you gain levels, as noted on the chart. You may add your Punch skill to the damage done by these attacks as usual, but Foci such as *Unarmed Combatant* that replace or improve your usual Punch damage do not apply to you.

Unarmored Defense: When not wearing armor or using a shield, your base Armor Class is equal to 13 plus half your character level, rounded down.

OTHER VOWED ARTS

Brutal Counter: Commit Effort for the scene as an Instant action after resolving an enemy melee attack against you, whether it hits or misses. You may make a free physical attack against your assailant, using either a normal attack or some other offensive ability that takes no more than one Main Action to execute. You cannot use this art more than once per any given attack, but you may use it while performing a *Total Defense*.

Faultless Awareness: Your awareness is such that you cannot be surprised, and will even wake from a sound sleep in time to respond normally to some imminent peril.

Hurling Throw: After you make a successful attack, you may Commit Effort for the scene as an Instant action. The target must make a Physical saving throw or be thrown up to ten feet in any direction, falling prone on landing and suffering the damage rolled for your attack. If the Physical save is successful, the target simply takes damage as normal. This art can be used only once per round on any given target, and the target must be no larger than an ox.

The Inward Eye: Commit Effort as an On Turn action. For as long as it remains Committed, you are mystically aware of your surroundings with a sense equivalent to normal eyesight regardless of darkness, obscuring mists, or your actual eyes being closed or blinded.

Leap of the Heavens: Commit Effort for the scene as a Move action to leap up to your full Move action horizontally or half that vertically. You may also

Commit Effort for the scene as an Instant action to negate falling damage, no matter the distance.

Master's Vigor: Your body retains its vigor and youthful vitality to the full normal span of your life. You regain two lost hit points per hour due to your natural restorative powers.

Mob Justice: As an Instant action, Commit Effort for the day to become impervious to the *Make'a Swarm Attack* maneuver as described on page 44. Your assailants cannot use this maneuver against you for the rest of the scene, and you become immune to Shock as long as you remain in melee with at least two foes. Making use of this benefit disrupts any spellcasting you may attempt, however, due to the violent motion required.

Nimble Ascent: Commit Effort for the scene as an On Turn action. For the remainder of the scene you may move up vertical and overhanging surfaces and across difficult terrain at your full movement rate with no chance of slipping or falling, provided the surface is not glass-smooth or enchanted. You require only one free hand to cling to a wall or ceiling.

Purified Body: You may Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action to cure any disease or poison currently affecting you, or instead to negate any need for sleep, food, water, or air for the next 24 hours.

Revivifying Breath: Commit Effort for the day as an On Turn action to heal yourself for 1d6 hit points plus your level. This healing does not increase System Strain. This ability may be used on your turn even when you are at zero hit points, but in such a case it Commits all your remaining Effort for the day. This art can be used only once per scene.

Shattering Strike: Commit Effort for the day and take a full round of motionlessness to prepare. On the next round, as a Main Action, your unarmed attack can shatter a wooden door, wooden wall, or other similar object up to a depth of one foot per level and a width sufficient to allow a man-sized creature to pass through. At fourth level this ability improves to affect even a stone wall and at seventh it can affect even a metal wall or solid iron door. The blow is useless against a target that can move, but against an immobilized creature the attack does 1d12 damage per character level.

Style Weaponry: Pick three general classes of weapons, such as "swords," "bows," "axes," "daggers," or the like. When using weapons of those classes, you may use Punch for hit rolls instead of Stab or Shoot. Your Punch skill does not add to the damage done by these weapons, however, though the benefits of *Martial Style* apply to their hit rolls.

Unobtrusive Step: You not only possess a considerable skill for disguise and obfuscation, you can become extremely hard to detect. Once per scene, you may Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action to reroll a failed Sneak skill check or skill check related to impersonating someone else.



DEVELOPING NEW SPELLS

It's a normal inclination for both GMs and players to want to add new spells to a mage's repertoire. Spell research is a normal pastime of almost all mages, and it's a useful sink for the money or magical exemplars that the wizard might have acquired. GMs should generally be willing to let PC wizards come up with new spells, provided they fit the tone of the campaign.

High Mages very rarely create New Magic spells. Their time and effort is spent unraveling the secrets of the past and trying to discover lost High Magic sorceries. Where an Elementalist might spend her time patching together fragments of other sorceries to create a spell, a High Mage would be poring over ancient books, searching for leads to new avenues of research and mentions of magic now lost to the world. Mechanically, it works out the same way; the Elementalist will eventually develop a New Magic spell of her own, while the High Mage will unearth a lost High Magic spell that fits his own desired effects.

To research a new spell, the wizard's player first writes up the spell they want to develop. The GM then checks the spell against the guidelines given below, adjusting it where it's necessary. If it passes, an appropriate level is assigned to the spell and the PC can begin the magical research process. Researching a spell requires a properly-equipped laboratory, raw materials, and time.

The laboratory must be established in a secure, serviceable room or building. A lab sufficient for researching a level 1 or 2 spell can fit into a room, one for a 3rd level spell can fit into a house, one for a 4th level spell can fit into a wizard's tower, and a lab suitable for devising a new 5th level spell needs its own subterranean research complex or similar edifice. The cost for the lab is given on the adjacent table; this does not include the price for the building itself. The necessary materials for a lab can generally be acquired in any major city, provided it's not hostile to sorcerers.

The raw materials must also be purchased in a city or gathered from ransacked lairs by adventurers. They include occult materials, esoteric creature body parts, specialized lab equipment, and obscure monographs and grimoires. These materials are used up in the process of research.

The time required for researching a spell varies with its complexity, as given on the table. A wizard can halve this time by spending twice as much on raw materials, and adventuring for certain lost grimoires or special ingredients might further decrease the time required.

A wizard can adventure and perform other tasks during their research time, including the development of Workings or the construction of magical items, but they can't simultaneously research two spells at once. Wizards kept entirely away from their labs for weeks or months at a time might suffer a halt to the work until they can get back to it.

Spell Research

Spell Level	Lab Cost	Materials Cost	Time Needed
1	50,000 sp	25,000 sp	1 month
2	125,000 sp	50,000 sp	2 months
3	250,000 sp	100,000 sp	4 months
4	500,000 sp	200,000 sp	8 months
5	1,000,000 sp	400,000 sp	2 years

Once the lab is established, the raw materials gathered, and the necessary time taken, the mage makes an Int/Magic skill check against a difficulty equal to 10 plus the spell level. If they have apprentices to assist them, they can add +1 to their skill check. Specialist mages researching New Magic in their own field add an additional +1 to the skill check, so an Elementalist researching a New Magic spell of elemental nature would get the bonus, as would a Necromancer researching a spell about undeath. Special resources or uniquely apposite grimoires gathered on an adventure might add an additional bonus to the roll.

If the roll is successful, the spell is perfected and added to the caster's grimoire. They can teach it to other wizards if they wish, or keep it to themselves. Specialist magic can only be learned by wizards of the same tradition; if they took the spell research skill check bonus, it's a specialist spell. Spells devised by High Mages are almost inevitably rediscovered High Magic and can be learned by any mage capable of casting such.

If the roll is a failure, the wizard has a choice. They can abandon their research and start over from scratch, expending new resources and time, or they can roll on the formula flaw table. This flaw becomes part of their spell, as adjusted by the GM. Some flaws might not be problematic at all; a spell only ever designed to affect the caster isn't much hindered by only being usable on willing targets. Other flaws might make the spell worthless or force the PC to start over. If the caster decides to live with the flaw and continue research, they can spend half the required research time and make a new skill check at a cumulative +1 bonus, with no need to spend additional resources.

A determined and unlucky mage may repeat this process several times, accruing new flaws each time and increasing their bonus until they eventually come up with a functioning spell. It may be so gnarled by flaws as to be scarcely recognizable as their original intent, but they can add it to their grimoire all the same.

NEW SPELL CRITERIA

When planning out your new spell, you should keep the following basic principles in mind. They are not iron laws to be followed in all situations, but a spell that breaks one of these rules should be inspected very carefully. Don't worry about trying to balance spells for the abstract masses; worry about balancing them for the specific people and situations at your table. If you know that a particular player is a bad match for a particular spell effect, then don't approve it, even if the effect itself seems innocuous.

Spells should not substitute for other classes. If a spell gives a mage the combat prowess of a Warrior or substitutes for an arbitrary selection of skills, it's too much. For specific groups, make sure that a spell doesn't substitute for the main concept of another PC in the party; if another PC's concept is that of a gifted musician, don't allow new spells that make the wizard a supernatural singer. Keep a special eye out for summoning spells, as any summoned creature that's remotely comparable to even a lower-level Warrior needs to come with serious drawbacks in usability or duration.

Spells should not offer simple numeric bonuses. A spell might add a bonus to hit rolls or damage rolls as a minor consequence of its effect, but a spell fundamentally made to increase a score or add a bonus to something should not be approved. Magic is meant to create impossible effects and alter the ground rules of a situation. If it simply amplifies the existing abilities of the group, it changes nothing in actual play.

Spells should not offer cheap and easy combat damage. No mage can cast very many spells each day, but it's important that the combat spells they do have be heavy, loud, clumsy things rather than easy magical bolts of unavoidable damage. Area-effect spells should not normally be able to exclude friendlies from their damage. If the spell's damaging effect is clean and simple, it should only affect one target. Think of mages as artillery rather than snipers; when they hit something, they tend to hit everything around it, too.

Spells should not create permanent magical effects or valuable matter. Any lasting changes the spell creates need to be sustainable by the existing situation. Growing plants in earth is one thing, but growing them on bare rock is something that should be a temporary effect. Creating rocks isn't much of an issue, but creating lumps of gold shouldn't be a persistent change.

Spells that buff a target shouldn't last more than a scene. This rule is somewhat looser, as buff spells that are intended to make the target viable in a hostile environment, such as water-breathing or cold-climate survival, might last for a full day. Their purpose is to make an adventure possible, so making them last as long as the adventure is reasonable. Buff spells that add new powers or benefits to a target shouldn't last longer than a scene, however, or else they tend to turn into permanent powers that just happen to cost a slot.

d10

Formula Flaws

- | | |
|----|--|
| 1 | The spell can only target the caster. |
| 2 | The spell only works on willing targets. |
| 3 | Your prior work is mistaken; the formula is not changed, but you don't get the cumulative +1 bonus on the research roll for this or prior research continuations. |
| 4 | The spell can only target people other than the caster. |
| 5 | The spell is unusually slow, taking at least a Main Action to cast, or two Main Actions over the course of two consecutive rounds if it already takes a Main Action to cast. |
| 6 | The spell is very draining, exhausting two spells worth of energy for the day instead of one. |
| 7 | The spell inflicts a severe backlash on the caster, adding 1d4 System Strain to them. If this maximizes their System Strain, they fall unconscious for ten minutes and can't cast this spell again until some System Strain is lost. |
| 8 | The spell is more difficult than it seems, being one level higher than expected. This doesn't increase the research costs or time, but if you can't cast a spell of that level, the entire project fails. |
| 9 | The spell is simply unreliable in its effects; whenever it's cast, roll 1d6. On a 1, the spell fizzles uselessly and the casting slot is wasted. |
| 10 | The whole effort was a tragic mistake. All progress and research materials are lost and everything must be done over from the start. |

Spells should not be petty. Latter Earth does not have much in the way of "trivial" magic spells, and cantrips that perform some minor change should not be allowed unless you want to change the general flavor of magic as a whole. Every spell should do something *big*, with even the smallest damaging spell capable of killing someone and the least magical effect having some degree of wonder about it.

Steal spells from existing games. You can usually borrow spells from other old-school games or the classic TSR role-playing games of the eighties and nineties with impunity, but halve their levels to figure out where they'd fit in *Worlds Without Number*. Thus, a 9th level spell in the original game might be a 5th level spell in this one. First-level spells should be upgraded if you import them, because most 1st level spells are too weak to fit well in this world. Keep in mind the other principles on this list when importing spells, however, as other games rarely follow all of them.



BUILDING MAGICAL WORKINGS

As potent as the Legacy is, it can be no surprise that various sorcerers and artificers have channeled it into useful edifices and standing magical effects. In the jargon of wizards, a **Working** is any stationary, persistent magical effect or structure, such as a magical ever-flowering spring, an array of heatless eternal lamps, or a persistent curse that blights all within its reach. Unlike a conventional magical item, a Working cannot be moved from its set location, and unlike a spell it will normally persist until damage or thaumic decay finally disperse it.

Workings come in five commonly-recognized tiers: trivial, minor, major, great, and supreme. Trivial Workings might be some minor magic like an enchanted light source, while a supreme effort might transform a whole city into a flying metropolis. While lesser Workings are still possible for skilled and erudite mages of Latter Earth, supreme Workings are too mighty to be accomplished by anyone short of a Legate. Examples persist from the former ages of the world, and surviving supreme Workings can be wonders renowned throughout whole nations, but they are beyond duplication by conventional sorcery.

A Working requires a skilled mage, a great deal of resources, and a considerable amount of time. Details can vary based on the arcane suitability of the landscape or especially powerful, useful components, but even a trivial Working is no minor labor.

To create the Working, the architect must first be a spellcaster of at least 6th level, whether a full Mage or a Partial Mage. Mage classes that do not cast spells cannot normally create Workings, as their magic is insufficiently flexible. Less-accomplished spellcasters also lack the practical experience necessary to mold the powers.

The architect then decides what exactly the Working should do. The table on the opposite page gives examples of different Workings and the effects they might produce. The player involved discusses any custom ideas with the GM, using the examples as guidelines. A single Working may involve multiple effects, but they should be closely aligned; enchantments that provide a magical spring, hot water, enchanted lamps, and a pleasant climate might all be established as part of the same housekeeping Working, but placing a ward against devils and a magical garden at the same time might not be so plausible.

The GM then decides the total difficulty of the Working by adding up the difficulty point cost of each element of it. The adjacent table gives common ranges for each degree of difficulty, and the GM should pick a number that sounds right; the pettiest of petty Trivial magics might be 1 point, while something that could maybe even be Minor in strength would be 4 points. The total cost of the Working is whatever element costs most plus half the rest, rounded up. Thus, if some 10-point major effect also had a 3-point trivial effect and 8-point minor effect bundled with it, the whole would have a difficulty of 16 points.

Magical Working Costs

Degree	Difficulty Points	Area Affected	Difficulty Multiplier
Trivial	1-4	Room	x1
Minor	4-8	Building	x4
Major	8-16	Village	x16
Great	16-32	City	x64
Supreme	33-64*	Region	x256

* Only Legates can fashion supreme Workings

This difficulty is then multiplied by the area the Working will affect. If the magic spring merely pours a small stream of water into the kitchen cellar, the area might only be that of a Room; if the stream was meant to provide a moat around a wizard's keep, it would affect a Building, or perhaps even a Village-sized area. If the spring was to irrigate miles of surrounding countryside, it would affect a whole Region, and would probably be a great Working to boot, if not supreme. The difficulty total is multiplied by the given multiplier of the biggest area affected, so if the 16-point example above affected the whole wizard's tower, its final difficulty would be 64 points.

The architect must then demonstrate that they can actually *design* such a Working. A given designer multiplies their character level by their Magic skill level times two. Thus, a 6th level High Mage with Magic-3 skill would have a total of 36. If this total is equal or greater than the Working's difficulty, they can establish it alone. If it's at least half the difficulty, they can build it if they can find other mages to help them and make up the missing points. If it's less than half the difficulty, the whole enterprise is too difficult for them to envision.

If the Working is designed properly and enough help is had, it can be constructed at a cost of 1,000 silver pieces per point of difficulty and a time cost of one month, plus one week per five points of difficulty or fraction thereof. If the cost is doubled, the work can be done in half this time. Note that this construction only applies to the *magical* components of the Working; if the mage means to enchant a wall, the wall must already be built. A mage can generally adventure and do other things while completing a Working, but if they are taken away from the site for too long, the work may halt in their absence.

While Workings are generally very durable, intentional sabotage of critical points or the slow decay of ages can end up corrupting or destroying them, sometimes with catastrophic results. It is for this reason that many of the Workings found in ancient Deeps or forgotten ruins are dangerous or perverse, and many nations that could at least theoretically afford the construction of Workings avoid making use of them.

Type	Example Elements of a Working
Trivial	Bar ordinary vermin from the area
Trivial	Create lights, or illusions that are obviously illusions
Trivial	Destroy wastes, dusts, or other nonliving matter
Trivial	Heats or chills things within normal climate ranges
Trivial	Preserve foodstuffs indefinitely
Trivial	Provide cooking heat in specific places within the area
Trivial	Provide plumbing or ventilation, assuming water and air supplies exist
Minor	Communicate between points in the area
Minor	Create convincing illusions that are still disproven by close interaction
Minor	Create guardian entities of limited intellect equivalent to a 2 hit die combatant
Minor	Create water or a common inedible material
Minor	Improve natural healing within the area, doubling natural System Strain and hit point recovery
Minor	Inflict minor damage on targets that trigger a trap or are struck by defenses, 1 d6 to 2d6
Minor	Maintain the area magically, repairing wear and minor damage over time
Minor	Provide simple motive force for an existing object with basic controls, though no intelligent response
Minor	Sustain a livable temperature in the area despite any normal exterior climate variations
Minor	Ward off a single type of intruder that can be described in no more than a sentence. Such targets must make a Mental save to enter
Major	Create foodstuffs that sustain the eater even if they later leave the affected area
Major	Create guardian entities with some modest special abilities equivalent to a 4 hit die combatant
Major	Create illusions so perfect that close interaction just grants a Mental save to realize their nature
Major	Grant compatibility with an environment to all occupants, like underseas, lava pits, or freezing heights
Major	Immunize occupants from the effects of diseases
Major	Induce a subtle mental influence to subjects that fail a Mental save, causing them to do or not do something unless it is hazardous to them
Major	Inflict significant damage on a target, 4d6 or 5d6
Major	Provide motive force for an existing object in a complex way, with intelligent adherence to its purpose
Major	Sustain a certain number of inhabitants without need for food or drink
Major	Teleport things within the affected area according to its rules
Major	Ward off several types of intruders as per the Minor effect, or make the ward so strong against a single type that it must be suppressed if they are to enter
Great	Create a powerful guardian with several impressive magical powers and 8 or more hit dice
Great	Create some moderately valuable material
Great	Distort internal spaces, shrinking or expanding them by up to a factor of 20
Great	Induce a powerful mental influence on targets that fail a Mental save, even a complex command
Great	Inflict lethal damage on a target, 8d6 to 10d6, or a save-or-die effect
Great	Ward it so tightly that only particular subjects are allowed to enter, while others must suppress the Working
Supreme	Affect the flow of time within the area
Supreme	Utterly mentally enslave subjects, perhaps even without a Mental save, forcing them to comply with a certain intent even if it's suicidal
Supreme	Generate a small army of 2 hit die guardians to defend it
Supreme	Imbue a structure or area with the ability to fly freely
Supreme	Implant an artificial mind in a structure to control and monitor it



CREATING MAGIC ITEMS

The forging of magical artifacts is not unknown on Lat-ter Earth, though the ease of the process varies greatly from place to place. Some regions are largely desolate of the subtle thaumic currents and special environments needed to set an item's enchantments, while others are particularly friendly to the process. A GM will have to decide on their own whether their campaign setting will allow mage PCs to create magical items.

Unlike Workings, which are comfortably stationary, a portable magic item directly increases the power of the bearer when they're out adventuring. Allowing the creation of magic items lets the party convert treasure into direct personal power, which increases the consequences should they find "too much" treasure in their ventures. If magic items can only ever be found, salvaged, or created by specialist mages who are no use at adventuring then the GM has a much better grip on power inflation. Conversely, a lot of GMs and Mage players are very fond of creating their own magical devices, and may not be satisfied by the use of Workings alone. For most campaigns, a middle ground is recommended.

All permanent magical items are difficult to make. Even if the item is nothing more than a tankard that keeps its contents perpetually chilled, making that tankard is every bit as difficult as forging an enchanted sword. As a consequence, very few sorcerers bother to make petty items; if it's going to be as hard to make a trifling token as a significant one, why make trifles?

Magical items are exceedingly expensive to build. The rare components, expensive rituals, and costly processes involved eat up vast amounts of silver and great labor on the part of the mage. These components must be bought at some major city or salvaged from the Deeps or ruins that the PCs are exploring. They form many of the same components that are used in building Workings or researching new spells, so the same general pool of magical components can be used for any of those purposes.

Magical items are also complex and difficult to create. A novice mage cannot fashion them and even an expert might find it difficult to get an item to come out just right. Flaws can creep into the construction process, forcing the PC to either start over or cope with an item that isn't exactly what was intended.

CREATING THE ITEM

To build a magic item, the player first describes what it is that the item is supposed to do. The player might want to build an item from the Treasures section of this book, or one from another old-school game, or perhaps one completely of their own devising. It's up to the GM to decide whether or not the item fits with their campaign and is an acceptable introduction.

For item designs, it's recommended that the GM be careful not to allow magic items that simply solve whole categories of problems. A set of magic earplugs that make it impossible to hear lies may seem clever, but it also immediately solves any challenge revolving around detecting deceit. Boots that grant perpetual flight, apotropaic wands that banish specific types of creatures, and other items that simply remove certain problems from the party's concerns should probably be denied. Even if they're charged or limit-use items, they'll probably be available whenever the party *really* needs them, which means those challenges that would otherwise be the most critical become the ones they most easily bypass.

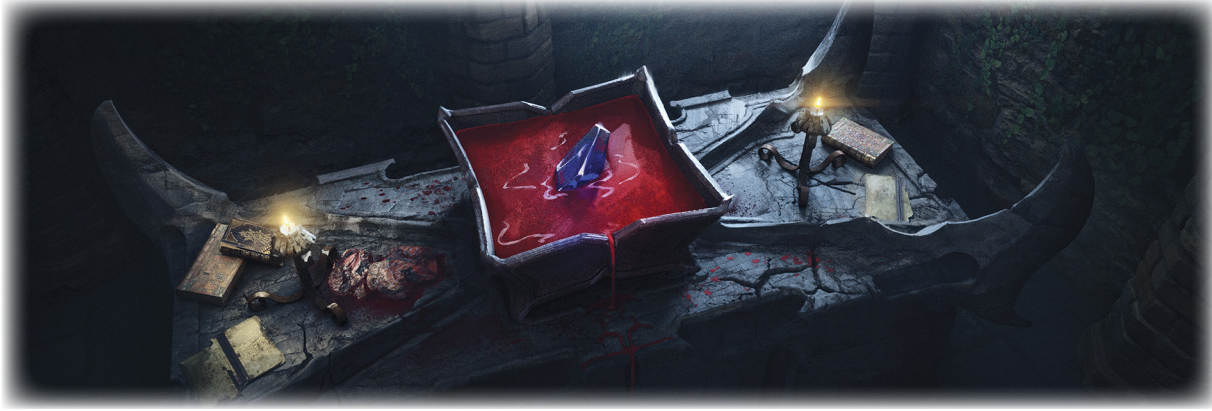
A GM should also be careful about items that simply add bonuses to the PC's rolls, whether skill checks or combat rolls. Magical weapons and armor do exist, and there are some items that do simply add numbers to the PC, but these should be avoided in other cases. There's a reason that most veteran Warriors are eager to find a magical weapon; such a weapon simply makes them better at their most important function. If other items exist that simply increase critical numbers, then the other players will feel obligated to hunt them down.

If the item's concept passes muster, the GM should compare it to the adjacent table to see what kind of price and minimum difficulty level should be required to make it. Spellcasting wizards can generally make any kind of magic item, while non-casters such as Vowed or Healers are usually restricted to making items appropriate to their particular concepts, whether those are magical scriptures or healing elixirs. A GM should always feel free to adjust prices and difficulties to reflect their own sense of what's appropriate for their campaign.

In addition to the minimum level and money involved, permanent magic items always require at least

Magic Item Creation Costs

Type of Item	Creation Difficulty	Creation Cost in SP	Creation Time
A single-use item, such as an elixir or calyx	8–10	250–2,500	1 week
A multi-use item that still contains limited charges, such as a wand	9–11	5,000–25,000	1 month
A low-powered but permanent magic item, such as a <i>Sword +1</i>	10	12,500	1 month
A significant item that creates a situation-changing effect	12	50,000	3 months
A powerful item or one with multiple significant abilities	14	250,000	6 months



one adventure to acquire the necessary components. The wizard will have researched the item sufficiently to know where they need to go and what they need to fetch, but it will always be dangerous and difficult to do so. Very capable underlings or hired adventurers might be able to fetch the required component, but it's up to the GM whether such efforts are successful. From a GM's perspective, this required adventure is to ensure that a wizard who makes a permanent magic item provides at least one session worth of adventure grist in exchange for the new gear, and it also ensures that not too many permanent magic items will be made unless the party agrees to constantly be out adventuring for parts.

If the creator is capable, the coin is at hand, and any adventuring components have been fetched, the mage can attempt to make the item. They spend the time given on the adjacent table and then make an Int/Magic skill check against the appropriate difficulty. If they're making a batch of limited-use items, such as a batch of magic potions, they can make two doses for a +1 difficulty or four doses for a +2 difficulty. If they have an apprentice to aid them, they can add +1 to their skill check.

If the check is a success, the item is made. If it's a failure, they have a choice; they can start over from the beginning, spending the money and time anew, though not needing to repeat any adventure the item might have required. They can then make a second attempt at creating the item. If they are reluctant to do this, they can roll on the Item Flaw table, suffering that hindrance to the item's eventual effect as adjusted by the GM. If that flaw isn't intolerable, they may spend half the time they originally took to make another skill check to make the item at a cumulative +1 bonus. No additional coin need be paid. They can repeat this process, adding a new flaw each time and paying half the original time, until they either succeed or the flaws become intolerable.

A mage can generally keep adventuring while crafting a magic item, as the work doesn't eat up all their spare time. Particularly massive or powerful magic items might require the use of a dedicated laboratory, forcing the wizard to remain there while the work is underway lest the process be spoiled. Any special tools or resources such as a laboratory requires are assumed to be part of the item's creation cost.

d12

Magic Item Design Flaws

- 1 The magic item can only be used by the first person to touch it after creation.
- 2 The item's magic can only affect the bearer or user.
- 3 The item actually has the exact opposite effect as the one intended for it.
- 4 The item is very slow to activate, not taking effect until the round after it's triggered or used.
- 5 The item is very loud and visually showy when deployed, and continues to be loud until it's no longer used.
- 6 The item will only benefit or function for a given user 1d6 times before becoming inert for them thereafter.
- 7 The item becomes non-magical if the creator dies.
- 8 The item drains the user's life force, adding one System Strain the first time it's used each day. It won't function without this drain.
- 9 The item bonds to its users; if separated from the item, the user gains one System Strain each day until the item's destroyed or recovered. The item forms only one bond at a time.
- 10 The item exudes a psychic pressure that makes it impossible not to notice and recognize as a magical object so long as it is carried by the user. Stealth is impossible while carrying it.
- 11 The enchantment is unreliable; the first time it is used in a day, roll 1d6. On a 1, it's devoid of magic for the rest of the day. Single-use or charged items waste the use or charge.
- 12 The whole plan was flawed from the start. All time and resources spent have been wasted, and everything must begin again from scratch.



THE WORLD OF THE LATTER EARTH

The Latter Earth is unknown in its whole; some sages would go so far as to say it is unknowable due to the existence of the Iterums and the chronospatial damage inflicted by the decaying Legacy and the spite of the ancient dead. Even so, something can be said about some of it, and this chapter will discuss what a GM must know about its Gyre region order to set a campaign within it.

STARTING A GYRE CAMPAIGN

To begin a campaign in the Gyre, a new GM should take the following steps.

Read this chapter. Read the following pages and get a basic grasp of the Gyre setting and its major nations.

Choose an initial campaign flavor. What do you want the first sessions of the campaign to be about? Dungeon-crawling? Urban adventures? Political scheming? It's unlikely the whole campaign will stick to this kind of activity, but your first session or two will be about it, until the players get their own ideas on where to take the game.

Pick a suitable nation or location. If you want to play a game of mercenary treasure-hunters, then Llaigis is a good choice. If you want to start the PCs out with exploring an *arratu*, then plant them near the Ashblight or some other badland. Don't worry about the specific details of location or what particular city or hex they might be in. Just choose a general area.

Create the introductory adventure. Using the tools in the adventure creation chapter starting on page 222, build an introductory adventure for the players, something simple that should only take them a session to resolve.

As you create the adventure, you'll start to need details. If the adventure is near a village, you'll need to name and define the village. If the adventure is in a Deep, you'll need to locate the Deep on the map. You might need a local lord, or a village priest, or a particular wicked wizard. Using the background info for the nation or location you just picked, fill out these blanks with names and places that make sense for the area.

Thus, instead of making all these sandbox details and then creating an adventure that uses them, you work backwards from the adventure to ensure that you only have to create content that will matter in play.

Round out the background details. You've established all the facts important to your adventure, but there are probably other details or bits of local information that are likely to matter in play. Take a moment to fill in important facts the PCs may need to interact with. Planting healing-capable shrines, naming a few local grandees or wealthy merchants, getting a sketch map of the area around the adventure, and cooking up a few obvious next-adventure hooks are all worthwhile.

Once the PCs finish the introductory adventure, just get them to tell you their next intended exploit, and you can repeat the process to be ready for the next game.

GENRES IN THE GYRE

The Gyre was built to provide support for a wide range of campaign styles and flavors. Some sorts of play are easily found almost anywhere in the region, while more specific flavors can be found in particular kingdoms or *arratus*.

Classic dungeon-crawling can be had almost anywhere. The ancient Deeps dug by the Outsiders litter the land, and new ones are discovered regularly by explorers and excavators. Seemingly-abandoned Deeps might suddenly reveal access to some deeper, unexplored region, while the ancient cities of the Gyre are often built atop older, buried settlements that still hold their treasures.

Wilderness exploration works well in the Black Spine mountains, the *arratu* wastelands, the jungles of Lost Emed, or the eastern border regions of the Gyre map. The simplest way to add some unknown wilds is to stretch out the southern border of the map and fill it with whatever terrain suits you, studding it all with the ruins of the lost provinces of the old Vothite Republic. Even players who read this chapter carefully will have no idea of what to expect in such lands.

Pulp sword & sorcery fits in numerous places, but has a special home in Llaigis, where steely-thewed warriors and sinister sorcerers are both readily found. The countless petty warlords and chieftains provide a steady supply of antagonists and patrons, and the decadence of their rulers offers a convenient source of plundered loot.

Steampunk or other tech-flavored play can fit in Thur, where the ancient Workings still provide thaumic energy and the Gentry provide a classist society. GMs who want to play up the tropes of gritty industrial labor and wondrous magic-tech can emphasize those traits in Thur and its culture.

Court intrigue is particularly supported in Ka-Adun and Emed-Kist. In the former, a withered class of dispossessed nobles struggle to gain access to the limited supply of tribute and taxes that the Hepatizon Throne still commands, while in Emed-Kist the Great King must perpetually balance the tensions and hostilities of innumerable petty lords and Darian officials.

Fantasy Wild West adventures are easily found in New Voth, where brash commoners are eager to pioneer dangerous regions and now-abandoned noble holdings. Law is little in evidence in these lands and self-reliance is the rule. An adventurer's worth is what they make of themselves, and there's no cavalry coming to save them.

Domain play is an option for any adventurer willing to become valuable to a local lord. All of the kingdoms have enough poorly-held or dangerous land that their rulers would have a reason to grant some to a strong subordinate capable of taming it. Adventurers who would rather not bow to an earthly lord can seize land in Lost Emed or reclaim some stretch of xenoformed *arratu*, leaving their ostensible rulers to accept an accomplished fact.



- CAPITAL
- MAJOR CITY
- RUIN OR DEEP
- 1 HEX = 6 MILES

THE CARCERAL SEA



OF FORMER DAYS

The region now known as the Gyre is a relatively isolated segment of the greater continent of Gyaros, once held under the rule of the mighty Hepatizon Throne and its Brass Hegemony, but now a troubled welter of quarreling subject-states and trackless *arratu* wastelands. The formerly docile subject states now have no fear of the seemingly-indifferent Reaping King, and concern themselves with the inevitable struggle over which is to be the new hegemon of the Gyre.

Records of this region are relatively well-supported, extending back for some two thousand years to an indeterminate period during the rule of the sorcerer-kings. These ancient lords had risen from the Deeps with their subject peoples once the rule of the Outsiders had been cast down, and throughout the Latter Earth they formed the nuclei around which new nations formed and grew. Their mighty sorceries and Deep-born kindred soon overwhelmed the remnant bands of surface-living human rebels and Outsider colonies that yet remained.

More than two thousand years ago, the whole of the Gyre was under the rule of the heirs of the Sorcerer-Queen Voth. The Vothite Empire was one born of terrible mental sorceries, with its nobility divided into "thought houses" dedicated to the furtherance of specific ideals or aesthetics. Their struggles were expressed in the form of arcane persuasions and elegant works of alien art, artifacts and spells that could bend the minds of onlookers into agreement with the values of the thought-house that constructed them.

The whole of the Gyre was riddled with grand monuments, cerebral mandalas, and infectious meme-chimes, all beneath the implacable will of the Mentarch. Even war lost its old trappings as the Vothite houses battled with symbols and artifacts to sway the opposing force, until one side came to see the transcendent correctness of the other and joyously joined with them in pursuit of a magnificent truth.

Vothite commoners were considered little better than animals, too stupid and imperceptive to truly apprehend the deep truths that each thought-house pursued. Their thoughts were transparently obvious to the least Vothite noble, but the mind-influencing magic used by the nobility was less effective against subjects that had not been exposed to the same complex inventory of symbolism and philosophical thought that the gentry of the thought-houses embraced. The rare commoner who was deemed capable of appreciating the deeper truths of reality was skimmed off by some ambitious thought-house, while rebels and malcontents were identified at a glance and disposed of with great rapidity by mind-shackled enforcers.

The Vothite Empire fell some two thousand years ago to a revolution from within. The precise mechanism of this fall is unclear at this late date. Some records suggest it was the product of a renegade thought-house that

rejected Vothite philosophy, while other artifacts imply a commoner rebellion that was somehow invisible to the Vothite nobility until it was too late for their enforcers to crush it. Some credit the interference of Outsider remnants, believing that they aided the rebels in order to eliminate the threat that the Vothites presented to them. A few even believe it was a relatively peaceful transition initiated by a thought-house that successfully imposed its will on the other Vothite nobility.

After an uncertain transition period, the next major hegemon of the Gyre was the Vothite Republic, a polity that was chiefly united in its absolute rejection of mind-sorcery of all kinds. The remnant thought-houses were either exterminated, dissolved, or driven into provincial exile as refugees or hidden cells. The various groups of commoners that had once made up the Empire were now left to their own devices, with minimal control exerted by a central government that could require very little of the provinces that they were not willing to give.

It was during this period that the Anak threat to the south became more pronounced. Several southern border provinces of the Empire were entirely destroyed by the Blighted or by the unchecked expansion of *arratu* land, and it was only after the loss of a considerable portion of the old Empire that the remaining provinces were convinced of the necessity of more active support. Together, their resources stopped the Anakim at the southern border of the Emedian province of Emed-Dar, setting the stage for an unending cycle of periodic Anakim invasions and constant border fighting.

This uneasy state of affairs persisted for centuries, the Republic never mustering the strength to truly drive back the Anakim and never quite allowing the Blighted to consume another state. The limited political capital possessed by the central government was constantly invested in getting the various provinces to continue their military contributions, leaving them practically independent for all other purposes. Petty wars between the states sapped the Republic's vitality, and such disruptions as the Rule of Shun, the Perfected Circle, the Free Cities Compact, and the Time of Three Senates limited its cohesion. Old Vothite infrastructure and the Workings of prior ages of sorcerer-kings were left to slowly decay and be forgotten, casualties of the constant, grinding expense of the war with the Blighted and the struggle to hold the Gyre together.

Matters changed a thousand years ago, when the immortal Reaping King crossed the Carceral Sea and made his landing on the Republic's northern coast. The origins of his power were complex, but are not pertinent here; it is enough that he landed with several thousand devoted followers and the dread might of the Black Brass Legion.

The Legion was unstoppable, rolling over the northern provinces league by league. While the numbers of these manlike automatons were never great, no ordinary

army had a hope of victory against them, and the few military resources that the Republic possessed that might have stood a chance were immured on the southern border, fighting the Anakim. The advance of the Reaping King was slow and methodical, culling out portions of the Republic, establishing his own followers as governors, and ensuring the docile obedience of the new lands before advancing further south. At times he even supported Republican troops against the Anakim, all the better to ensure that the Gyre did not collapse completely before he could take control of it.

His final victory came some eight hundred years ago, when the last Senate of the Republic voted to accept his rule. Resistance was pointless by that time, with the very existence of the Republic hinging on the Reaping King's forbearance and the protection of the Black Brass Legion. With the dissolution of the Vothite Republic, the Reaping King was the unquestioned immortal ruler of all the human lands of the Gyre.

His rule was a relatively light-handed one. Tributes of labor and goods were exacted for his grand capital of Ka-Adun, and a quota of slaves were required to staff his human armies and serve the noble families of his first followers, but such demands were considerably less than what he could have extracted from the beaten Vothites. The governors of the provinces were allowed a relatively free hand with their people, provided the growing city-state of Ka-Adun received its expected tributes, and the strength of the Black Brass Legion ensured a modicum of peace on the border and between the states.

The Reaping King remained a mystery to most, however, dwelling always within his folded palace in vast Ka-Adun and communicating with the outside world through slave-officials and favored Adunic nobles. His wives were in the thousands, but only a handful ever saw him, and no true progeny were ever recorded. Only on certain ritual occasions were even the nobility permitted to gaze upon their lord, and the commoners were allowed to know him only by the commands he handed down.

It was not until two hundred years ago that the Reaping King's rule was truly shaken. One of the periodic Anak invasions erupted from the south, but this time the Black Brass Legion was present only in trivial numbers. The pleas from the viceroy of Emed were ignored, and his entire province of Emed-Dar was wiped out by the exultant Blighted. Only the desperate efforts of the warriors of Llaigis, the followers of the Sixteenth Prophet, and the hastily-gathered forces of the other provinces were able to hold the Anakim back from further conquests.

The questions that flew north to Ka-Adun never received useful answers. In desperation, the provincial governors curtailed their tributes to Ka-Adun, pleading the necessities of war; when no chastisement came, this curtailment became permanent. The rulers obeyed the other commands that came from the Hepatizon Throne, but their traditional attendance at the Reaping King's court was gradually omitted, and in time even their lesser obediences were performed less fastidiously.

EPOCHS OF THE GYRE

The common epoch of the region is the landing of the Reaping King in Ka-Adun; dates are thus measured either AL, After Landing, or BL, Before Landing. The current date in the Gyre is 1055 AL.

Scholars argue over specifics, but most would place the rise of the Vothite Empire around 2500 BL, its fall and the ascent of the Republic at about 1000 BL, and the final collapse of Republican resistance in the year 241 AL. Even so, all these dates are susceptible to multiple interpretations.

This abandonment came to a head a hundred years ago, when a new Anak invasion was repelled without the slightest help from Ka-Adun or the Black Brass Legion. Infuriated by the neglect, the lords of the remaining provinces resolved to treat the Hepatizon Throne with the same indifference they had received. A few maintain polite fictions of submission, but they no longer pay the slightest attention to the wishes of the Reaping King, and the king in turn no longer sends them commands.

Were it not for Ka-Adun's importance as a port on the Carceral Sea and the taxes he takes from goods traded there, it is questionable whether he could maintain even the populated zone of his capital city. As it is, countless noble houses of the Hegemony have been thrown into dire poverty as their provincial lands are confiscated and their traditional tribute neglected. For a century they have dwindled, making do with what resources they have, until now only a handful can still maintain some pretense of their former wealth. Hegemonic nobles without such fortune have found themselves reduced to serving as advisors, tutors, and the occasional hiresword for provincial lords. The remaining open province surrounding the massive megalopolis of Ka-Adun is now a welter of petty warlords and desperate robber-princes, plundering their neighbors for the wealth to continue on a little longer.

Forty years ago a tide of war swept over the Gyre states, each of them snapping at the others to become the new hegemon of the region. The results of this Autumn War were singularly inconclusive, with borders shifting somewhat but nothing more accomplished beyond a great loss of life and a seeding of grudges. The struggle was over within a year, but it was enough to leave the successor states licking their wounds and plotting to better their position.

Now, a new season of war is feared to be at hand. The Anakim have been quiet, perhaps too quiet, and their attention has been distracted by the crusaders of their cousins in Sarul. The successor states eye each other warily, wondering which of them is to be first to declare war, and which of them might be the first to perish. And in the north, the Reaping King sits silent in his folded halls, the Black Brass Legion never departing far from the megalopolis. It is an uneasy season for all in the Gyre, and there is little that promises a kinder age to come.

THE NATIONS AND FEATURES OF THE GYRE

The following pages describe the major nations of the Gyre and their qualities. Aside from the great human polities of the region, however, there are a number of points of interest to be found. In addition, numerous small *arratus*, minor ruins, forgotten citadels, or Outsider enclaves can be found throughout the Gyre, unremarked here but of great significance to their near neighbors.

The Ashblight: A vast southern *arratu* that extends into the ancient lost provinces of the pre-Hegemony Gyre. The Anak hordes that crushed Emed-Dar poured out of the Ashblight and the losers of their endless quarrels inhabit it still. The craggy terrain is dominated by monstrous fungal growths that exhale choking, ash-like spores that root in the unfortunate or unprepared. The monstrous fauna of the *arratu* is a mix of amorphous, tentacular Outsider beasts and luckless native creatures that have been colonized by the fungus, thus rendered immortal and insane by the parasitism.

The Black Spine: A towering mountain range that marks the western edge of the Gyre. The vast height and near-impenetrable wall of the mountains catches the western rains; were it not for the constant venting of the Font on the eastern side of the mountains, much of the Gyre would be a desert. The Black Spine is riddled with ancient Outsider facilities and sorcerer-king outposts. The danger of their high peaks makes mining or herding too perilous for ordinary souls to attempt.

The Blind Marsh: A product of the Black Spine's rain-catching and a constant outflow of water from the mountain range's roots, the Blind Marsh is a boggy hell of voracious plants, venomous beasts, and amphibian abominations. Scholars believe it was once a coastal stronghold of the Polop, and some of those Outsiders and their ruins may lurk there still.

The Carceral Sea: Like most seas of the Latter Earth, sailing far on the Carceral Sea is tremendously dangerous. Huge Outsider sea-monsters prowl the waves, many of them as intelligent as humans in their own way, and the vicious Polop are jealous of intruders into their domain. Unpredictable ocean currents, lethal atmospheric disturbances, and blindly dangerous megastructures only compound the risk. Sorcerously-augmented ships might have some chance of making it across the sea, but the traders and wayfarers that ply the northern coast seldom dare to lose sight of land. Only pirates and other reckless mariners dare venture far out, and those are usually reliant on some charm or assurance that will help them dodge the inevitable sea monsters and Outsider beasts that would otherwise sink them there.

Emed-Dar: Once the jewel of the southern provinces of the Hegemony, Emed-Dar was overwhelmed by the Anakim two hundred years ago. Its fertile fields, beautiful cities, and peaceful villages were annihilated, and it was only by a desperate struggle at the Usuldarum River that the forces of Llaigis and the remaining Emedians were able to hold the line. The Anakim have ruled Emed-Dar ever since, occupying themselves chiefly in murdering each other and raiding the surrounding lands. Despite the long arm of the Ashblight that has spread into Emed-Dar, much of the land remains rich and good, should the Anak ever be driven back into the *arratu*.

The Font: A tremendous megastructure that predates even Outsider rule, the Font is a mile-wide well of perpetually-overflowing water, the drainage rolling down the eastern slopes to eventually form the headwaters of the Usuldarum River. Numerous broken control structures ring the Font, with evidence of ancient tubing suggesting that the Font was once the main water source for some long-vanished megalopolis or far-buried Deep.

Lost Emed: Emed-Dar was not the first part of Emed to be lost. In the early days of the Vothite Republic, before a stable confederacy could be achieved, Anak raiders from the Ashblight succeeded in rolling over the ancient province of Emed-Mar. The destruction of certain Vothite Workings there and the last desperate efforts of the Emedians caused an ecological eruption that turned much of the area into a steaming jungle of viciously dangerous plants and native fauna. To this day, countless Maran cities and towns remain lost within the green shadows of the place, their relics guarded by Maran automatons, furious shades, and those Anak jungle clans that have learned to adapt to the environment.

The Mirewash: The waters of the Usulmot River flow into this depression, swelled by the runoff from the Black Spine. The marshy bog has always been a favored retreat for rebels and refugees from the Reaping King's rule and today its seclusion serves to cloak a considerable number of fallen Hegemony officials and beggar-nobles. Many family treasures and stolen goods are carried into the Mirewash, but few come out without bloodshed.

The Plains of the Iron Sky: This great *arratu* has been partially dislocated from the surrounding reality; the sky within it is a perpetual shade of dull iron and the air is an unbreathable, choking haze like that favored by certain Outsiders. Only adventurers with special tools or sorcery can venture within to plunder the ruins that dot its gray, waterless sands. Not all of those ruins are human, and sages suggest that one of the ruined cities within the Plains was actually translocated from a different world.



The Rebel Coast: Once part of Ka-Adun's administrative sphere, the cities of the Rebel Coast split off over a century ago to make their own way. That way consists largely of intercline warfare, piracy, and a kaleidoscopic shift of rising and falling princes. The coastal cities send considerable trade to the First City of Ka-Adun, but the inland princelings and the machinations of the rival cities keep the coast in a constant state of low-level turmoil. Rule of the various princedoms is often far more reliant on a lord's strength of arm and powers of cunning than any purity of blood, and more than a few of the coast's rulers were once freebooters. Few last long enough to install heirs.

The Sisters: A refuge for the boldest and maddest of the Gyre's pirates, those seamen skilled enough to cross the narrows from the mainland without incident will find a few small, thickly forested islands and the single ramshackle town of Spray to serve their needs with whatever might be available. The "uninhabited" islands are favorite refuges for wizards and worse, their lairs made in the ancient ruins that are common there. Indeed, the *arratu* on the largest isle appears to be a festering mass of heaving alien life that's completely overgrown the miles-wide top of some ancient, sunken megalopolis' highest tower.

The Tombwater: The depth of the Tombwater is unknown, but scholars agree that somewhere at the bottom, some ancient pumping device is forcing a river's worth of water up to the surface. Most credit the mere as a fallen-in Deep, the miles-long tunnels and galleries of the ancient working now filled with dark, silty water. Explorers along the southern coast of the Tombwater have found numerous surface ruins from the age of the sorcerer-king, and some villages of demihumans or exiles have made homes out of these remains.

The White Waste: The climate of the Gyre is fairly temperate, being cooler in the north and somewhat hotter in the south, but the White Waste is an anomaly created by the ancient Working at its heart. Within its zone of effect the temperature is usually below freezing, with occasional thin snowfalls or white-out blizzards sweeping across the barren land. Most believe the disruption to be produced by some damaged ancient xenoforming Working, but a few claim that the waste is a product of an ancient sorcerer-king's experiment gone awry. Whatever the cause, only the desperate venture into the Waste, and then only to plunder the frozen dead of the installations and small Deeps that can be found beneath the snows.

EMED-KIST

A loosely-bound monarchy among the nations of the Gyre, Emed-Kist is ruled from the city of Medek, where the Great King deals with the numerous barons, earls, and dukes that hold ancestral fiefs throughout the kingdom. The lords are constantly conniving to weaken royal power, while the king relies on the merchants and commoners to give teeth to his pronouncements.

Emed-Kist was once the backwater frontier of the kingdom of Emed-Dar, a loose patchwork of tribal chieftains, isolated ethnic groups, Darian colonial towns, and villages of *arratu*-reclaimers, with a not-inconsiderable fragment of Old Vothite nobility who had fled their falling empire a thousand years ago. When Emed-Dar was drowned under the Anakim hordes two hundred years ago, vast numbers of refugees flooded into the eastern frontier, overwhelming the existing authorities.

The Kistian refugees coalesced around a minor cadet branch of the Darian royal house, elevating its patriarch as the first “Great King” of Emed-Kist. The Great King claims nominal rule over all of former Emed-Dar, but in practice, his authority extends only to the Kistian border and that, only to a degree. The former tribal chieftains, Vothite thought-houses, provincial governors, and minor ethnarchs were raised to noble ranks commensurate with their influence, and their traditional lands assigned to them as royally-granted fiefs.

Ever since then, the old nobility of Emed-Kist have waged a halfhearted struggle against royal authority while jealously guarding their ancient privileges and the autonomy of their fiefs. The refugee Darrians had no particular loyalty to these new lords, and the villages they founded and the towns they swelled had a much deeper tie to the king than to their nominal local overlords. Numerous royal rights and protections were granted to them, limiting the degree to which their lords could tax them, enlist their labor, or conscript them for war.

As a consequence, the lords rely chiefly on their own ancient kindred, enlisting them as soldiers and officials in their domain. This leaves the heirs of the Darian refugees with little prospect of advancement outside of mercantile wealth or service to the king, leaving it the present case that hardly any feudal officials are Darian, and hardly any royal servants are of the Old Kistian peoples.

This tension can occasionally erupt into violence. Some fiefs are relatively calm, with the Darrians and the native locals forced into cooperation by external threats or reconciled by a skillful lord’s rule. Others are bitter, sullen places with a restive Darian population under the hard hands of a lord and people who view them as little better than colonial invaders. While the combined military strength of the lords and their kin-armies is vastly greater than any of the standing forces of the Great King, their ancient grudges and the shared hostility of the Darian commoners keeps them nominally subject to the will of the throne.

Population

Approximately 1,000,000 humans and demihumans. The capital of Medek has perhaps 50,000 citizens.

Government

Great King Syet Lun rules through vassal dukes, marquises, counts, and barons. Towns and cities are held directly of the king by chiefs and mayors.

Problems

Border raids from Sarulite bandits or the Anakim of Emed-Dar are common perils. The feudal lords are constantly quarreling over land. The Darian-descended newcomers and the native Kistians dislike and distrust each other.

Names

The non-Darian peoples have their own name customs which often vary considerably from those below.

Male: Suen, Lauw, Kham, Wan, Kang, Tuok, Shway, Kwo, Sam, Zan, Bo, Pak, Hun, Gyat, Kin, Byet

Female: Kata, Jena, Jaia, Zaia, Sami, Pai, Zena, Kaia, Ji, Kanna, Hana, Fei, Ani, Dani, Juni, Chana

Family Names: Gow, Lyak, Tau, Jwei, Kej, Lien, Mak, Dek, Seng, Zju, Myan, Kwai, Xong, Jiet, Kyan

Character Concepts

Darian freebooter, Fallen noble heir, Rebel Kistian, Mercenary sellsword, Disgraced official, Displaced refugee, Wandering troubadour, Runaway peasant

Every fief of Emed-Kist has its own ancient traditions, customs, and quirks, kept fastidiously by the natives and respected only at convenience by the Darrians dwelling there. In the rare harmonious domains, the two groups mingle socially and may even live together; in others, there are Darian villages and native villages, and their interactions are at arm’s length. Most of the market towns and major cities are populated chiefly by Darrians, and it is through this influence that they control much of the liquid wealth of the kingdom. The great vassals are perpetually annoyed by the fact that most trade towns are direct vassals of the king, and not the local lord.

The present Great King is gravely worried about this division in his kingdom. He would like very much to pronounce a grand crusade of reconquest into Emed-Dar, there to reclaim the lost kingdom and unite his bickering people in a shared dream of their former glory. This plan has considerable support even among the native lords, for they imagine that the Darrians may then all go back to their own country. Despite this, the Great King has been unable to quell the grudges and mistrust among the feudal lords, and any great commitment of military force into Emed-Dar would leave the state easy prey for an attack by Llaigisan warlords or a greedy Vothite Senate.

KA-ADUN

Ka-Adun is a city and a province both, the former so vast that it is almost the province itself. When the Reaping King landed in the ancient port city a thousand years ago, it was little more than the crumbled remnants of some ancient Vothite coastal garrison. By the time he finished his conquest of the Gyre two centuries later, it was a vast metropolis that has only grown in the centuries since.

The heart of Ka-Adun is the “First City”, the original port on the Carceral Sea. Almost all the remaining inhabitants of the city dwell there, with food grown in cleared areas of the new city or sent down the mighty Usuldarum River as payment for foreign goods. It is the last outpost of true authority for the Brass Hegemony, and the nobles and officials who rule there do so with desperate vigilance.

Beyond the First City is the legacy of a thousand years of tireless construction by the automatons of the Black Brass Legion and uncounted slave laborers. Mile upon mile of paved streets and pale buildings and endless tunnels and vaults all stretch out for leagues in every direction, encasing the earth in structures of stone and alien metal brought up from the Deeps. This “new city” was intended for the Welcoming, a promised time of greeting when the kindred of the Reaping King will come to take possession of the entire continent.

No such kindred have ever come, and few seriously believe they ever will. The Reaping King orders the Legion to raise new structures but the artisans who design them and the human laborers who remain to toil do so only for the sake of their pay and the hope of security. The vast majority of the new city stands wholly empty, with pockets of bandits, monsters, rebels, and worse making petty baronies and miserable dominions in palaces and gardens meant for those who will not come. The Black Brass Legion shows no interest in such intruders, too absorbed in the work of further construction.

Every month, a welter of trading vessels make port in Ka-Adun. Most are coasters from along the Rebel Coast to the east, taking produce and plunder to the markets in order to trade under the eye of nominally neutral masters. More precious by far are the Yellow Ships that come at unpredictable times in a season, bearing wondrous goods from across the Carceral Sea. The delicacies, fabrics, mechanisms, grimoires, and priceless raw materials they bring draw merchants from throughout the Gyre and the interest of wealthy grandees from every corner of the realm. The men of the Yellow Ships go veiled and silent, communicating through manlike slaves that speak their thoughts. To rob them is punishable by a hideous death at the hands of the Hegemony.

The great city of Ka-Adun does not absorb the whole of its province, though it is intended to eventually do so. Outside the new city, noble estates and grand retreats were built in former centuries for the refreshment of Adunic nobility. Since the collapse of the Hegemo-

Population

Perhaps 500,000 people still remain in the province, a quarter of them packed into the First City, another quarter in various pockets in the new city, and the rest in the remaining rural area of the province.

Government

The Reaping King is silent in his folded palace. Currently, the Grand Censor Euphon leads the strongest party in the First City’s political mire.

Problems

Rebels and worse are forming small statelets within the empty structures of the new city.

Ka-Adun has a noble class far too large to be supported by the commoners without oppression. The Reaping King seems totally indifferent to his own government, leading to chaos in the palace.

Names

Male: Arcadius, Constantine, Damianus, Demetrios, Phocas, Valens, Basil, Alexios, Belisarius

Female: Ariadne, Eulogia, Eudokia, Irene, Sophia, Zoe, Thekla, Theodota, Helena, Anastasia

Family Names: Komnenos, Phokas, Cydones, Lascaris, Psellos, Dalassa, Prodromus, Xiphilinos

Character Concepts

Beggar-noble scion, Out-of-work clerk, New city robber, Escaped slave, Coastal pirate, New city builder, Urban merchant, Impoverished functionary

ny, these estates have become strongholds for desperate beggar-princes, ones who no longer receive their largesse from the Reaping King nor the fruits of their expropriated provincial estates. They maintain the old elegance of Ka-Adun with grim determination, many refusing to accept the present situation as anything but a temporary inconvenience to be remedied when the Reaping King finally sees fit. In the meanwhile, they collect “taxes” from their serfs and plunder each other in the name of fairly sharing the wealth due to the nobility. Many employ devices or Workings created during the height of the Hegemony and poorly maintained since. The numbers of magical disasters and unplanned arcane events in Ka-Adun dwarf those elsewhere.

The broken nobility rule over a common populace that once made their living as servants to the great or laborers on their vast estates. Many are gone now, having fled into the Rebel Coast in hopes of better prosperity or perished to banditry or plundering. Those that remain are left to either huddle in the First City under the eye of the Reaping King’s chief servants or to seek the patronage of some beggar-prince who has the strength to protect them from his foes. Many are disappointed in their search.

Llaigis

Grim Llaigis is a half-tamed land of wild hillsides, trackless forests, pockets of *arratu* badlands and the looming peaks of the Black Spine to the west. Throughout the past two millenia it has always been a backwater land for the desperate and the strong, its few cities built on the bones of prior civilizations and its farming hamlets hemmed in by perils.

Llaigis offers little to those living there. Its fields are unremarkable, its forests dangerous to exploit, and its hills not unduly burdened with riches. Its isolation, however, has made it a favorite refuge for exiled sorcerers, fallen nobility, and unacceptable cults. The ruins these refugees have left behind often contain precious remnants from a former age, and so relic-plundering has provided the Llaigisan people with rare opportunities for riches.

For all else, the people of Llaigis turn to steel. They fight each other for the meager wealth of their fields and mines when they cannot find more profitable work fighting for foreigners willing to pay for their savage strength. Llaigisan sellswords and mercenary bands are found throughout the Gyre in the employ of any master who has the silver and bread to hire them. While they are a brutal lot even by the standards of the Gyre they are not ignorant of military discipline or incapable of subtle tactics. The ordinary Llaigisan farmer knows as much of a warband's work as most common soldiers elsewhere.

The folk of Llaigis sharpen their skills not only on each other, but on the grim foes that emerge from the south and the ruins of Emed-Dar. The Anakim who destroyed that nation make a habit of raids north into Llaigis, and every savage warband must be turned back with blood and steel. The *arratu* that have festered in Emed-Dar send their own share of abominations to harry the people of Llaigis, and the considerable stretches of their own infected lands add to the burden.

In such a harsh land military might is the final justification for any ruler. Each patch of land has its baron, chieftain, prince, duke, pontiff, headman, or autarch to claim it, and each one proves his claim by the number of warriors he can direct into battle. Those warriors must be fed, of course, and so heavy taxes and cruel exactions are commonplace among the peasantry. Many such serfs yearn to be accepted into a lord's retinue and win a place in the warband, but a lord can afford to accept only the best warriors into their service.

King Hulit in the great, vile city of Gathis is the foremost of these warlords, with a legion of warriors ten thousand strong to carry out his will. While his might is more than a match for any single rival, there are enough great lords in the country that he cannot act with complete impunity. He makes bargains with his subordinates, trading them license to act as they wish in exchange for obedience in matters important to him. He rose to rule the city by his cunning, but he fears his son lacks the wit to keep it once he is gone.

Population

Approximately 800,000. Gathis, its largest and most decadent city, has 40,000 inhabitants.

Government

King Hulit of Gathis is the foremost of a half-dozen kings, princes, and primates. In practice, the law belongs to whatever warlord is nearest to hand.

Problems

Llaigis' government is unstable and constantly subject to disruption by ambitious warlords.

Anakim and monsters from Emed-Dar are forever crossing the southern border.

Numerous vile cults and loathsome groups operate with relative impunity within Llaigis' borders.

Names

Male: Goruk, Hroth, Lagan, Gurm, Narhak, Kroth, Yarog, Bolg, Yirn, Jagan, Mirtok, Fulvik

Female: Sarra, Tarsha, Miluni, Haru, Nira, Laheli, Bolga, Guthli, Jireela, Minna, Hejati, Kalana

Family Names: Rare outside of membership in some important dynasty or clan. Most distinctions are by epithets or places, where it matters.

Character Concepts

Untamed barbarian, Decadent thief, Grizzled mercenary, Hard-bitten village defender, Reclusive hunter, Abandoned concubine, Former cultist, Warband survivor, Ruin robber, Escaped slave

Gathis itself is a city that feeds on the wealth its soldiers bring it, either as tribute from its subject settlements or as silver brought from foreign paymasters. Filthy delights and abhorrent pleasures are to be found there, along with rare delicacies from afar and plundered opulence from ages past. Gathis makes little itself, but it feeds on what its people bring it.

Gathis, like most of the cities in Llaigis, is built atop a buried and ruined city of ages past, presumably one of the cities of the Rule of Shun that ended more than a thousand years ago. That grim sorcerer-king's land extended over much of present-day Llaigis and his places of power can still be found deep in the forests and hills. While generations of Llaigisan adventurers have plundered many of these sites, there are always new ones being discovered in some hidden copse or revealed beneath a hollowed hillside.

More than the past lingers in Llaigis, however. With the warlords so indifferent to any matters but their own advantage, Llaigis is a fertile ground for the planting of unseemly cults and dark conspiracies. There are many groups operating in the country that would never be tolerated in a more orderly realm, and sometimes the lords themselves find uses for their dark arts.

NEW VOTH

New Voth is a land lavishly endowed with the trappings of rule. Ancient ruins of the Vothite Empire lie beneath the foundation stones of Republic-era structures, and atop them stand the palaces of the Hegemonic governors that once ruled this land as regents for the Reaping King. Now all those old lords are gone, and New Voth's people are eager to regain their former place in the world.

New Voth is the sole significant republican state of the Gyre. All of its neighbors are under the hand of oligarchs, warlords, or hereditary nobles, but in New Voth alone the Senate can be found as proud representatives of their fellow citizens. Each of the hundred and one districts within the borders grants full suffrage to every land-owning citizen and the right to choose their representative senator every four years.

As any proud Vothite would tell you, it's only natural that the senators so elected should be the richest and most influential people in their home district, or the favored choices of those men and women. Admittedly, their interests are perhaps better-protected than those of the common citizenry, and the consequences for opposing these favored candidates can be very unfortunate, and some senatorial seats are practically the hereditary property of certain powerful dynasties, but still, they serve at the leave of the people.

The Vothites are proud of their civilized and educated populace and their fierce independence from any outside rule. They were the last to bow to the Reaping King's legions at the Hegemony's rise to power, and the first to refuse him tribute when the Legion no longer came. They deplore the hidebound classism of the Thurians, the brutality of the Llaigisans, and the blood-consciousness of the folk of Emed-Kist. There is little doubt in New Voth that their own ways of self-reliance, industrious effort, and determined personal improvement are the best.

To the Vothites, personal self-determination is something sacred. They have inherited a horror of all mind-influencing sorceries from their imperial predecessors and even today, the proven use of telepathic or mind-bending magics is a capital crime. In the same vein, New Voth and Sarul are the only provinces of the Gyre where privately-owned slaves are outlawed; in Sarul because the Church assumes its parishioners would inevitably use slaves as occasions for sin, but in New Voth because the people consider it an unforgivable crime against freedom.

The Vothites did relatively well in the Autumn War forty years ago, and popular feeling still believes that the ancient Republic should be reformed, whether by diplomacy or steel. Only the fear of uniting their neighbors in an alliance against them currently stays their hand.

The love of independence and free thought has spawned numerous small communities of like-minded men and women, along with communes, social pacts, religious retreats, and other self-chosen settlements. Some

Population

Around 1,500,000 total inhabitants, with the capital city of Clarum holding 150,000, the second-largest city in all the Gyre.

Government

A hundred and one senators make laws to be carried out by functionaries and bureaus they appoint, but these agents are often pawns of the magnates.

Problems

A senatorial faction wants to increase its influence by conquering new districts from surrounding lands. Slave traders are furious at their inability to travel in New Voth with their stock, and demand concessions. Popular feeling is for war with their "backward and wicked" neighbors to impose republican government.

Names

Male: Brogimar, Domnu, Epon, Olor, Mertom, Tecto, Rigos, Volcan, Marku, Torix, Maros, Taskos

Female: Adia, Camma, Inda, Mara, Epona, Manisa, Sibylla, Teria, Beka, Milya, Xanthe, Korai

Family Names: Ankyra, Gordon, Clow, Konion, Angra, Bedu, Midai, Vanak, Attis, Secrops, Lycas

Character Concepts

Badlands prospector, Runaway foreign slave, Debt victim, Aspiring entrepreneur, Political party agent, Ambitious peasant, Ignored Hegemonic noble heir, Freedom fighter

are established on philosophical grounds, while others are simply towns where the locals think new profit is to be had. A surprisingly large number of Vothites are *arratu* settlers, willing to risk death to tame the wastes.

In many ways, New Voth is a gold rush nation, one eager to burst free of a thousand years of alien rule. Strangers and expatriates are welcomed so long as they offer something to their neighbors, and the broad tracts of land once held by absent Hegemonic nobles are being thrown open to new settlers. Old ruins once sealed off by cautious Hegemony governors are now open to plunder and explore, and the *arratu* wastes that former viceroys found unprofitable are now being parceled out to newcomers willing to risk their unearthly perils.

Yet this new exuberance comes with an equal measure of roughness. The losers in this great game are given little mercy, and a man without silver in his pocket or a friend to hold him up has little hope for help. The strong are eager for workers and serfs, and while slavery is forbidden in New Voth, the employment of rough-handed "persuaders" is easier to hide. On the frontiers of New Voth many things are done that are not in accordance with the laws, and there are few officials or senators interested in righting such wrongs without being paid for it.

SARUL

Sarul is a great rarity; a nation composed almost entirely of Blighted. Most of the natives are Anakim, savage war-born Blighted imbued with an intrinsic hatred of humanity and brutal instincts of violence, cruelty, and malice. Others are different breeds of Blighted, those crippled and maimed by ancient curses or magical alterations that make it all but impossible for them to live peacefully in human lands.

All, however, are devotees of the nameless Bleeding God, an ancient deity promulgated by the Sixteenth Prophet some two hundred years ago, when the Anakim swept over Emed-Dar and threatened to destroy all the western Gyre. The prophet's tremendous martial prowess and invincible charisma formed the seed of Sarul, and it continued to expand until his death some thirty years later. Its borders have been relatively stable since then, despite the constant attacks by the Anakim of Emed-Dar and the uneasy peace Sarul holds with Emed-Kist.

The Bleeding God's teachings are simple: he is the only true god, all thinking life is wicked and deserving of damnation, and it is only by the Bleeding God's self-sacrifice and love that any are spared from eternal suffering. The Blighted are cursed with evil hearts, perhaps, but they are not fundamentally different from baseline humans and no more damned than their brethren. By faith in the Bleeding God and obedience to his teachings both baseline and Blighted may be forgiven their evils and saved in the world to come.

As a consequence, it is the Church that rules Sarul, from the village priests and priestesses to the Bishop-Generals that rule cities and the mighty Red, White, and Black Pontiffs who are chosen from among the bishops. The command of a cleric is law to the commoners, and a predictable amount of corruption, wickedness, and selfishness comes from this authority. The Church itself expects as much due to its theological principles, and so the Inquisition within its ranks never lacks for work.

Sarulite law is brutal and direct. Much petty crime that would bring severe punishment in other lands is held lightly here; brawling, mugging, minor theft, unlawful adultery, and public disturbances are met with on-the-spot beatings or fines and then dismissed. Serious crimes such as murder, rape, maiming, blasphemy, treason, or assault on a cleric are answered by summary execution, usually carried out by the nearest available Church crusader. These judgments are not always fair, proven, or merited, but the Church is convinced that only through merciless law can any kind of peace be kept in the nation. Outside scholars argue over whether or not they are right.

The villages and towns of Sarul are crude, poor, and dangerous. Fistfights and bare-handed robbery are common, advanced learning is a province almost exclusively of the clergy, and many of the cities and towns are built in the ruins of earlier, more materially advanced civilizations. Bandits and worse are common on the roads.

Population

Approximately 400,000 Anakim and other Blighted. The capital of Uzag has 20,000 residents.

Government

The Red, Black, and White Pontiffs of the Church of the Bleeding God are the absolute rulers of Sarul, their personal identities known to few.

Problems

Corruption within the Church is a constantly-fought menace at all levels of the organization. The Anakim of Emed-Dar hate the Sarulites as traitors and rivals for control of the southern Gyre. Blighted within Sarul can cause significant problems due to their own cursed needs or psychology.

Names

Male: Abdi, Arakhu, Balasu, Anshar, Dakuri, Izdu, Gamil, Kha, Kullani, Makru, Suzub, Uruk, Zabu

Female: Belit, Shala, Kishar, Aralu, Mylitta, Rubati, Gula, Damkina, Sunat, Serua, Zirra, Sarae, Kalu

Family Names: Largely unknown. Individuals may have epithets of their role, church rank, father, clan, or village when a distinction must be made.

Character Concepts

Secret unbeliever, Crusader sent wandering, Blighted seeking refuge, Escaped criminal, Framed innocent, Adventurous Anak peasant, Cleric out to convert, Merchant adventurer, Hunted infidel

While the Blighted of Sarul are lacking in the civil arts, no one disputes their terrifying martial prowess. The crusaders of the Bleeding God are some of the most fearsome cavalry troops in the Gyre, many of them still riding the fanged coursers of their tribal ancestors. They fight constantly with warbands from Emed-Dar, Blighted bandits and renegades within Sarul, and the least of them is a hardened veteran of war. Their Blighted instincts of warlike aggression have been channeled and directed by the Church, and they fight with a combination of joy and pious cruelty that disquiets even their allies.

There are very few baseline humans or demihumans in Sarul. The Anak urge to kill baselines can only be shackled by the laws of the Church, not erased, and human visitors are advised to go cloaked and avoid dealing with those Anakim not verified in their ability to control their innate Hate. The continued company of a crusader or other Anak in authority is advised for such safety as it can bring.

Visitors who do not share the faith of the Bleeding God are counseled to be strictly silent about matters of religion. While unbelievers and backsliders are by no means unknown within Sarul, any cleric who suspects a stranger of spreading a false faith will act accordingly.

THUR

Thur is a land of fragile wealth and delicately-balanced prosperity. Numerous ancient Workings still function in Thur, survivals from the age of the Vothite Republic. While relatively fragile and in need of regular maintenance, their distance from the capital in New Voth spared them from much of the violence of war and allowed their Thurian caretakers to profit from their ancient power.

These Workings provide raw energies of heat, light, and motion to their attached factories and infrastructure. Every town of significance is built around such a Working, with the factories and pumping stations at the heart of the town and the residential quarters encircling them. Great buried leytubes snake outward to surrounding villages and estates, providing smaller measures of energy to light heatless lamps at night and provide hot running water and smokeless warmth to those wealthy enough to afford a connection.

The great engines and factories of Thur are capable of producing large amounts of consumer goods, granted sufficient raw materials imported from New Voth, Ka-Adun, and Emed-Kist. The standard lifestyle of a Thurian commoner is as comfortable and well-fed as a knight of Emed-Kist or a Llaigisan slave merchant. Many sophisticated goods are made in Thur, including most of the functioning hurlants found in the Gyre.

Ruling over the common laborers and countryfolk of Thur are the Gentry, a class belonging to the Great Guilds that command Thur. These Guilds are heirs to the maintenance workers who kept the Workings running, and their *de facto* control of Thur's wealth has ensured their domination over the military powers of the state. The High Masters are in charge of each guild's affairs, and every five years they elect one among them to serve as Grand Master and first among equals.

Many of these Guilds no longer have any functioning arcanotechnical knowledge, their arts having decayed under the shifting of the Legacy or the Workings they once kept having since been lost. Even so, tradition and their entrenched political power have kept the Guilds in firm control of Thur, with every position loftier than a village clerk being filled by one Guild member or another.

Membership in the Guilds is not hereditary. Every Gentry candidate must successfully graduate from one of a number of elite schools originally founded to pass on the arcanotechnical arts. Certain Guilds will accept recruits only from certain schools, and the loftiest and mightiest will accept only from the best of them. While a Guild member might expect to find a place for one or perhaps two of their children, only extensive connections and dearly expensive bribes can ensure that all of a family's children have a hope of joining the Gentry as well.

The schools are hotbeds of politics, treachery, and the occasional assassination. Rivals are expelled via blackmail and bribery, and unworthy candidates are passed through with enough "encouragement" from a patron.

Population

Approximately 1,200,000. Its capital of Highbridge has a hundred thousand permanent residents.

Government

Grand Master Ellia Grinton of the Hydrotheurgic Guild leads the High Masters of Thur. Other senior guild members act as officials, mayors, and chiefs.

Problems

The Gentry schools are increasingly corrupt, with rankings and expulsions bought and sold. The Workings the nation relies upon are very vulnerable to sabotage and focused attacks. The damage of the Autumn War forty years ago has caused serious infrastructure problems.

Names

Male: James, Edward, Thomas, Henry, Theodore, William, Philip, Cuthred, Hugh, Owen, Harold

Female: Mary, Elizabeth, Rebecca, Anne, Emily, Gwyn, Felicia, Penny, Susan, Olivia, Morwen

Family Names: Usually by place or an ancestor's trade, such as Cooper, Smith, Witch, or Watermaster. Foreign names from immigrants are not unknown.

Character Concepts

Expelled school candidate, Workings maintenance mage, Ambitious guildsman, Hard-used common laborer, Demimonde denizen, Immigrant with something to prove, Fugitive debt-slave

Even so, sometimes a remarkably talented commoner might be allowed to enter one of the lesser schools.

Unsurprisingly, many outsiders would love to live in Thur, enjoying the comparative luxury and comfort of the land. Thurians are very selective about who they allow to settle permanently, however; adventurers and travelers can pass through with minimal difficulty, but winning permanent residence requires the patronage of the Gentry, and that kind of favor never comes cheap. Foreigners with business in Thur are given passes at the border, and the Gentry are not gentle with interlopers who are found without those documents or who have overstayed their allowed time.

Alas, Thur's prosperity has been on a steady downward slide since the Autumn War forty years ago, when Vothite armies sacked several important border cities and destroyed their Workings. The remaining facilities can barely keep up with the current load on them, and outages of light and heat are becoming more common. Without the material comforts that have kept them docile, Thurian commoners are beginning to blame the Gentry for failing at their ancient duty, and accusations of "power theft" and "energy hoarding" are beginning to inspire anger among the populace.



THE PEOPLE AND LANGUAGES OF THE GYRE

Most of the inhabitants of the Gyre belong to one of five different major ethnicities, all derived from different mother-populations that emerged from the Deeps at the end of Outsider hegemony. While all of these peoples had their own tongues, customs, and ancient culture, the ensuing thousands of years have largely effaced these old ways, leaving only small tokens behind in the surviving populace.

Aside from the five major groups, there are dozens of smaller ethnic groups that derive from surface populations of rebels, Outsider servants, or escapees from the Deeps. Most of the original stock has melted away into the surrounding population, but in isolated areas or frontiers such as Emed-Kist there yet remain a considerable number of these minor populations. Those that derive from Outsider servants are often considerably changed from human baselines, not uncommonly to demihuman degrees of difference. This difference is often the only thing that has kept them from being assimilated into the surrounding population, so the surviving groups tend to be those that had least occasion to mingle with their neighbors or conquerors.

Among the five major groups there is relatively little ethnic feeling or solidarity compared to the ties of place and province. A Vothian official in Ka-Adun will care far more for the interests of his peers in the First City than the well-being of his kinsmen in New Voth, and a Khalan in Emed-Kist will fight her own kind at the command of her lord without much concern. Shared ethnicity can be a convenient point of sympathy when two people wish to interact, but it does little to hinder competition or existing loyalties.

The minor groups tend to have a different mindset. These small populations simply could not have survived as they did without a keen sense of their own difference and the importance of preserving their own identity. They often refuse to marry outside their own kind and will commonly prioritize the interests of the group over those of outsiders. A steady state of friction with the surrounding majority populations is common, though most long-standing communities have worked out methods of dealing with these strains. Many such small groups survive by being especially useful to the majority in some way, often employing any unique graces they have in the service of the local rulers. Their leadership cultivates patronage relationships with important local powers, and it's common for the resident duke or local war chief to have them under their personal protection... in exchange for proper tribute.

MAJOR ETHNICITIES OF THE GYRE

The five different major groups are found throughout the Gyre. Some may be more densely represented in some nations than others, but seldom would they look out of place in any cosmopolitan center.

Vothians are the people that emerged from the Deep known as the Well of the One Thought, a folk originally led by the first Mentarch of the Vothite Empire, the dreaded Emperor-Queen Voth. They're found largely in New Voth, with considerable populations of Hegemony servants and officials in Ka-Adun. Refugee thought-houses from the fall of the Empire also left groups of them to be found in Emed-Kist. "Vothian" is the ethnic name they go by; citizens of New Voth or the prior Empire are distinguished as "Vothite" regardless of their bloodline. Vothians tend to be tall, slim, and pale-skinned, with black hair and blue eyes.

Khalan are the people of the Black Crucible, a terrible punishment-Deep established for unfathomable reasons by the Outsiders. The awful scars that the Deep left on the people and their customs have largely dissipated in the ensuing ages, but unwary adventurers still sometimes stumble on ancient Khalan ruins and the hideous engines within. Some postulate that the excesses of the vile Rule of Shun derived from study of these things. Most Khalan are found in Llaigis, though they are known in Emed-Kist, and a few Vothite river-villages are of their kind. They are a large, broad, bronzed people in the main, with dark or red eyes and hair that ranges from black to various dark hues of red. A few Khalan bloodlines are unusually slight, however, rarely exceeding five feet; most think them the heirs of some special-purpose sub-group.

The **Lin** are derived from the people of the Tin Mirror Sky, a false-world Deep fabricated by the Outsiders. The experiment appears to have been loosely monitored, and an unusual number of ancient Lin escaped to add their numbers to the rebels and hunted survivors of the surface world. They once formed the aristocratic elite of Old Emed, with lesser cadet houses as governors in Emed-Kist. When Emed-Dar collapsed, the rush of refugees has left Emed-Kist well-populated by their kind. They are a somewhat short, compact people with skins that range from ivory to dark gold, black hair, and almond eyes that are usually black. Some surface-tribe admixtures have left certain lines with pale hair or light eyes.

Olok are the folk of a broken Deep, the Downward Tower, that was disrupted in some Outsider quarrel unintelligible to humanity. Cast on the surface before the fall of Outsider rule, they were harried in a desultory fashion but left largely alone until the eventual fall of alien rule. They concentrated chiefly on the northern coast of the Gyre, forming the original population of the modern state of Ka-Adun. They were the folk the Reaping King first met on his landing, and so formed the backbone of the Hegemony's aristocracy and laboring classes. They are a very dark-skinned people for the most part, with dark, tightly-curled hair and matching eyes. The marks of their time spent among surface tribes sometimes emerge in different colors and textures of hair or different shades of eyes.

Osrin are the people of modern Thur, having derived mostly from the labor-Deep known as the Turning Vault. When their endless labors on behalf of the Outsiders ended, they emerged into a Gyre that had already been largely dominated by those Deep-dwellers who had emerged earlier. As such, their main population is found mostly in Thur, though considerable numbers of smaller groups are found in almost every other land as the descendants of unsuccessful independent city-states or colonial outposts. They are a folk of average stature, with skin colors ranging from pale cream to ruddy or olive hues. Their hair color is blond or brown, with blues, greens, and hazels most often found for eye colors.

LANGUAGES OF THE GYRE

Each of the five major groups had their own native tongue in the days gone past. Scholars and Deep-raiders sometimes study the written form of these languages to better understand the inscriptions they find, but none of them are spoken today save in the most venerable cultural rituals or by the most zealous enthusiasts. Sages refer to them as *Ancient Vothian*, *Ancient Khalan*, and so forth.

Trade Cant is a language favored by merchants, adventurers, and travelers, being a pidgin of various tongues found throughout the Gyre. While it has no status as a literary language and scarce any as a written one, a speaker of Trade Cant can generally convey basic ideas and important wishes to most cosmopolitan people in the Gyre, or conduct sophisticated mercantile exchanges with a fellow speaker.

Old Vothian was the lingua franca of the Vothite Empire and its subject peoples in the Gyre, gradually supplanting the ancient versions of their own speech and shifting their subjects' tongues in turn. It's found on many ancient Workings of the Empire and early Republic, but it is not spoken save by erudite scholars, who often use it as a common language between them. *Modern Vothian* is the common tongue of the present-day New Voth; while influenced by its neighboring languages, its speakers can often get the general gist of the older tongue.

Brass Speech is the tongue of the Hegemony and its servants, being spoken as a mother tongue in Ka-Adun and among the nobles and elites that once served the Hegemony. Aside from being a spoken language, it is found in many Hegemony-era books and inscriptions meant for the use of the Reaping King's loyal servants.

Emedian is the former language of Old Emed, and by extension much of Emed-Kist. Derived from Ancient Lin, it was a poetic tongue of sophistication, grace, and nuance, and it has never lost its reputation as a tongue of literary importance, even during the rule of the Vothite Empire.

Thurian is the modernized form of Ancient Osrin that serves as the common tongue of Thur. That nation alone can maintain any effective printing industry, and so popular pulps, newspapers, and extensive arcanotechnical documentation continues to be produced in Thurian.

Llaigisan is a smoothed-over Ancient Khalan, with extensive loans from Emedian and Old Vothian. Considerable amounts of Ancient Khalan vocabulary were excised over the years as being incompatible with peaceful sleep by those familiar with the terms.

Anak Speech is the local language spoken by the Anak tribes of the wastes and the people of Sarul. Its roots lie in the servant-speech of the Outsiders who created the first Anakim, and it has nothing to do with any of the modern human tongues. It is crude, simple, and direct, unnuanced in anything but its vocabulary for violence. The Church of the Bleeding God that rules in Sarul finds it necessary to use Old Vothian as its clerical language in order to discuss more sophisticated ideas.

Predecessant is a particularly rare and esoteric language known only to the most determined scholars and the most rapacious adventurers. It is the original language of the Reaping King and his first servitors, preserved only in a handful of documents and found on certain strange structures and occult inscriptions within the new city of Ka-Adun. Most believe it to be a language from over the Carceral Sea, spoken by whatever powers sent the Reaping King forth.

Preterite is not so much a language as a code, an ancient method of directly communicating with the Legacy. It is impossible to learn Preterite as a mere tongue; scholars can spend their entire lives trying to define the magical and metaphysical significance of a single Preterite glyph. Any mage or learned scholar can recognize the existence of Preterite markings, but even magical spells of translation are useless in giving anything but the crudest, most superficial translation of their meaning. Their presence is usually an indication that the Black Gate to a major world-Iterum is near to hand, or some similar Legacy working of unearthly power.

Outsider tongues are largely incomprehensible to humans, and usually impossible for them to physically produce. *Abased* is a patois that survives in certain places, a more easily-vocalized pidgin used by many Outsider species of the Gyre region in order to command their slaves. It exists now chiefly in the books of scholars and the memory of adventurers who must often interact with Abased inscriptions in the ancient Deeps.

Among the demihuman peoples of the Gyre, the languages spoken are usually those of the surrounding majority. Those descended from some cohesive cultural group may still preserve their ancestral speech, but many of these groups never had one to begin with, being created out of another group's population, and the "ancestral speech" of two different populations may have been entirely different. Some scholars maintain that the "*Recurrent*" spoken by some of those transhumans known as "elves" is evidence of a unified origin for that demihuman species. Others believe that the "*Deep Speech*" of the Outsider-engineered "dwarves" is more a consequence of their intimate involvement with the Legacy and its impact on their communication rather than the result of any unified origin.



FAITHS OF THE GYRE

Every nation in the Gyre has their own selection of favored deities, some shared between peoples and others unique to particular nations, provinces, or even individual cities or villages. Most of these gods are of little interest to adventurers, and a GM who wants to detail them for additional setting flavor can use the tools on page 140.

Other gods, however, are more pertinent to an adventurer's ambitions. They either offer services of special interest, goals that adventurers could either further or oppose, or they are major political authorities in certain areas. The faiths described below are but a few of these.

THE BRASS CULT

The Reaping King never required formal worship from his subjects, but it was inevitable that some among them would seek to give him the honors due a divinity. Veneration of the King became a mark of nobility and membership in the Hegemonic elite, and even today many elaborate Brass Cult temples can be found in places that were once important to the Hegemony's aristocracy.

Since the Reaping King went silent, the cult has become convinced that inadequate worship and reverence is the cause for his seeming inaction. They loudly preach submission to the Hegemony and return to a strict obedience to Hegemonic officials, a plea that commonly falls on deaf ears. Even so, the Brass Cult is still in possession of substantial wealth and arcane resources given to it by noble believers, and they are able to reward cooperative lords and work vigorously against open enemies of the Hegemony. Most of their aristocratic clergy seek only the stabilization and strengthening of the remaining Hegemonic authority in the Gyre, and will commonly employ adventurers to carry out tasks toward that end.

THE SERVANTS OF SHUN

The Rule of Shun was a centuries-long secessionist movement during the Vothite Republic, during which much of modern Llaigis was taken over by the devotees of a latter-day sorcerer-king known only as "Shun". While his bloody kingdom was eventually crushed by a Republican army, his worshipers persist even into the present day in modern Llaigis, New Voth, and Emed-Kist.

The Rule of Shun was infamous for its biological experiments and mutated abominations. Modern devotees pray to Shun for deliverance from sickness and injury, and seek his favor in order to gain physical might and martial prowess. The clergy of Shun are privy to many techniques from the fallen Rule and are marvelously effective healers and augmentors. All of them, however, are sworn to aid Shun in being reborn into this world, a process that requires numerous ancient artifacts and a vast supply of "raw materials" from believers and their prey. Once this is done, believers are convinced that they will be the elect of the new age and appointed to rule over the lesser, inferior breeds of the present day.

THE OLD LORDS

Dreaded servants of the ancient Outsiders and their alien gods, the worshipers of the Old Lords are convinced that the rule of the alien tyrants was actually an era of order, harmony, and peace, and that it was only through the treacherous machinations of wicked humanity that the era was ever lost. They blame every modern suffering on human error and point to the vast megastructures of the Deeps as proof that the Outsiders had the power to grant humanity all they could ever desire. Records of suffering, torment, and cruelty are dismissed as sorcerer-king lies.

This faith is usually found in small cells centered around an ancient Outsider control unit or fabrication node, one powered by various rites of submission and sacrifice. The cultists tend to credit any cruelty it inflicts as no more than just punishment for human wickedness, and are rewarded by the goods, powers, or augmentations that the ancient artifice bestows on them. Sometimes actual living Outsiders, particularly Tuhulot, can be found as high priests of these cells, using them for their own purposes and rewarding them for their slavish obedience.

While priests bemoan the folly of the poor and wretched sorts who often become cultists of the Old Lords, these acolytes have their reasons. Many surviving Deep artifacts can bestow wondrous benefits or abundant goods on humans who perform the proper rituals of abasement and sacrifice, and these tangible rewards of piety can mean the difference between life and death for some communities. Even some cultists who privately acknowledge the horror of the Outsiders are willing to hold their tongues for the sake of the rewards they grant.

THE GOLDEN PATH

This faith is convinced of the eternal recurrence of the soul, that every creature is incessantly recycled by the Legacy into new incarnations of suffering, attachment, and loss. Only by liberating the self from any attachment to the world and conducting special rites of disentanglement may a soul be permitted the peace of final unity with the cosmos... or final extinction, depending on the sect's particular interpretation of their doctrine.

The Golden Path has temples that follow the teachings of a host of different "Liberators" who are supposed to have escaped the cycle of life and death. Their doctrines vary from place to place, but their dedication to eliminating suffering makes them a major source of Healers, and numerous temple-schools of the faith instruct candidates in those arts. Extremists of the faith, known commonly as "Wheelbreakers" are convinced that only the destruction of the world can cut short the suffering of existence, and their zealous pursuit of complete nullification of all extant reality has caused more than a few disasters.



THE BLEEDING GOD

Devotees of this faith flatly refuse to recognize the deserved divinity of any other god; to them, the name of their deity is simply “God”, and they distinguish him as the Bleeding God only when they must be clear with nonbelievers. Their church rules the nation of Sarul, but other branches can be found in other nations, usually minor missionary churches and local cells. Outside of the theocracy of Sarul, the only authority is a given nation’s Pontifex, and many regions have more than one of them due to disagreements on theological or political matters.

The Bleeding God is depicted as the sole creator, ruler, and judge of the world and the font of all virtue and meaning. Sentient life is hopelessly deficient in virtue, being inescapably wicked and deserving of eternal suffering. The Bleeding God accepted this just punishment on behalf of creation out of love for what he had wrought, and so believers may be redeemed by accepting his sacrifice and striving to follow the teachings of his prophets. Compassion, courage, mercy, continence, truthfulness, and self-discipline are prized by followers.

While the ethical standards of the faith are attractive to many, and its promise of an eventual afterlife of joy to faithful believers is appealing, its contempt for human virtue and strict moral demands makes it an unpopular faith in most areas. It’s found most often among Blighted, slaves, outcasts, and the lowest social rungs, who find the idea of an all-powerful god that actually cares about their existence to be an exciting novelty.

THE SEERS OF VOTH

While worship of the first Mentarch of the Vothite Empire was proscribed during the thousand-year rule of the Republic, it didn’t stop a variety of refugee thought-houses, wary provincial villages, and secret Republic cells from maintaining their rites. With the fall of the Republic and the religious tolerance of the Brass Hegemony, it grew back into a faith that has congregations in almost all the cities and major towns of the Gyre.

Voth is held to be the arch-architect of the Gyre, the fathomless mind that set in motion all that has come to pass. Any suffering or misery is the result of deviation from Voth’s great plan and any personal problems can be overcome if the petitioner finds the correct course of action that Voth’s omniscience would direct him to take. Believers work on behalf of Voth’s clergy, carrying out their directions and paying tithes in exchange for oracular knowledge, secret guidance, and practical advice. Even nobles have considerable use for a Seer advisor, as their information networks can often supply any deficiencies of their magical foretelling.

Every provincial district has its First Seer to direct and coordinate individual temples, with the First Seers gathering from time to time to further the plans of their enigmatic mistress. These plans are derived from ancient rescripts issued by the Mentarch, exegised and interpreted according to cult methodologies. Different factions employ different methods, but all are eager to unearth additional “scriptures” to better plot out the future.

OUTSIDERS AND THE ARRATUS

The aliens that formerly ruled the Latter Earth are innumerable and at least partly indescribable. The conquered world was host to thousands of different alien species, each with their outposts, consulates, and garrisons bent on maintaining their control over humanity and its Legacy. There is no doubt that a considerable number of them would have been just as glad to eradicate the entire species, but the power of the Legacy made such measures impractical; too drastic a genocide risked triggering ancient defense protocols that may have been too much even for the conquerors to have overcome.

As a consequence, the Outsiders settled in for an ages-long occupation, punishing, consuming, or “improving” the humans in their charge as they saw fit. The Deeps ensured that the populations were easily controlled, and the rebel surface tribes and the limited number of humans directly in service to the Outsiders were of little importance. During this period the chief interests of the Outsiders lay in their own obscure quarrels and interline struggles, with wars fought occasionally by human slave armies or Blighted servitors.

When the rule of the Outsiders finally collapsed, whether from their own conflicts, the rebellion of the first sorcerer-kings, or from some unknowable decision to depart, the remnants left behind were swiftly slaughtered by the avenging human survivors. Those that survived retreated to their best-hidden or most strongly-fortified fastnesses, there to seethe in bitterness. Due to the constant splintering of Iterums, the Outsiders of most iterations of Latter Earth cannot even hope to flee the world. They are trapped forever in the home of their mortal foes.

Outsiders hate humans, for as much as a human emotion can describe their attitudes. Some hate them for what they did, others hate them for what they are, and a few hate them for what they might yet become. It is not impossible for an Outsider to form a working relationship with a human, and indeed, some modern communities still have secret ties to Outsider patrons, but such arrangements are almost always born of desperate mutual necessity. A few Outsider species are rumored to have a more benevolent attitude toward humanity, and some might actually be well-disposed toward them... or feigning it for some more awful end.

There are three major species of Outsider found within the Gyre, along with more than a dozen lesser species that have been identified in certain remote regions.

JIKEGIDA, THE PARASITES

Known as the “Stickmen” by some, the Jikegida are an emaciated-looking, bipedal, four-armed humanoid species that stands approximately seven feet tall. They have a chitinous, plate-like outer integument, seven long, slender talon-fingers on each arm, and a long, flat, beetle-like body surmounted by a head with bulging black eyes and mandibular jaws. Due to their reproduction method,

many of them have incongruous body parts or features from their host progenitor, such as human-like faces, furred pelts, pawed feet, horns, or human hands.

The Jikegida are semi-immortal once mature, but require immobilized or helpless warm-blooded hosts to reproduce. The larva is implanted along the spinal column, putting the host in a torpid daze that continues while the larva swells to fill their abdominal cavity and digests the less-important tissues of the host. Within a week, surgical removal is impossible without killing the host, and only powerful healing magics have any chance of saving them. After a month, a juvenile Jikegida emerges, killing the host, and then grows to full maturity over a period of five or six years. While any warm-blooded host of sheep size or larger will serve, Jikegida spawned from intelligent, neurally-dense hosts such as humans are more intelligent, bigger, and stronger.

The Jikegida favor the use of crossbow-like launchers and other mechanical weapons, as their thin limbs are relatively weak compared to human arms. Their social life revolves around pheromonal exchanges and scent “debates” that resolve theoretical questions of philosophy and ontology that humans can barely categorize, let alone fully understand. As far as human scholars can tell, the Jikegida consider humanity to be nothing but “philosophical zombies”, false machines of flesh that only *seem* to have emotions and desires, and so are fit only for use.

A Jikegida nest is usually built of lightweight plant materials unless they have access to their ancient construction-shells or Blighted slave laborers, whereupon they favor smooth stone buildings with hexagonal masses of shapes and passages. Their technology is usually slightly better than that of nearby humans, but a few of them have access to marvels inherited from their once-dominant ancestors.

POLOP, THE SEA KINGS

The “seamaws” or “fish devils” are never found far from water. A Polop can usually breathe air for as much as a day, but dry climates and extended periods outside of water or away from their life-support equipment doom them to a suffocating death. Most appear as horse-sized, vaguely sexapedal shapes with glabrous, scaled skin, huge, unblinking eyes and a maw of fanged teeth. Their body plan involves six clusters of locomotive and manipulatory appendages evenly paired along either side of their body, each cluster consisting of two to four crab-like legs that end in small “hands” of curved chitinous material. Flexing these limbs and the thin integument between them propels them rapidly underwater, while land movement leaves them in a vaguely centauroid posture, leaving two clusters free to manipulate tools.

The Polop are the unquestioned rulers of the Carceral Sea around the Gyre. Coastal raids by Polop harvesters are a commonplace, and every fisherman knows to sail

only in daylight hours, when the fish devils are quiet. Even so, colonies of Polop have been found in the Blind Marsh, the Mirewash and the Tombwater, with some reported around the Font. Even the Usuldarum and Usulmot rivers have known local infestations of them.

The Polop eat humans. As far as scholars can understand, they find humans to be delicious, but the act of eating them is some sort of religious or philosophical statement of species superiority. "We Who Eat" is the Polop term for themselves, and it's true that Polop biology appears capable of consuming almost any living creature without ill effects. Some Polop trench-cities contain extensive human breeding pens where captive populations are raised as meat stock. Most humans, however, are eaten shortly after they are taken back to the city. While Polop will eat dead flesh, they find it more satisfying to consume sentient creatures aware of their fate.

Polop magic and technology are sophisticated in matters of life support, live-coral construction and the mental domination of monstrous sea life, but their underwater existence leaves them with few high-temperature or high-energy resources. Their great trench-cities are built in the lightless depths, illuminated by phosphorescent masses, while colonies nearer the surface are fabricated of bubbles of pressure-tight coral lattices.

TUHULOT, THE ONES OUTSIDE

The "folded men" are some of the most alien of Outsiders. They manifest as human-appearing entities but their motions are utterly wrong. Limbs jerk in non-Euclidean ways, voices manifest without moving lips, and their "walk" is a hideous shamble of twitching limbs like some ill-managed puppet. This is because the Tuhulot is not fully present; it is interacting with this world through a single facet of its being, and the interface is inevitably crude.

At some point in the unfathomable past, humanity locked the entire Tuhulot species away in some sort of alternate dimension. Only through ages of ferocious effort have they been able to penetrate this far back into our reality and the manifestations they have formed are the best they can do until the remainder of the seal is broken and they can fully incarnate in this world once more. This freedom can be obtained only by destroying certain ancient relics, disrupting certain ancient control sites, and extinguishing certain critical human bloodlines. The Tuhulot are desperate to escape their prison and return to their former rule, and they will do anything to advance this goal by so much as a single step.

Tuhulot are never found in groups. They operate as kingmakers and manipulators, using their uncanny powers of spatial and temporal perception to provide information and backing to their agents. They are extraordinarily difficult to kill, though a successful destruction of their manifestation will seal that particular Tuhulot away from the world for some indeterminate age. They are terrified of this fate, and will bargain richly to save their own "lives".

THE ARRATUS OF THE OUTSIDERS

In the ages of their control over humanity it was inevitable that the Outsiders should have tried to xenoform the Latter Earth to better suit their wishes. Despite their control of the surface, the Legacy made this process very difficult; xenoforming engines and curses of transformation were contained and suppressed. A frigid atmosphere of liquid methane might spread for miles around a Quhal ice-spire, but six miles from the center point it would be suddenly halted by the Legacy, unable to so much as chill the neighboring terrestrial atmosphere. If the ice-spire were to be destroyed, the entire atmosphere might be reverted back to Earthly norms in a matter of days, though the damage the methane did may or may not be swiftly repaired.

An *arratu* is one such xenoformed area. The closer it was to the terrestrial norm, the less likely the Legacy was to forcibly deconvert it, so the Outsider engineers tended to make their changes in small increments. Many of these *arratus* were so palatable to the Legacy that they continue to persist even in the absence of their makers or the destruction of their original central nodes. Within these cursed lands there can be found abominations both earthly and otherwise, some dependent on the special environment of the *arratu* even to exist.

Most surviving *arratus* have a human-breathable atmosphere, though it may be toxic over a period of long exposure. The flora and fauna within are usually wildly different from terrestrial varieties, being alien colors, strangely configured, or exceptionally vicious. Monsters from the *arratu* may roam outside its boundaries for hunting purposes, but few can survive extended absences from its alien vapors and strange radiations.

With long ages or favorable conditions, such an *arratu* can spread of its own, gradually expanding to devour the surrounding lands. Ancient boundary-markers placed by the sorcerer-kings sometimes work to contain these expanding wastes, while others are constantly fought by their human neighbors. Lacking such constraints, they will expand until the Legacy restricts them.

Within the *arratus* are found ancient Outsider ruins and the forgotten remnants of human cities overrun by the wastes. The difficulty and danger of penetrating deep into such lands keeps these ruins unusually well-preserved from scavengers, and particularly bold adventurers make a point of exploring *arratus* in search of these lost troves. These explorers often fail to return.

Especially brave settlers or wretched penal slaves are sometimes sent to deconvert an *arratu*, sowing certain Terran plants along its borders and raising certain native animals that assist the Legacy in rectifying the wastes. Through generations of effort, this can gradually shrink the *arratu* until it is entirely gone. With sufficient arcane power and the right artifacts, large stretches of *arratu* can be deconverted in a matter of moments. Of course, employing such powers often requires the discovery of the *arratu's* origination point and the defeat of whatever defensive measures the makers originally put in place.



ITERUMS, THE ECHOED WORLDS

As the Legacy holds within it the raw descriptive encoding of innumerable possibilities, the application of sufficient energy to its patterns can create splinters of alternate reality. These *Iterums* echo the baseline worlds they emulate but each has its own independent substance. Some Iterums are as small as rooms, while others are so vast as to be full-scale replicas of the Latter Earth itself.

An Iterum usually shares the physical laws of its parent world, though arcanists of sufficient learning and ability to manipulate the Legacy may introduce changes. Errors in this process can produce catastrophes on a literally global level; more than one Iterum has been generated as an unsurvivable hellscape of twisted monstrosities when its creator desired only to make a paradise.

An Iterum's history splinters off at the point of its instantiation. While it may have been called into existence with a full panoply of inhabitants and sentient minds, the events and activities that go on from the point of creation are unique to each individual Iterum. Even those inhabitants who somehow manage to journey into the Iterum's past, before its supposed time of creation, find only a copy of the people and events that led up to its eventual divergence. The only conventional way to cross between Iterums is through those portals coded by the Legacy to admit cross-reality traffic, the infamous "Black Gates" that connect specific realities.

Powerful sorceries can also reach through the barrier between worlds by relying on the Legacy and its universal connection to all Iterums and all possibilities. Through the correct incantations and the appropriate thaumaturgical implements, entities from foreign Iterums can be called forth as servants, agents, or occasionally as gods. Such summoning powers are as capricious and dangerous as is all High Magic, and the decay of the Legacy has put many foreign Iterums out of the reach of modern sorcery, leaving only the stranger and more dangerous ones in common reach.

Every Iterum has its own identifying code. The Iterum described in this book is coded as "108 Triumphant Void", the last ideogram's translation being disputed by those few scholars capable of analyzing the Preterite glyphs that encode it. Some have translated it as an now-unknown place-name or personal name, while others would read it as "Consumption", "Undoing", "Negation", or "Completion". These names and their accompanying arcane coordinate glyphs are important in summoning magics, and numerous examples of other Iterums and the names given them by their creators are preserved in ancient texts.

This Iterum, like many others, is a vast one. It encompasses the entire Latter Earth and appears to be a relatively late splintering of the timeline, perhaps dating to the final years of the downfall of the Outsider rule of the planet. It is unclear what provoked the creation of this Iterum; some say that in its parent reality, the Outsiders

were successful in crushing the rebellion, and this world was splintered as a refuge in which their efforts were in vain. Others suspect that this reality is one created by the Outsiders themselves, in which they did not suffer the complete extermination that they experienced in the parent Iterum. The truth is largely unguessable, as not even the name of the parent Iterum of 108 Triumphant Void has survived into the present day.

As implied, the denizens of an Iterum can splinter further iterations, some larger than the parent itself. Because of this, it is clear that the true Latter Earth, the First World of ancient origin, is now hopelessly lost somewhere back along the path of forked possibilities. The inhabitants of 108 Triumphant Void are thus trapped within the boundaries of their Iterum. While they may roam the whole of the Latter Earth and ascend to the very limit of its atmosphere, the stars beyond are nothing more than lights in the roof of the world, images calculated into reality as part of the Iterum's creation.

Only by tracking backward through the innumerable sharded possibilities of their parent Iterums could an explorer hope to somehow find the First World, and without knowing even the code for this world's parent Iterum the first step on such a journey is impossible. There are arcane cosmographers who devote their scholarly lives to mapping out the known connections between Iterums, identifying parent and child worlds and tracing the links of Black Gates and summoning incantations between them, but even those sages have never managed to find a provable path to the First World where they may ascend once more to the stars.

For most inhabitants of the Latter Earth, the existence of Iterums is of little importance. They are Hells, or Heavens, or fairy-tale worlds, or the muttered hair-splittings of useless old scholars. This world is as real as anything and its people as substantial as anyone could be. They have no interest in what could have happened in other possibilities; their concern is for their own lives and loved ones, and that is enough.

For sorcerers and heroes, the matter is not so simple. Expert mages have means to create Iterums of their own as Workings, albeit rarely ones larger than a room, or perhaps a building. A few nurse mad dreams of calving off entire nations to be their devoted slaves and worshippers, studying means by which the creation process can be corrupted and shaped more to their liking. Ancient Iterums can be found in many places, most serving as pockets in which some long-dead wizard was conducting their own unfathomable experiments, while others were fastnesses for Outsiders, exiled nobility, or fallen peoples. A few seem to have been created to suit their progenitor's aesthetic tastes or artistic visions. The Black Gates that connect these worlds to 108 Triumphant Void are usually obvious, but a few are so well-concealed that a traveler can pass through without even noticing their translation.



ITERUMS AND RELIGION

Many religions promise an afterlife to their believers, whether it is the paradisaical garden granted to the faithful souls that die in the Bleeding God's grace or the endless torment that awaits rebels against the just rule of the Old Lords. Others place the homes of their deities not in some sacred mountain or holy glade on earth, but in a far realm beyond the reach of humanity.

While humble priests and common believers take these things as ordinary fact, theologians and sages argue over how many of these places and fates are purely fictional, how many are misunderstood Iterums, and how many are actual divine realms unrelated to the Legacy. These arguments would be considered abject blasphemy by most, were most believers able to understand them in the first place.

Yet there is no denying that some religions really do appear to have an afterlife in which the "souls" of their believers reside. Their shades can sometimes be called back by certain rituals, and the holy envoys of their gods can sometimes be called up by pious petitioners or special ceremonies. Other faiths can point to very palpable Hells for their renegades and the monstrous devils that sometimes are unleashed on the world. Orthodox theologians would declare that these realms are divinely-produced.

Yet atheistical sages have proposed that these afterlives are man-made creations of ancient Legacy-engineers who embedded the ideas of their faith in the basic fabric of reality. They created the Iterums of heavens and hells and encoded the rules of their functioning in the Legacy so that believers would receive their promised dues.

A few deny both proposals, saying that these realms are something else entirely, some phenomenon or state of being that humanity can only encounter and not create. The truth of the matter remains in dispute.

ITERUMS IN PLAY

For a GM, Iterums serve as a simple in-world explanation for any differences or modifications you may choose to make to the default setting. If you prefer to shuffle nations around, rewrite the past, add or subtract sentient species, or adjust other elements of the default game you can simply set it in your own Iterum and not worry about "contradicting canon". While you could certainly do the same to 108 Triumphant Void, many GMs feel more comfortable in clearly distinguishing their own work.

Iterums also serve as "planes of existence" for the summoning of strange creatures or the machinations of invidious extraplanar entities. Many fantasy games all but require the existence of demons, angelic powers, extraplanar abominations, or other beings native to entirely different worlds. Iterums can serve as those worlds, providing a convenient source of otherworldly beings.

Iterums can also function as convenient dungeon sites. The rules of reality within such an Iterum might be such that strange Workings or warped natural laws prevail, and the architecture and contents of the place could be impossible under conventional physics. Such Iterums can be as large as they need to be for the GM's convenience. Some could be no more than handy pocket labyrinths to entertain the heroes for a session, while others could be big enough to hold all of Averroigne or contain an alternate-world campaign.

Most players honestly won't care much about Iterums or worry over the consistency of their details. Give them a "real world", a selection of alternate planes, a few dungeons that don't seem to respect conventional laws, and that's a sufficient campaign setting for their interests. Their main use is for the GM, so that they might have a coherent in-universe explanation for providing those elements to their own campaign creations.



CREATING YOUR CAMPAIGN

Heroic adventures take place in particular places and settings. If you're going to run an urban adventure, you need to have a city to put it in, and if the players want to delve into some long-forgotten tomb, you need to have someone buried there. Some of these details are handled when you create the adventure content, but that creation process is much easier if you have a certain default background setting to work with.

For a sandbox game, your *campaign* is the setting in which your adventures take place. At its broadest, it's the particular game world, while at its narrowest, it's the part of the setting that exists immediately around the adventure you're running, one that gives you the information you need to adjudicate events when players stop engaging with the content you prepared for that adventure.

Campaign settings tend to be built for two purposes. In the first, the GM is honestly just interested in the worldbuilding. They want the fun of sub-creation, forging their own world in the privacy of their home, fabricating nations and gods and societies as a pleasant recreation. This is a perfectly valid way to have fun, and this chapter can be used to support that worldbuilding hobby with a host of tools and resources.

The other purpose is more practical. These GMs build their campaign settings so they have a well-supported framework for creating and placing adventures and adjudicating the choices that PCs make during them. A good campaign setting not only provides a wide variety of hooks and inspirations for adventure creation, it's also fleshed out in ways that serve as a backstop and GM cue for handling unplanned situations.

If you know that the nation the adventure takes place in is a magocratic mandarin state with locals who love law and order and who identify their interests with their ancestral magical school, you'll have a much better idea about what will happen when the PCs decide to start a violent rebellion against the government. You'll know that they need to get the magical school deans on their side, that they'll be opposed by a lot of wizards, and that the natives won't be enthusiastic about it unless they can dress their actions in the guise of law. You'll also have a wide selection of adventure hooks and pre-existing conflicts to mine when it comes time to build playable content for your campaign.

It is for this reason of support that this chapter was written. The goal of these tables and tools is not just to create a satisfying, plausible world you can put on your mantle to admire, it's to create a usable backdrop that you can mine for adventure inspiration and consult for plausible consequences for PC actions.

It is not strictly necessary to build a campaign for your adventures. You can handwave the material not covered in your adventure prep as some generic fantasy world or commonly-understood trope setting. Spending the time on creation, however, generally repays the cost.

AN OVERVIEW OF CREATION

While a GM can always pick and choose among the tools in this chapter, the basic process for campaign creation follows the steps below.

Plan your scope. What is the basic kind of campaign you want to run? Is it intrigue-based? Dungeon-crawling? Nautical? Exploratory? Emulating a particular existing setting or book? This scope can and probably will change over time as player interests shifts, but you need to start somewhere and have an idea of the sort of game play you want to have.

Build your backdrop. Starting from the topmost, global level of your campaign world, you make decisions about the place and assign it qualities and facts. There are three levels of backdrop of increasing specificity: world, region, and kingdom.

At the world level you're making a few basic decisions about the place: what the locals call it, any ways in which its basic qualities are obviously different from Earth, and any powers so mighty that their influence is felt throughout the planet. You may not even have a map of this world or know anything about its political geography, because those facts don't matter yet.

At the regional level, you're carving out a block of the world perhaps two hundred miles on a side, or some coherent peninsula, island, or chunk of geography. The region describes the area in which your campaign's play is probably going to take place for a long time, with multiple nations and groups that have their own histories, interests, and relationships. You sketch out this region in more detail, but you don't seriously develop any single part of it yet.

That happens at the kingdom level, when you pick the kingdom, polity, or province in which your campaign's first adventure session is going to take place. Your players are probably going to spend the first few game sessions there at least, if not more, so you dress this kingdom up fully in a properly-developed society, government, religion, and history. These facts can then serve as springboards when it comes time to build adventure content there using the tools in the next chapter.

Assigning tags to sites is a process that can happen at multiple levels during campaign creation. Tags are simply tropes or key ideas that can be mixed and matched to characterize particular noble courts, urban or rural communities, ruins and dungeons, or wilderness areas. By picking two tags and synthesizing them, you equip a site with a set of pre-made adventure hooks that you can easily return to later when needed.

Ultimately, the tools in this chapter are meant to save you time and effort, allowing you to spend your creative energy on the parts of your world you find fun and interesting. Use these tools in that spirit; they're here to serve you and your needs, not some abstract process.



PLANNING YOUR WORK

When reading this chapter, it is crucial to draw the distinction between worldbuilding for fun and worldbuilding for playable content. Most of the people reading this book probably enjoy worldbuilding for its own sake. It's a lot of fun to brew up strange lands and stranger people, to fill dark corners of the world with nefarious evils, and to carefully limn the features of alien gods and time-lost history. These activities are a perfectly good hobby and a relaxing way to spend your downtime.

Campaign prep is meant to be more directed. You need to focus your efforts on creating useful, playable content. Sometimes that means leaving aside a fascinating thought-toy or neglecting some intriguing facet of your creation in order to have the time and creative energy to hammer out the pieces you *do* need for the next session. It's okay to return to those things once you've got your homework finished, but you need to get your critical components finished first. It's all too easy to exhaust both your time and your creative energy on peripheral matters, leaving you stressed and unequipped for the next session of gaming. If you follow the guidelines in this chapter, however, you should be able to get something fun and playable ready with minimal grief, giving you that much more time and energy to play with the fun parts of your world.

When creating your own campaign, the first step is to think carefully about the scope of the work you need to accomplish. Blindly charging into the job with a demiurge's enthusiasm and a bubbling font of ideas is a lot of fun and doubtless a fine way to spend an afternoon, but if a GM is concerned with actually creating playable, functional table content a little more preparation is in order.

First you need to think about your players and the scope of the campaign you want to build for them. Is this going to be a short campaign of tightly-linked episodic adventures, or do you want to build a big, sprawling sandbox for them to explore for months or years on end? Is the campaign meant to focus on the skulduggery and politics of a single vast hive-city and its ruined environs, or do you expect the heroes to be roaming from adventure to adventure over the whole of a kingdom?

Players being who they are, your expectations might be wrong. That short run of linked adventures could suddenly arc off into the wild unknown after the party gets fascinated by some peripheral hook you didn't realize you were feeding them. The roving freebooters might enjoy a particular decadent city so much that they spend a dozen sessions conquering its myriad mad oligarch-guildmasters. It's okay to revise your plans when the situation has clearly changed, but at the start, you need to pick a scope and build to fit it.

This basic scope is your touchstone. Everything you build, plan, or create should relate to this scope in some way and preferably be associated with some kind of adventure-worthy content or situation. Maybe the

Athavian Empire has ten million war-saints who slay with edged words and murderous pity, but if the empire has no reason to impinge on your campaign scope, it's not an efficient use of your energy to spend much time elaborating their nation.

Once you have the basic scope set, you create your **backdrop**. The backdrop for your campaign amounts to all the world facts that need to be established to give meaningful context to play. The backdrop is built in multiple layers, starting from global facts about the world itself down to details of the specific adventure location the PCs will find themselves in at the start of the campaign. The more remote a given layer is from your scope, the less work you need to put into defining it and detailing its features.

If you're working on a completely new world, you may honestly not know any of the details about it. You might have a basic idea for a theme and a scope for your campaign, like "Island-hopping pirate-wizards" or "Decadent political maneuvering in an underground city", but you have no idea what these islands might be like or what the name of the underground city is. By working from the top down on your backdrop, you build a framework and a context for your campaign that helps you answer important questions like these.

THE GOLDEN RULE OF PREPARATION

In all of these pages, there is a single abiding rule you should follow in preparing your campaign. It is absolutely imperative that you understand it and that you apply it to your own work, or you run the risk of exhausting yourself and your creative powers long before you finish the content you need for a fun, relaxing night of play.

Whenever you are building something, you need to ask yourself two questions.

Am I having fun building this? If yes, you can keep going. You need to make sure you cover material you need for your next adventure session, but if you're having a good time then it's okay to indulge yourself. If the answer is "no" or "maybe", however, you need to ask yourself a second question.

Am I going to need this for the next play session? Will you need this specific content for your next gaming night? Don't ask yourself if it could be potentially useful, or if it's something you'll need in the future. Ask yourself if this piece of work is going to be necessary for what you expect of the very next session of play. If you can't answer yes with confidence, *put it down*.

It is painfully easy for a GM to exhaust their powers on minutiae or peripheral details that aren't fun to make and don't get any useful play time. All of us are limited mortal creatures with finite amounts of time, energy, and focus. We can't afford to spend it on trifles when there is more important and more satisfying work to be done. Instead, focus on what you need and what you enjoy.

BUILDING YOUR BACKDROP

Backdrops are created at several different levels. As the GM, you work top-to-bottom, letting the facts you establish at one level inspire and mold the facts you establish at lower levels. At no point do you put more work into defining or characterizing a level than your actual campaign scope requires, unless you're consciously doing so for the sake of enjoyment rather than efficiency.

Each level has certain questions and generation procedures associated with it. You don't need to give final answers to these questions, but you should be ready to make at least provisional decisions from which you can fashion lower, finer levels of detail. If you're using an established setting for your campaign, a lot of these questions might already be answered in the novels or fiction you're drawing on.

THE WORLD

At this level you're establishing some basic global facts about your campaign world. This "world" might be literal; if you're playing in an Iterum of the Latter Earth, the facts you establish here might be related to the Latter Earth itself. Conversely, you might be running a campaign about dimension-shifting refugees fleeing some cosmic pursuer, in which case your "world" might be the overall framework of dimensions and cosmic mechanics for your campaign. This layer of the backdrop is usually the most distant from a campaign's scope, and so needs the least prep.

Many GMs love making world maps for the campaign settings, or establishing different grand empires on far-flung continents, or writing cosmic histories for their world known only to the sagely. These activities can be fun worldbuilding indulgences, but the great majority of them have no meaningful bearing on the campaigns that they'll actually be running in that world. The coastline of England means nothing to a campaign set in 340 BC China, and the entire Tang Empire is no more consequential in Anglo-Saxon England than the silk embroidery on a bishop's best cloak. To give such distant glories names and a sentence or two of description is as much as any world-level backdrop likely needs, and often more than it requires.

At this level, the GM should establish any noticeable and drastic deviations from real-life physics or daily life. If there are two moons, or if the surface never knows night, or if water flows uphill as a general rule, then this is the level to establish those facts. Even in this case, however, these deviations should only be recorded when they're something the PCs should be expected to notice immediately. The world may be hollow and full of divine clockwork, but if that fact isn't widely known or doesn't have any particular effect on the chosen scope of the campaign, then it's not worth spelling it out beforehand.

Here are some basic questions to answer about the world level of your backdrop.

- ***What's the name of this world for people in your campaign's scope?*** Other people might have different names for it, but you need some kind of label to stick on your creation.
- ***Are natural physical laws mostly the same as in our world?*** If there are multiple moons, a lack of stars, a great crystal dome over a flat earth, or some other obvious global novelty of reality, you need to decide on it at this point because the PCs will likely know about it as a societal commonplace.
- ***Are there any spirit-worlds, alternate dimensions, novel planes of existence, or other cosmological locales generally associated with the world?*** Don't worry about gods just yet, but think about whether there are any heavens or hells or Crawling Darks that the natives of this world would likely know about. Of course, some such alternate planes might be established later in the backdrop creation as secrets known only to sages or sinister priests.
- ***Are there any grand global-scale empires or groups that impinge on the campaign's scope?*** If so, give them a name and two sentences of description at this point. If you can't give them a useful shorthand description in two sentences, then their concept is too vague; tighten it and try again.
- ***How interconnected are the parts of your world?*** Is it easy to move from one region to another? Do the natives know a lot about their more distant neighbors?
- ***Are there any vast global events that have happened recently?*** You can use the history tables on page 136 as inspiration if you wish, but this is the part where you identify any world-spanning catastrophes or dramatic universal changes that have happened in the relatively recent past. Leave distant history alone for now.

It can be tempting to add gods and religious faiths at this level of backdrop creation, but it's generally better to save that work for the regional level, or even the kingdom level. Some settings actually do have a set number of universal deities that are honored and worshiped worldwide under assorted names and guises, but most worlds will have faiths specific to particular regions and cultures. The divine patron of one kingdom might be unknown in a neighboring region, or have no more than a few petty shrines.

Once you've answered these general questions about your world, you're ready to step down to the next level of backdrop creation.



THE REGION

This level covers the cluster of nations or civilizations most relevant to the intended scope of the campaign. The nations, tribal groups, marauders, and faiths of the people in this region are likely to have an impact on the campaign scope, so it gets more attention and more carefully-drawn detail than the broader world. You should only worry about detailing one region at first, the one most pertinent to your campaign scope. If that scope shifts, then you can concern yourself with a different one.

One danger to watch out for at this level is that of excessive detailing. GMs and players both have a limit on the amount of detail they can constructively manage in a campaign setting. Just because you write it down doesn't mean you remember it in play or that the players will bother to read the handout about it. As such, you have to restrict your detailing at this and lower levels to those facts and situations that are most likely to produce interesting, playable content.

Remember also that this limit on attention applies to your entire campaign setting. You can't draw up a meticulously-detailed region and then focus down on a meticulously-detailed kingdom and expect your players to remember or engage with all the facts on both levels. You have a limited budget of things that will matter to them, one varying with the interest and engagement of the players, and every call you make on their attention will eat up some of that budget.

If you're working with an existing setting, it's relatively easy to draw the lines around a region. Mark the outline so that it includes about a half-dozen important nations, organizations, or other groups. These groups might have relations with nations outside the region, and external actors might sweep in from time to time, but most of the time these participants will be dealing with each other and creating the situations that are most likely to affect the PCs.

If you're starting with a blank slate, however, it can be difficult to generate a workable region. Follow the steps below to flesh out something usable.

Name the region. Decide what the locals call the general area. Perhaps the name is derived from ancient myth, a major cultural group, a particular significant geographical feature, or a former governing entity. Giving the region a name will help you keep things straight in the case that you need to create multiple regions to accommodate a shift of PC adventuring.

Choose about six major geographical features. The section on page 120 can give suggestions, but for this step you want to pick out the mountain ranges, great forests, huge rivers, steep plateaus, volcanic Hell-gates, blasted *arratu* wastelands and other major features for the region. You don't need to place them precisely just yet, but you should have a vague idea about their locations.

Create six nations or groups of importance. A few more or less is fine, but don't try to pack a score of major players into the same region unless you have the copious free time necessary to track their doings. At this stage, all

you need is a name and a few sentences of description for each. You can use the section on page 124 for inspiration, but don't worry about fine details yet.

Identify regionally-significant gods. Many kingdoms and groups will have their own favorite deities, but if there are any gods honored throughout the entire region, define them now. The tables starting on page 140 provide tools for this. Remember that just because two nations worship the same god, it doesn't mean that they necessarily like each other. Most faiths despise heretics far more than they do mere unbelievers, and two churches with similar-but-not-identical ideas about the same god can hate each other with a fiery passion.

Make a sketch map of the region. Don't try to get it perfect at this stage unless you're doing it purely for fun. All you need is a crude map showing where the nations are in relation to each other as explained in the section starting on page 120. Use rivers and mountain ranges as convenient border markers, while forests, swamps, deserts, and other trackless zones can make for disputed frontiers. Don't forget to mark in plenty of unclaimed wilderness, dangerous wasteland, and other "blank space" that can serve as a playground for nefarious evils, lost cities, and ambitious heroes.

Assign two important historical events to each group or nation. The tables on page 138 give example historical events. These events might be very recent, in which case the region is probably still dealing with them, or they might be some remotely distant event that was somehow critically important to the group's development or current state. Try to connect the different groups via these historical events; use their neighbors as either antagonists, victims, or associates in the events. You might add even more events to each if you want to develop a fleshed-out timeline, but such deep historical work is best saved for a lower level of the backdrop.

Define the relationships between the groups. For each one, decide what they generally think about the others and pick something specific they want from them. One kingdom might have a claim on land taken from it in a long-distant war, while an ambitious faith might be trying to get a major temple built in an otherwise-unreceptive nation's capital. No group should simply "be there". Every one of them needs to be wanting something or doing something that could spark adventures.

Optionally, assign each group faction statistics. The *Factions* chapter starting on page 322 gives the rules for interactions between major groups and organizations. You can use these rules to run between-session events among the major players in the region, and use the results either as adventure hook grist or as background color to help give the region a lively feeling. You may want to restrict the initial number of factions to the three or four most pertinent to your scope, however; many GMs can have a hard time running more than a half-dozen factions between sessions, and new ones might pop up as the PCs establish their own forces or new NPC groups suddenly become relevant.

THE KINGDOM

Once you have the general region sketched in, it's time to take it to a still lower level. The kingdom level of your backdrop covers the nation or tribal region that best includes your adventure scope. This is the first level that's likely to include facts and details that matter to your very first session of play, so the amount of creative work you put into this single kingdom is roughly the same as you just put into an entire region.

"Kingdom" should not be taken literally. This broad scope might apply to a grand metropolis that's expected to absorb the first dozen adventures, or a raw frontier dotted with hardscrabble settlements and ancient ruins, or a particular stretch of *arratu* where the barbaric PCs were born and raised. It's the worldbuilding box that your campaign's initial stages will take place in.

In the end, your entire campaign might well remain in this single zone, if the PCs decide that their interests lie here as well. You may continue developing and adding on to this kingdom for the full length of the campaign. Conversely, your heroes may light out for parts unknown after the first few sessions, obliging you to generate another kingdom-level backdrop wherever they end up. As always, focus your prep work on what you expect to need for your next gaming session.

When building your kingdom-level backdrop, start with some basic steps.

Pick a linguistic touchstone and give your kingdom or area a name. This language is likely the tongue of the current or historical dominant group in the region. Conventional fantasy names tend to be random nonsense-syllables picked from the creator's cultural phoneme stock, and places often end up as the city of AdjectiveNoun or the NounNoun river. While some of this can work perfectly well, it's easier for the GM to pick some obscure or extinct real-world language known to nobody at the table and use it for names. Even if the words they use from it have no relation to what they're naming, the consistent set of sounds and syllable patterns will help give a coherent feel to the work.

Flesh out its history. You already have an event or two related to it that you generated at the regional level. Now take those same tables and add three or four more events. These historical circumstances might've been localized to specific areas of the kingdom, or they might have been nation-wide happenings. It's not necessary to have a year-by-year timeline of the past, but a half-dozen solid events can help inform the kingdom's current state.

Decide how it is ruled and identify the ruler. The zone might be a patchwork of city-states or a single unified monarchy, but now's the time to decide those details. Give names and a sentence or two of definition to the rulers in the area, with the tables starting on page 132 providing some help.

Identify the enemies of the rulers. Maybe they're a usurper who seeks to claim the throne, maybe they're a sullen band of rebel peasants, or maybe they're a slowly-advancing army of Hell. Somebody wants to depose or destroy the rulers of the region, even if they're so subtle in their work that the public knows nothing of them. The conflict they create is eminently useful for a GM.

Choose one or more problems or goals it's facing. It may be that something is not working right in the region, and its inhabitants are being forced to deal with it or suffer the consequences. These problems might be restricted to particular regions, or they might be long-standing afflictions that have been woven into the culture, or they could be sudden eruptions that the leadership is not equipped to handle. These conflicts will help create adventure hooks in the area and give the leadership something to react to. The tables on page 135 can help.

Make a rough map of the area. This doesn't need to be any more precise than the scope of your game requires. If you plan on doing serious hexcrawling in the area, you might make a detailed hex map of the kingdom, while a looser, more point-hopping style of campaign might just sketch some outlines and mark points of interest. Make sure to identify neighboring nations or groups.

Place ethnic groups and demihumans. The kingdom might consist of a single monolithic ethnic group, with their own gods and customs evenly distributed throughout the land, or more than one group may exist in the area, with relationships that may be friendly or fraught. Demihuman enclaves likely exist at some distance from human settlements, the better to ensure their relative independence. These groups may use the same linguistic touchstone you picked when building the kingdom, or you might give them different languages.

Flesh out the society and style of the kingdom and its occupants. The section starting on page 128 can be used to give character to the zone. The resultant society you create might be equally shared by all the ethnic groups in the kingdom – whether they like it or not – or each group might vary in their own way. The key at this stage is to give enough flavor to the kingdom that you can confidently ad-lib facts and details associated with it, because there's no possible way to prepare everything you might need in advance.

Assign local gods and religious traditions. Once you have the societies and cultures largely fleshed out, you can put details to the god or gods they worship and identify any major religious power groups in the area. At this stage it can sometimes be helpful to plant a dead or lost god or two into the area, perhaps still venerated by hidden cults or bitter survivors. At least one deity should be thoroughly malevolent or unsympathetic if you mean to make much use of evil cults or sinister high priests in your campaign.



GEOGRAPHY CONSTRUCTION

Almost everyone loves a good fantasy map. A well-drawn map has more than purely artistic charms; the names and borders and carefully-sketched wilds all evoke possibilities in the viewer's head and invite thoughts about the kind of adventures that could be had in such a land. A place feels more real for having been mapped, and the verisimilitude of a campaign setting is greatly improved by being established in cartography.

But as a working GM, your needs are a little different. A beautiful, artistically-done map is a wonderful thing, but very few GMs have the skills to execute such a project or the time to create it even if they did. When thinking about the physical construction of your world, it's important to start with the essentials and save the elaborations for afterwards.

CAMPAIGN MAP ESSENTIALS

You need two maps at the start of your campaign: a map of the region most relevant to your campaign's backdrop, and a map of the kingdom-scale area in which your initial gaming sessions will occur. These two maps are going to be the most important when you're running through the other creation tools in this section, because they'll tell you which of the major players are adjacent to each other and show you where ruins, wildernesses, conflicts and problems are most likely to be found.

If you're playing in a fantasy-land sandbox the region might be a two hundred mile square chunk of terrain holding the various fantastic nations and organizations you picked as major players during the backdrop's creation as described on page 118. If you're running an urban campaign focused on a single massive city, the "region" might be a particular zone of the megalopolis. If you're doing an alt-history campaign set in 1033 AD, the region might simply be western Europe.

The kingdom-scale map should simply cover the specific nation or culture-zone where the first adventures of your campaign will take place. If you plan on starting the heroes in Neue Gruzland, then you want a map of Neue Gruzland. If they're working out of a keep on the untamed borderlands, then you want a map of the borderlands and its savage wilderness. Megacity campaigns might flesh out a single slum area within the greater city-zone. The region-scale map will tell you where the players could end up going and what they might find there. The kingdom-scale map will tell you what they find during their very first few sessions.

Note the distinct absence of any need for a global or continental map. You don't actually have to establish any details whatsoever about what the rest of the world looks like unless it's a fun bit of recreation for you. A few sentences of suggestive prose about the Enigmatic South or the Unknown North is plenty, especially since very few realms will have anything resembling reliable maps available to the PCs.

MAKING THE REGIONAL MAP

Your beginning campaign maps should consist of nothing but loose scrawls and crude symbols. Indeed, many campaigns can make it through their entire run without creating any map more elaborate than a rough relational scribble. Hex-crawling campaigns and groups that like firm cartographic certainties can build out their initial maps later, but to start with, take a blank sheet of paper and focus purely on mapping basic relationships.

First, decide how many sides of the regional map will be oceanic. One or two makes for a curving coastline or a peninsula or land bridge that extends off two edges of the map. Three makes for a self-contained peninsula, and four means that the region is an island. It's generally wisest to have at least one side be a sea, or else you severely hobble your opportunities for piracy, nautical adventures or sea travel to distant regions.

Second, use the tables in this section to generate a half-dozen or so significant geographic features. Space them out on the map, keeping in mind the notes as to which features shouldn't go closely together. Of course, magic or Outsider manipulation might subvert that expectation, but if that's the case, make it clear that it's so. These features should be scaled to the size of the region; a mountain range might extend for a hundred miles in a large regional map, but a small map might have plausible room only for a stretch of rugged hills with a few mountain-worthy peaks.

Note that most regions will be small enough that the climatic variation is likely to be minimal. The polar-ward portions might be colder than the more equatorial side of the map, but a few hundred miles is unlikely to have comfortable room for both steaming jungles and barren glacial wastes. If you get table results that suggest a geographic impossibility, either convert the result to its local-climate equivalent or come up with some magical or geographical explanation for why it really makes sense. Warm ocean currents, geothermal heat wells, sorcerous curses, and berserk Outsider xenoforming engines are always handy rationales.

Third, sketch in 1d4+2 major rivers. Rivers make excellent borders for the nations you're going to be planting in this region. Barring sorcery, rivers will start in mountains or highlands and flow down to the sea or until they vanish into a lake, bog, or other sink. Rivers can split into tributaries and sub-branches, but these tributaries do not join together again; once the river splits, it can only split further, though multiple mountain-fed rivers might join on the lowest path to the sea. Across flat land the river will tend to meander, while streams that come down from a height will usually cut straighter from the force of the flow. Any given river should probably be no longer than a quarter of the maximum dimension of your map, though it might twist and wind within that length.

Optionally, add one to three significant lakes or inland sea areas to the map. These bodies of water can be particularly useful in giving “conjoining borders” to nations that would otherwise be entirely separated from each other. Each body of water should have at least one river flowing into it, but only one at most flowing out of it.

Fourth, place your nations, important tribal groups, major organizations, or other significant players you’ve decided will play a role in this region. Nations and tribal lands should be largely coterminous with natural barriers such as rivers, mountain ranges, deep forests, impassable swamps, or other easily-defended terrain. If the borders extend beyond these barriers, it’s probably the result of successful warfare and a cause for future battles.

National borders probably include significant regions of marginal or uninhabitable land. Sun-blasted deserts, mephitic bogs, cursed *arratu* wastelands, or jaggedly perilous peaks might all be well within a nation’s borders without actually having any locals to respect the nation’s laws. This is perfectly acceptable, and a good source of adventuring grist when the heroes quest into the unmapped wilderness or fight back the hideous evils that burst forth from it.

If these badlands extend across a border, they probably are a source of regular tension as raiders or monsters emerge to scourge a nation before fleeing back into the wastes. Expeditions to control or punish them can easily become forces of invasion, and both nations might want to bring the land entirely within their borders to better have a free hand in repressing its dangers.

Don’t worry about placing cities, ruins, or other points of interest on the map just yet. You’ll do that as necessary when you flesh out the kingdom. Also, don’t concern yourself with turning this rough sketch into a “proper” map just yet. You only need it to inform you of the basic spatial relationship between things in your campaign backdrop.

MAKING THE KINGDOM MAP

Now take the chunk of your region that will contain your campaign’s initial adventures and start with a new sheet of paper. Scrawl out the rough edges of the borders, filling up the whole sheet with the outline of your starting nation. Copy in any major terrain features from the regional map that happen to obtrude into the kingdom.

At this point, you basically repeat the regional creation process on a smaller scale. You roll for terrain features, add rivers, mark out provincial or cultural borders within the nation, and finish by placing cities, trade routes, and other features as explained in the nation generation tables starting on page 124.

For small kingdoms, it can be useful to roll a single time on the terrain feature table or take a single obtruding regional terrain feature and then riff off of it for the general landscape of the kingdom. If you roll “light forest”, then maybe the entire kingdom is lightly forested, with other terrain types being spice. It can sometimes be illogical for a sixty-mile-wide stretch of land to somehow

d20

Significant Terrain Features

- 1 **Ancient farmland.** A huge stretch of land was re-engineered for optimal farming.
- 2 **Arratu wasteland.** An area here was once xenoformed by the Outsiders into an environment hostile to humanity or one inhabited by dangerous alien lifeforms.
- 3 **Blasted lands.** Radioactive or scorched over by ancient war. Many ruins are likely.
- 4 **Canyons.** A region with extensive canyons cut by rivers present or long-vanished. Make sure the rivers don’t climb after leaving them.
- 5 **Dense forest.** Trackless, dark, and an effective natural barrier.
- 6 **Grasslands.** A broad sweep of savanna or grassy plains is a coherent whole here.
- 7 **Islands.** There’s a single significant island off the coast or an archipelago of some note.
- 8 **Jagged mountains.** A new or re-sharpened mountain range forms a barrier in the region. The mountains are young, tall, and likely cast a substantial rain shadow.
- 9 **Jungle.** A classic adventure-worthy jungle of wild, semi-alien flora and fauna.
- 10 **Light forest.** Interspersed with other terrain.
- 11 **Megaplex.** The ruins of a single huge ancient structure stretch for endless miles.
- 12 **Pit.** A Deep or some other underground megastructure collapsed and left a hole with a diameter measured in tens of miles.
- 13 **Rain forest.** Vast, damp, and green.
- 14 **Rocky hills.** Rough and stony, with little arable land. Herding and raiding are the most profitable employments here.
- 15 **Rolling hills.** A stretch of gently rolling hills makes for good agricultural land.
- 16 **Sand desert.** This desert is a waste of sand and dunes. It may be from a rain shadow, or it might be a legacy of ancient war.
- 17 **Scrub desert.** These often appear on the leeward side of mountain ranges. Borders will often be grasslands or savanna.
- 18 **Swamp.** A sinking river, lake margin, or wet coastal delta forms a vast bog in this flat land.
- 19 **Volcano.** One or more mountains in a nearby range are volcanically active. This may be natural or it may be a consequence of Legacy flux or ancient manipulation.
- 20 **Weathered mountains.** A significant skirt of hills is common. The rain shadow is likely limited due to the rounded, low mountains.





contain both rain forests and scrub deserts simply because you rolled those to results on the table. In the same fashion, you can use this main terrain type to modulate the results you do get, so that the scrub desert you roll in your jungle kingdom is actually a stretch of barren land due to the exposure of naked, infertile bedrock.

Naturally, the rivers and terrain features you roll at the stage will be of significantly smaller scale than the ones you rolled for the region. A “volcano” result that was a stretch of seismically-active mountains on the regional map might be a single ominous peak in the kingdom, and the rivers and lakes rolled here might be modest bodies of water too small to bear marking on a regional-scale map.

Every terrain feature you roll will have its effect on the local inhabitants, however. Swamps will have swamp-dwelling fishers, grassy plains will encourage farmers, hills will often have mining activity or jealously independent herders, and so forth. These people will usually be different from those dwelling in the surrounding land, either consciously so as a self-separated minority, or different by virtue of their practical living requirements. PCs who go to mountains will tend to find mountaineers, and even if they speak the same language and have the same lord as the plains-dwellers their lives will inevitably be shaped by the different terrain they occupy.

REFINING THE MAPS

What you have now is perfectly adequate for an initial session. If you need to establish specifics of distances and position as part of the first adventure’s play, you can do so on a case-by-case basis, and some groups may never particularly care about the details of distances beyond knowing how many days it takes to get to wherever they want to go.

Some campaigns need tighter details, however, such as hexcrawl exploration campaigns that focus heavily on scouting and mapping an unknown land. For those cases, it’s best to use a digital tool such as Hexographer to make a usable map at whatever scale is most convenient. A six-mile hex is a popular choice, as it’s large enough to hold multiple points of interest but small enough to reasonably contain only one major type of terrain.

Artistic and handsomely-done maps of kingdoms or regions or continents should be left as exercises in creative enjoyment and recreation rather than necessary campaign prep. A simple hex map provides all the information needed to adjudicate the vast majority of travel or distance questions, and even the most art-incapable GM can stitch one together with the online tools available.

ONE-ROLL TERRAIN FEATURE DETAILS

It can be difficult to add spice to your sixth mountain range; there are only so many ways to enliven a forest, a desert, or a pile of rocks before the creative springs run dry. As a supplementary tool, you can roll one die of each type and reference the tables below to add more detailing and character to a given terrain feature.

It's assumed that the terrain feature is meant to be a place of adventure and profit, so the table's results are canted towards dangerous, enigmatic places. It's assumed the bucolic breadbasket regions of your campaign aren't in need of particularly exciting features.

A suitably inaccessible region can end up becoming a "borderland" zone even in the heart of a developed kingdom. Bandit kings, monstrous hordes, and other grist for adventure can thus be placed almost anywhere.

d6 How Dangerous is the Feature?

- 1 Safer than usual for someplace like it
- 2 There's one notable kind of danger there
- 3 It's got some site-specific flavors of peril
- 4 It's unusually dangerous in several ways
- 5 It will quickly kill the unprepared or unwary
- 6 It's a death zone for all but the strongest

d8 What Use is the Feature?

- 1 A rare and precious resource is found there
- 2 Ancient sites and relics are common there
- 3 It's sacred land to a group or religion
- 4 Controlling it has military significance
- 5 It has substantial productive infrastructure
- 6 A major trade route goes through it
- 7 Uncontrolled, it's a nest of raiders and worse
- 8 A mighty Working is still functioning there

d10 What Kind of Event Last Happened There?

- 1 A significant battle was fought there
- 2 A mad prophet tried to start a faith there
- 3 A usurper and supporters fled into it
- 4 A resource strike drew numerous people
- 5 A major nest of bandits or raiders formed
- 6 A rich ancient ruin was discovered there
- 7 An uncanny plague erupted in the area
- 8 Some grim and terrible thing was awoken
- 9 A community of outcasts or marginals formed
- 10 A natural or uncanny disaster struck there

d4 How Populated is the Feature?

- 1 Almost unpopulated for something like it
- 2 Very few settlers or workers there
- 3 Average or more population density
- 4 A rush of people have gone there

d12 What Antagonists are Common There?

- 1 Violent secessionist rebels
- 2 Angry cultists of a local faith
- 3 Locals who resent interloping outsiders
- 4 A type of cunning, dangerous beast
- 5 Relic-creatures of ancient settlements
- 6 Elemental emanations of the disordered land
- 7 A hostile sentient monster civilization
- 8 Brutal envoys of the central government
- 9 Raiders and bandits driven into the area
- 10 Rapacious local lords and gang bosses
- 11 Remnants of a furious native population
- 12 Outsider remnants with a bitter grudge

d20 Optional Quirk of the Feature

- 1 It has significant magical structures in it
- 2 It has a place in the national origin legend
- 3 It is entirely man-made by ancient arts
- 4 Time and space sometimes slip there
- 5 The magical power there attracts wizards
- 6 It subtly changes those who live there
- 7 It's holy land to a particular faith
- 8 It was formerly a different kind of terrain
- 9 It has human-worked vistas of beauty
- 10 It was formerly an Outsider stronghold
- 11 A significant part of it is subterranean
- 12 It'd expand were it not for ancient wards
- 13 It was a nature preserve of a megastructure
- 14 It's maintained by an ancient artificial mind
- 15 Magic is somehow warped in its area
- 16 The flora and fauna are queasily "off"
- 17 The locals once populated it more heavily
- 18 Rulership of the feature is widely disputed
- 19 It's riddled with caves and delvings
- 20 A unique type of sentient lives there



NATION CONSTRUCTION

When following the guide on page 118, sometimes a little extra flavor or a few more specific details are needed for a nation. These pages offer some guidelines and examples. The disputes, positive ties, current problems, and present felicities suggested on the opposite page can be used to provide a hint about current national concerns, while the nation themes that follow might be used to color the societies that you place there. Beyond those random tables, there are also a few more material qualities to a nation that require a little more guidance to establish.

BORDERS

The borders for your nations should generally follow rivers, mountain ranges, trackless forests, and other major geographic barriers. Borders that run through clear, easily-traversed terrain are likely to be points of friction with greedy neighbors and hotbeds of cross-border banditry.

Deserts, *arratu* wastelands, deep swamps, and other difficult terrain might nominally be inside a nation's borders, but they may have little or no practical control over such desolations. Lands and titles often await heroes who can make the nation's claim more than mere words.

POPULATION

Population density in the Latter Earth is skewed both by the perilous *arratu* and the occasional pocket of ultra-dense habitation made possible by ancient sorceries or still-functional Workings.

For a general baseline population for a relatively low-tech, low-magic land of unremarkable prosperity, you can assume 60 people per square mile of non-wilderness, or 2,000 per six-mile hex. You can get a tolerable approximation just by multiplying the nation's longest width and length dimensions by sixty and adjusting that according to what seems sensible.

URBANIZATION

For most nations of the Latter Earth, at least ninety percent of the population will be rural. They will live in small villages of a few hundred people, if not fewer, with the occasional somewhat-larger market town. The more productive the agriculture of the nation, the greater the percentage that will be able to live an urban life.

For most nations, begin by taking ten percent of the population as city-dwellers. A third will live in the capital or chief city. Of the rest, a quarter will live in the second largest city, while the remnants will be roughly divided up among as many cities as you wish to place. A city in most nations qualifies as any settlement with more than two or three thousand people.

Thus, if you have a nation of a hundred miles square and 600,000 people, 20,000 would live in the capital, 10,000 would live in the second largest city, and the remaining 30,000 urbanites would be split up into as many as ten minor cities and major market towns.

CITY PLACEMENT

Put the nation's capital in the central region of the map or the richest farming terrain, unless there's a particular reason why the borders expanded rapidly in a particular direction. Locate it on a river or seacoast, because any city of its size will require constant food imports that would be prohibitively difficult to haul overland.

Now, starting from a random cardinal direction, start placing the remaining cities, working clockwise. Place them on rivers and other bodies of water. If you need to put one in the middle of a dry-looking region, assume that there's some small river there too minor to show up at the national map's scale.

When placing cities, put them near resource sites, good farmland, trade crossroads, or excellent ports. Most of these communities will have grown up around exploiting those resources. Urban centers without any obvious resource extraction probably serve as trade hubs, industrial centers, military strongholds, or religious centers.

To characterize each city, you can use a pair of Community Tags as described on page 152. If you need to flesh out the dynamics of their ruling institution, you can use a pair of Court Tags from the same section.

MARKING WASTELANDS

A land with no empty spaces and no regions of dubious law is lacking certain charms to adventurers. When building a nation, you'll want to know where to place forbidding ancient ruins, desolate lost cities, rabid bandit kings, and hard-bitten frontier settlers.

Look at your map and the cities you've placed. Identify the most likely routes of travel or trade between them. In all probability, the connections are by water when possible, and overland only when there are no canals or navigable waterways connecting them.

The resulting mesh will have holes in it, zones of land distant from any major travel route. These are the best places to put ancient ruins, *arratu* badlands, trackless forests, war-torn provinces, and other areas suitable for adventure. Note these zones down for later, even if you haven't made up any ruins yet or haven't decided exactly what desolate wastelands exist there.

These are certainly not the only places you can put your wastelands and ruins, but if you put them closer to the cities or directly on a trade route between them, you'll need to explain why the locals haven't already plundered the lost cities, or why they're insisting on sending a major caravan route through the middle of an *arratu*. There may be a perfectly good reason for either of those situations, but you'll need to think of one. It may be that the former trade route was recently blocked, or the ruin has already been reputed to be plundered, or the traders have some bargain with the Blighted tribes that roam the badlands that lets them pass with relative safety.

d20 Disputes With a Neighboring State

- 1 Raiders are taking refuge in their lands
- 2 Ownership of a resource site is disputed
- 3 A usurper or criminal is being sheltered there
- 4 A troublemaking religion is based there
- 5 Their rulers have a political claim on the throne
- 6 A diplomatic marriage is going sour
- 7 A past war's savagery has left deep scars
- 8 Their culture is supplanting local beliefs
- 9 Their immigrants are gaining great influence
- 10 They broke off an alliance or important pact
- 11 They lured away an academy or great temple
- 12 Border tariffs and taxes are blocking trade
- 13 They drove a terrible beast into this land
- 14 A Working of theirs caused problems here
- 15 They woke up a great peril from the past
- 16 They're cooperating with an enemy group
- 17 They're suspected of backing assassinations
- 18 A spy ring is suspected or has been found
- 19 They refused to give aid for some current need
- 20 They've been hostile to an allied group

d20 Current National Problems

- 1 Farmland is becoming worn-out and depleted
- 2 Verminous monsters are swarming
- 3 A rebel front is stirring up trouble
- 4 An outside power is backing internal strife
- 5 The leadership is inept and distracted
- 6 A religious reformer is breaking old compacts
- 7 An evil is provoking outraged rioting
- 8 Dark cults are attracting the ambitious
- 9 A Blighted horde is threatening the borders
- 10 An ancient ruin has disgorged some peril
- 11 Malcontents have obtained a potent artifact
- 12 Luxuriance has left the nation's coffers bare
- 13 Local aristocrats are pushing for independence
- 14 An important mine has run out or been harmed
- 15 A sinister favorite has infatuated the leader
- 16 A recurring plant plague is causing hunger
- 17 Fearsome monsters are migrating into the land
- 18 A rival is preparing for war or raiding
- 19 A grand national plan is exhausting the people
- 20 A savage grudge has erupted between lords

d20 Positive Ties With a Neighboring State

- 1 The ruling classes are related in some way
- 2 An important faith crosses the border
- 3 They fought by our side sometime in the past
- 4 Their culture is widely admired here
- 5 They helped to overcome an eldritch peril
- 6 They held back an enemy from our border
- 7 They are co-ethnics of the same origins
- 8 They provide critical trade relations
- 9 Sages and scholars came from there
- 10 They gave critical aid during a disaster
- 11 A hero of this land came originally from there
- 12 A past hero-king once ruled both lands
- 13 They produce some vital commodity
- 14 They have a shared enemy
- 15 A Working they have is helpful here, too
- 16 A long-standing alliance or trade pact exists
- 17 They recently conceded some disputed land
- 18 They greatly admire elements of this culture
- 19 They're considered unusually attractive here
- 20 They took in refugees from here at one point

d20 Good Things Happening Right Now

- 1 A splendid mine or resource has been found
- 2 A pious saint is strengthening a major faith
- 3 A noble heir shows signs of heroic greatness
- 4 A major rival has recently suffered a calamity
- 5 New farmland has been opened up recently
- 6 A new trade route has been forged
- 7 A horrible monster was slain or driven off
- 8 Good harvests have enriched the people
- 9 A wicked minister has been deposed
- 10 A new academy has recently opened
- 11 A bandit or rebel uprising has been crushed
- 12 Two rival lords have started to make peace
- 13 An old enemy has agreed to a peace pact
- 14 The military won a recent smashing victory
- 15 A helpful Working has been activated
- 16 A powerful artifact is helping the ruler
- 17 An old source of unrest has been calmed
- 18 A dark cult has been revealed and purged
- 19 New diplomatic ties have been made
- 20 A new lord has risen, loved by his people



EXAMPLE NATION THEMES

The themes here offer some suggestions for nation traits that might make for good adventuring grist. The adjacent table is organized in two groups; you can roll 1d10 to get a largely negative thematic trait or 1d10+10 to get a more positive quality.

Whether positive or negative, remember that the themes of the nation should be related to actual playable content. A seemingly idyllic land with traits of Justice and Pageantry might be splendid in many ways, but something about those qualities should cause problems or conflicts that adventuring PCs could become embroiled in. If you feel stumped at a prospect, think about the consequences of taking a virtue too far, or applying a virtuous trait in the wrong way.

Barbarism: The nation is brutally assailed by bestial, primitive forces, whether from external enemies or internal divisions. Naked violence, cruelty, ignorance, and hatred are always near the surface of things, either as threats pressing on the familiar or as instincts and habits among the natives.

Decadence: The nation is voluptuously cruel, indulgent, and indifferent to the prices it pays for its pleasures. Unspeakable debaucheries and sordid delights are in common circulation, and few ever think to question the appropriateness of inflicting brutal evils in order to obtain some elevated enjoyment or refined pleasure. The PCs are regularly exposed to the consequences of such indulgences and the damage they inflict on others.

Despair: The nation is redolent of hopelessness and apathetic submission to fate. It may be because some overwhelming evil seems inevitably due to pass, or because all prior efforts at improvement have brought only worse suffering, or because some bright cultural hope or golden age is now clearly lost and ruined forever. The nation will tend to accept evils and sufferings as inevitable, and the natives will do little to rebel, resist, or defy their unhappy fates.

Enlightenment: A genuine love of knowledge imbues the nation, such that academies and schools have an important role in social and political life and a good education is considered a hallmark of gentility. The populace has a genuine curiosity and zest for investigation, and finding the truth of things is considered more important than secure stability.

Exhaustion: The nation is depleted of something critical, whether that is a tangible resource or their spiritual reserves of enthusiasm and hope. Everything is tired in this nation, with spent rivers, barren fields, cut-over forests, and shorn hillsides. If material resources are sufficient, the natives simply don't have the energy or enthusiasm to bring in more than they presently do, perhaps out of a sense that nothing good can come of any putative improvement.

d20 Thematic Element

1	Barbarism , with brutal savagery
2	Decadence , of sins and fadings
3	Despair , with good things unlooked-for
4	Exhaustion , with strength spent and lost
5	Ignorance , of terrors and the unknown
6	Oppression , with rule a crushing weight
7	Poverty , where even the rich are poor
8	Precarity , with all goods made fleeting
9	Stratification , where classes do not touch
10	Violence , where life is something cheap
11	Enlightenment , where knowledge is loved
12	Expansion , where things swell greater
13	Hope , that the future should be better
14	Justice , where a reckoning is had
15	Legitimacy , where rulers are by right
16	Pageantry , of splendor and magnificence
17	Prosperity , with wealth easily had
18	Renewal , with things growing brighter
19	Triumph , with victory a fresh memory
20	Unity , where purposes are shared

Expansion: The nation's borders are expanding, either through successful conquest, peaceful assimilation of bordermarches, or the seductive appeal of their values and culture. The society is vigorous and confident, assured of the justification of their expansion and of the good it will provide to everyone deserving of good. There's usually some truth to this, albeit perhaps less than the expansionists would like to admit.

Hope: The nation is imbued with a sense of hope and potential, the promise of a better day to come and a brighter future for those who win through their present problems. There may have been a recent discovery of some great trove of resources, some magical or technological innovation that promises great results, or the rise of a beloved house of seemingly-blessed rulers.

Ignorance: The nation is an ignorant one, redolent of (incorrect) superstition, false gods, blundering institutions, and erroneous beliefs of all kinds. These beliefs are somehow critical to the setting's culture or society, such that being rid of them would cause some profound, potentially bloody disruption of life. Life in this nation can go on as it does only so long as the ignorance remains unilluminated, and the vast majority of its populace would rather remain in error than exist in chaos.

Justice: One or more powers or institutions in the nation have a genuine concern for justice and righteousness, such that the society's laws and values are fairly and even-handedly enforced. These laws may not perfectly match modern conceptions of justice, but what exists is meant to be applied evenly. Righteous crusaders for the cause, honest magistrates, and some great struggle to enforce justice on a widely-understood wrong might all be present.

Legitimacy: The nation's rulers or controlling institutions have a profound degree of legitimacy among the populace, such that it's hard to imagine ever overthrowing them as a group. Individuals among them might be criminals or incompetents, but the structures as a whole are accepted as necessary and eternal by most elements of the society. This legitimacy may derive from divine mandates, personal prowess, honored lineages, or a terror of the chaos that would exist without them.

Oppression: Some substantial portion of the nation is cruelly oppressed by some force. It's rare that this is the same group in all areas of the nation; oppression as a key theme to the setting implies that many groups in many places suffer under this, and it may be accepted as a commonplace that one group or another needs to be harshly repressed if the rest of society is to prosper. Oppressive groups will usually have a clearly-enunciated philosophy of why this state of affairs is necessary, and it usually will have at least some coloring of justification to have persisted as it has.

Pageantry: The nation is marked by dramatic displays, magnificent architecture, sweeping demonstrations of might, and large-scale undertakings for the glory or edification of the rulers and populace. The locals tend to place great store by such ritual displays, finding them inspiring, meaningful, and important in more than strictly material ways. These grandiose efforts actually have real results towards unification, inspiration, and societal harmony.

Poverty: The nation is poor. Even aristocrats might not be assured of the necessary staples of life, or basic resources might be constantly threatened by monsters, warfare, calamities, or simple dearth. The struggle for resources and the basic necessities for survival are apt to drive numerous conflicts in the setting, and the consequences of failure can be far worse than mere discomfort for the losers.

Precarity: Whatever good the nation has is under immediate siege by circumstances, and it looks very likely that it might crumble. Something is happening in the setting to make old verities and assured societal institutions totter, whether a massive monstrous invasion or a revolt by some displeased underclass. These institutions will tend to strike out violently at threats, fearing that their basic existence is at stake, and the recklessness of their responses might be the very catalyst that provokes their eventual collapse.

Prosperity: The nation is relatively rich, such that conventional scourges of famine, privation, and desperation aren't nearly as common as they would be in other cultures. Pockets of genuine want may exist, but the average commoner leads a well-fed, well-clothed life and the grandees have the resources for impressive displays of wealth. This prosperity may be the fruit of unusual natural resources, exceptional societal harmony, magical blessings, or simple good climate.

Renewal: A spirit of reformation and renewal breathes through the nation, with old noble houses rising once again, decayed religions being reformed, corrupt institutions being shaken, and the populace generally more insistent on improvement. This renewal could be a harkening back to the old ideals of yore or an appeal to some new innovation, and the subjects could just as easily be a royal house recalled from exile as a new republic's establishment.

Stratification: The nation draws harsh lines between social classes, cultural groups, regions, sexes, or some other distinction between people. Castes and aristocracies are a common feature of these settings, ones drawn sharply by blood or birth circumstances. Adventurers are apt to be wild cards in these societies due to their ability to obtain outsized personal power, and they may regularly run into conflicts or complications that they have the strength to deal with, but not the social permission.

Triumph: Something wonderful has recently been accomplished in the nation; a dark lord defeated, an evil king overthrown, a plague ended, a natural disaster overcome, or the like. The setting is touched with a sense of success and victory, despite the costs of that triumph, and filled with a confidence in its own power and potential. There will be many new institutions and groups seeking to exploit the aftermath and earn their rightful share of the rewards.

Unity: Powers and groups within the nation are highly united in their goals and sense of fellow-feeling. While not necessarily xenophobic, they will tend to value their brethren more than strangers, and paper over internal conflicts and disagreements that might fester into civil disorder or chaos in less harmonious societies. These societies might have been shaped by some all-consuming peril that forced them together or a culture that greatly prizes unity.

Violence: The nation is a bloody one, with human life held cheap and death a commonplace. This may be the result of incessant warfare, such that most people half-expect to die in battle, or it may be the product of a society that simply doesn't value people's lives. Death may be a penalty for comparatively trivial sins, or the environment might just be so dangerous that a death in bed is a thing unlooked-for by most.



SOCIETY CONSTRUCTION

A nation is the product of its society. While you can easily sketch the borders of a particular fantastic domain on a map, the more difficult part of the process is thinking about the kind of people who live there. The things they value and the way they organize their lives will have inevitable consequences when thinking about their government, their conflicts, and their ambitions.

This section allows you to roll up a society to inhabit the nations you've made. Some nations may be mono-ethnic, with a single dominant group and no meaningful pockets of any other ethnicity. Others may have more than one significant group within their borders, either as a legacy of shifting boundaries, ancient conquest, migration, or an old division in an existing people.

For now, just create one society for your nation and take it as the dominant group. If your history generation or your own plans suggest the need for an additional group, you can come back and build it out, placing it within the context of the majority's culture.

Note that the same society can exist in multiple nations. One might have been a colony of the other, or exiles from a lost conflict, or pioneers who pushed the border out and then demanded the right of independent rule. There may be pockets of the group as minorities in distant lands, and it's often convenient to use already-extant

societies as candidates when your worldbuilding needs a minority pocket within some empire or vast kingdom.

Some societies may not be based on ethnic groupings at all. While the tables here presume that the members of a society share some overarching physical relationship, cultures based on ideology, religion, or historical chance might have many different bloodlines and ethnic groups mingled together. Membership in such a society might be contingent on agreeing to intellectual principles shared by the group, or joining with them in some overarching faith that is considered much more important than mere lineage. Of course, rebels against these principles can find themselves exiled or isolated, lacking any other ties with their former comrades.

The societies you generate with these tables may or may not be sympathetic to your own sensibilities, but you should have a good idea of how the party is likely to react to them. If you generate a society that believes in ritual kitten defenestration and ceremonial puppy-based sadism, you can't expect to use them as anything but villains with most parties. You may need to blur the uglier qualities of some groups or emphasize the virtues of others to make them into a more neutral society. Even so, don't be surprised if your party draws unexpected conclusions about how willing they are to work for a particular group.

MAKING PLAYABLE SOCIETIES

Every society needs to be built to serve the creator's purpose. For recreational worldbuilders, that purpose might be one of building the most "realistic", verisimilitudinous culture possible in a Barkerian opus of world building. For working GMs, the purpose is often much more modest and much more pragmatic.

This means you need to be ready to embrace assumptions and commonplaces. If your society violates the ordinary expectations of real life history or social organization, there has to be some kind of immediate payoff to it in adventure possibilities or play streamlining. Exoticism for exoticism's sake just makes more work for you at the table.

When you build the organization and cultural stylings of a society, start with the most basic, ordinary, commonplace expressions of your choices or random table results. If the roll says the society is based on dynastic houses, then start with a medieval-fantasy-standard collection of noble houses. If it says the society values martial might, then haul in schoolboy-simple echoes of Sparta or viking raiders. If it takes more than two sentences to reference how that part of the society works to a listener, you're making it too esoteric.

Only afterwards, once you have a simple, navigable, *playable* framework should you go back and start weirding it up or adding unique fantasy aspects or

elements to your society. Maybe the dynastic houses are each blessed by feuding immortal saints. Maybe the violent raiders need human blood to empower an ancient magical gift. You can add these fantastical flourishes *after* you have a playable society built.

Almost every one of these flourishes should be attached to adventure hooks or societal conflicts that the PCs can get involved in. A marvelous weirdness that means nothing to the PCs' play is something they'll look at, admire, and then forget it exists because it doesn't matter to them. The truly satisfying weird societies are the ones where the strangeness is the direct fuel for the adventure session.

This basic framework also helps a GM deal with the inevitable awkward questions and unexpected angles that always crop up during play. The PCs may suddenly ask about some facet of the society the GM hasn't thought out, or make some assumption about local laws or values that may or may not be true. By starting from a basic framework the GM can fall back on those ordinary assumptions to fill in the blanks that they haven't personally scripted out.

These default assumptions may not fit perfectly, but they're quick to produce and playable at the table. Such qualities are ultimately worth a lot more in play than a perfect reply that takes a day to formulate.

PHYSICAL APPEARANCES

A GM usually needs some idea of what the average member of a society looks like. The tables on this page provide some suggestions and possibilities for GMs who don't already have a clear visual aesthetic in mind.

These tables take into account the innumerable eons of sorcerous alteration, genetic manipulation, intermarriage, and alien aesthetic preferences that have gone on in the Latter Earth. The combinations may not map well to any real-life group, largely because all the real-life groups that presently exist have long since gone extinct.

In addition, it's not remarkable for certain groups of humans to have unusual physical additions or traits as an inheritance from some prior age's manipulations. So long as their cognition is similar to that of their neighbors, all but the most hostile usually count them as humans.

d8 Typical Skin Colors in the Populace

- | | |
|---|---------------------------------------|
| 1 | Extremely dark hues |
| 2 | Dark browns and mocha shades |
| 3 | Golden, sallow, or ivory |
| 4 | Olives or light browns |
| 5 | Ruddy or tanned complexions |
| 6 | Pale white or pinkish hues |
| 7 | An unusual color or pattern of colors |
| 8 | Scales, fur, or unusual hide type |

d8 Hair Color Hair Texture

- | | | |
|---|----------------------|---------------------|
| 1 | Night-black | Very tightly-curved |
| 2 | Dark browns | Dense and curled |
| 3 | Lighter browns | Slightly wavy |
| 4 | Red shades | Stiff and straight |
| 5 | Blonds | Thick and wavy |
| 6 | White or white-blond | Thin and fine |
| 7 | An unusual palette | Thick and flowing |
| 8 | They lack hair | Scant and delicate |

d8 Eye Coloration

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | Black or extremely dark brown |
| 2 | Hazel or olive |
| 3 | Blues in varying shades |
| 4 | Grays, whether flat or metallic |
| 5 | Ambers and yellows |
| 6 | Greens in different shades |
| 7 | An unusual or luminous color |
| 8 | Slit or unusual pupils; roll again for color |

d4 What's the Typical Build of the People?

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1 | Smaller and slighter than their neighbors |
| 2 | Same height and weight as the neighbors |
| 3 | Either short and stocky or tall and slender |
| 4 | Much bigger and bulkier than neighbors |

d12 Optional Common Forms of Adornment

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | Intricate hair styles or braiding |
| 2 | Painted skin markings that sometimes change |
| 3 | Tattoos of some cultural significance |
| 4 | Piercings, whether minor or elaborate |
| 5 | Role or class-specific clothing items |
| 6 | Patterned hair shaving or depilation |
| 7 | Culturally-significant jewelry or accessories |
| 8 | Color choices with social meaning to them |
| 9 | Socially-meaningful animal motif items |
| 10 | Worn weapons, tools or trade implements |
| 11 | Significant scent or perfume uses |
| 12 | Impractical or elaborate role-based clothes |

d20 Optional Physical Quirks or Traits

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | They possess an extra eye somewhere |
| 2 | An additional set of limbs or extremities |
| 3 | Extremely pronounced sexual dimorphism |
| 4 | Patches of feathers, scales, fur, or the like |
| 5 | They have a tail of some sort |
| 6 | They possess wings, whether useful or not |
| 7 | Their skin is an unusual texture |
| 8 | Sigil-marked by their creator in some way |
| 9 | The sexes look very similar to outsiders |
| 10 | They have a particular scent to them |
| 11 | Their voices are peculiar in some way |
| 12 | Additional or too few fingers or toes |
| 13 | They have animalistic features in some way |
| 14 | Have one or more manipulatory tentacles |
| 15 | They have light-emitting organs or skin |
| 16 | Their mouths are fanged or tusked |
| 17 | They have alien Outsider features somehow |
| 18 | Their proportions are distinctly strange |
| 19 | They don't show age the way others do |
| 20 | Roll twice and blend the results |



VALUES OF THE SOCIETY

Societies will tend to esteem certain values, holding them as emblematic of their people or specially blessed by their gods. Institutions will honor these values, folk heroes will act in ways to further them, and the rightness of decisions will be judged on how well they conform to these virtues.

These special virtues are not the only qualities the society values, of course. Even the most individualistic society will value some degree of order and civic peace, while the most violent warrior cultures can still understand the need for some periods of enforced calm. Yet when these values clash with other principles, the society will generally choose their favorites to prevail.

From the GM's perspective, you can use these principles to generate adventure hooks and problems within the society. Just take the virtue too far, or make a favored vice a cause for significant civic troubles.

The table below can help you generate two or three traits the society values. Conversely, you could use the table to find those qualities the society especially hates or considers contemptible.

It's easy for a GM to come up with unsympathetic societies with these tables or from their own campaign needs. If you need an antagonistic nation of slavery-loving ritual cannibals for your setting it's not likely that the players are going to find the natives particularly appealing in their habits or moral values.

For some tables, it's fine to leave it at that. The players want to put steel into slavers and not have to think carefully about it. The society is an evil one and it gets what it deserves. If the natives are Blighted or non-humans they might actually be every bit as intrinsically malevolent and wicked as their society implies.

If you're building a human society with unsympathetic values, however, you may want to think more carefully about how human traits such as compassion, familial love, loyalty, delight in beauty, and other positive qualities manifest. The natives have explanations for their beliefs that satisfy them and account for their own experiences. Even in a society of cannibal slavers, there will be beloved children, bonds of friendship and respect, and other positive human relationships. Don't make the natives into caricatures unless caricatures are wanted.

d100	Values They Esteem	d100	Values They Esteem
1–2	Individual rights and freedom of action	51–52	Personal sacrifice for one's causes or purposes
3–4	Courage and valiance in danger	53–54	Building things in service of their posterity
5–6	Honesty and truthfulness in speech	55–56	Faithfulness towards one's chosen friends
7–8	Eloquence and social expertise	57–58	Dominating and possessing other people
9–10	Raw strength and personal prowess	59–60	Exploring the unknown and discovering secrets
11–12	Discipline and obedience to the law	61–62	Seeking fortune in new places or new roles
13–14	Filial devotion to family and parents	63–64	Social progress toward some eventual utopia
15–16	Education and knowledge-seeking	65–66	Excellence in one's profession or trade
17–18	Piety and devotion to the gods	67–68	Loyalty to one's friends, family, and own
19–20	Beauty and seductive charm	69–70	Vengeance and execution of just vendettas
21–22	Conquest and domination of others	71–72	Restoring some real or imagined glorious past
23–24	Ascetic unworldliness and pious poverty	73–74	Unity and elimination of group differences
25–26	Harmony with nature and existing life	75–76	Magical prowess and occult ability
27–28	Ethnic purity of blood and culture	77–78	Sharing wealth and goods with others
29–30	Cunning and the ability to trick others	79–80	Membership in an elite bloodline or caste
31–32	Subtlety and indirectness of action	81–82	Personal indulgence and luxuriant pleasure
33–34	Prosperity and accruing material wealth	83–84	Scheming subtly against enemies or rivals
35–36	Submission to the collective will or culture	85–86	Remembrance of the past and memorializing history
37–38	Hardiness and endurance before woes	87–88	Aesthetic beauty in material goods and architecture
39–40	Honor and maintaining one's integrity	89–90	Zealous guardianship of their own land or holy sites
41–42	Sexual license and wantonness	91–92	Humanistic reason and "rational" religion
43–44	Submission to lawful authority	93–94	Industry and the ability to work tirelessly
45–46	Personal development and limit-pushing	95–96	Leadership and charisma in the group
47–48	Justice and fairness between people	97–98	Pacifism and peaceful resolution of problems
49–50	Purging evil and expelling the wicked	99–00	Societal or ethnic superiority over all outsiders

SOCIETAL ORGANIZATION

How is the society organized at the basic level? While the ties of blood are fundamental to almost all societies, the basic units of identity and cooperation don't always fall along nuclear family lines. In the far future of the Latter Earth, societies built on ideological or functional delineations are more common, as some human lineages have had their cognition and preferences adjusted to better suit their ancient manipulator's purposes. These modified humans can make functional societies that modern humanity could never find tolerable.

The adjacent table gives suggestions for major social groupings in the society. A given individual might consider several of these identities to be important to them; a man may be deeply committed to his family and children, but he might also see himself as a member of his caste or professional role, and fight on behalf of their interests as well as those of his immediate family.

For the GM, conflicts between these groups are an easy source of adventure grist. The government likely treats many of these groups as subjects for their policies and laws, and different groups probably vie to win control of the governmental apparatus. A powerful dynastic lineage might strive to keep control of a particular ministry, while a trade guild might jealously guard "their" senatorial seat.

SOCIETAL AESTHETICS

It's impossible for a GM to define everything about a culture that might conceivably become important during play. Small details of dress, architecture, the titles of officials, and other minutiae might suddenly become critical when the GM needs a particular fact at hand.

Rather than trying to formulate a heroically Barkerian level of detail for your society, the easiest workaround is to take an existing historical society as a template. Whenever you need an answer for a particular question, provide whatever answer roughly matches the way that the chosen template society did it.

Historical accuracy is completely unimportant, as the whole point of the exercise is to give you quick, relatively coherent answers rather than to correctly portray an existing real society. You may be generating a society of albino pacifists with three eyes that have a magocratic government divided into multiple fractious religion-based factions, but if they have an Aztec aesthetic then they build grand stone architecture, favor their clothing styles, and like erecting imposing religious monuments.

For some of the more esoteric cultures or societies on this list, you might need to do some background reading to pick up the necessary details. Such investigation of real-life cultures and history can be a fruitful source of inspiration for problems, adventures, and novelties in your own world.

d20	Major Unit of Social Identity
1	Extended family out to cousins and like kin
2	Religious factions or faith alliances
3	Regional and province-based identity
4	Ethnic membership
5	Professional guild or trade-specific group
6	Identity based on their local community
7	Educational ties to institutions or traditions
8	Patron-client relationships with major figures
9	Hereditary loyalty to a political group
10	Trade guilds specific to particular roles
11	Dynastic lineages with cadet branches
12	Lineages based on ancient hero-ancestors
13	Numerous castes of hereditary workers
14	Inheritance of an ancient body modification
15	Astrologically-determined birth groups
16	Warbands or civic military service groups
17	Voluntary mutual-assistance brotherhoods
18	Far-flung clans of affiliated families
19	Having or lacking noble blood
20	Ideological groups or philosophical sects

d20	Example Template Societies
1	Victorian England
2	Standard Medieval Fantasy Land
3	Spring and Autumn China
4	Pre-Columbian North American Tribes
5	Mali Empire
6	Unified Dynastic China
7	Imperial or Republican Rome
8	Greek City-States
9	Mongolian Steppe Nomads
10	Modern-day America
11	Renaissance Italy
12	Imperial Persia
13	Early Medieval Europe
14	Byzantine Empire
15	Incan Empire
16	Fantasy Viking Land
17	Sumerian or Assyrian Empire
18	Aztec Empire
19	Post-Islamic Arabia
20	Polynesian Islanders

